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LITERATURE IN ENGLISH • UPPER SIXTH | UPPER SIXTH — LITERATURE IN ENGLISH

CHAPTER 3

CHAP3: EMPHASIS ON TRUE TO LIFE HUMAN REPRESENTATIONS – CHARACTERS, CHARACTERISATION, ROLE PLAY...

SUGGESTED TIME: 56 PERIODS

IN THIS CHAPTER

This chapter completes the Upper Sixth study of the four prescribed genres — drama (A Raisin in the Sun, A Dance of the Forests), prose (Nineteen Eighty-Four, Anthills of the Savannah) and poetry (Chaucer's The Merchant's Tale) — with emphasis on true-to-life human representation: characters, characterisation, role play, themes, style and setting. It consolidates textual knowledge and builds systematic mastery of GCE Paper 1 and Paper 2 answering techniques through guided analysis and revision of past questions.

- By the end of this chapter I can analyse Walter Lee Younger's dilemma and the resolution of A Raisin in the Sun, relating character choices to theme and context.
- By the end of this chapter I can evaluate the themes, characterisation, plot, setting and literary devices of any prescribed drama text and answer GCE essay questions on them.
- By the end of this chapter I can discuss the ending of Nineteen Eighty-Four (Part 3, Chapters 5–6) and give a critical general overview of Orwell's dystopia.
- By the end of this chapter I can analyse the characters, plot movements, fabliau features, themes and literary devices of The Merchant's Tale, including its links with The General Prologue.
- By the end of this chapter I can situate Anthills of the Savannah within Achebe's biography and the historical-political framework of post-colonial African military rule.
- By the end of this chapter I can trace the plot of Anthills of the Savannah chapter by chapter, analysing friendship, betrayal, the press, censorship and the role of women.

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CHAPTER OBJECTIVES

- By the end of this chapter I can analyse Walter Lee Younger's dilemma and the resolution of A Raisin in the Sun, relating character choices to theme and context.
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- By the end of this chapter I can explain the structure of A Dance of the Forests — the gathering of tribes, the flashbacks, the trial, the dances and the open ending — and interpret its symbolism.
- By the end of this chapter I can compare characters and characterisation techniques across drama, prose and poetry, using role play and dramatic reading to deepen interpretation.
- By the end of this chapter I can interpret GCE question instructions (discuss, examine, comment, compare, assess) and plan, write and time-manage full essay and context answers.
- By the end of this chapter I can revise strategically using past GCE questions, mark-scheme expectations and self-assessment checklists.

PREREQUISITES

- Lower Sixth study of A Raisin in the Sun Acts 1–2 and of Nineteen Eighty-Four Parts 1–2
- Lower Sixth study of The General Prologue and the opening of The Merchant's Tale (January, the marriage debate)
- Knowledge of the three genres (drama, prose, poetry) and their basic elements: plot, character, theme, setting, style
- Basic literary terminology acquired in Lower Sixth: irony, symbolism, imagery, satire, flashback, foreshadowing, point of view
- GCE essay-writing conventions: introduction with thesis, developed paragraphs with textual evidence, conclusion

1 SECTION 1: A RAISIN IN THE SUN — ACT 3: WALTER'S DILEMMA AND THE RESOLUTION OF PRIDE

In a Bamenda neighbourhood, a family argues over whether the only son should use the family's savings to open a drinking spot or pay his sister's university fees; down the road, a radio station debates whether a journalist should be jailed for criticising a minister; and at a village festival, masquerades dance to 'judge' the living for the sins of their ancestors. These everyday Cameroonian scenes are exactly the worlds of Lorraine Hansberry's A Raisin in the Sun, Chinua Achebe's Anthills of the Savannah, Wole Soyinka's A Dance of the Forests, George Orwell's Nineteen Eighty-Four and Chaucer's The Merchant's Tale. Great literature does not invent strange people: it holds a mirror to true-to-life human beings — their dilemmas, pride, blindness, betrayals and resilience. This chapter trains you to read that mirror: to analyse characters, characterisation, role play and dramatic structure, and to convert that analysis into top-grade GCE Advanced Level answers.

Our first mirror is the Younger family of Chicago's Southside, and the sharpest image in that mirror is Act 3 of Hansberry's play, where Walter Lee Younger must decide what kind of man he is. The problem we shall solve in this section is the following: **how does Hansberry use Walter's dilemma and its resolution to transform a broken dreamer into a true-to-life portrait of dignity?**

1.1 Recap: The Road to Act 3

No analysis of Act 3 can succeed without a firm grasp of what has happened before. Let us reconstruct the situation briefly and precisely.

- **The insurance money.** The Younger family awaits a $10 000 life-insurance cheque following the death of Big Walter, the father, who literally worked himself to death. The money is therefore not just cash: it is the father's sweat converted into paper, and every character reads it differently.
- **The liquor store dream.** Walter Lee, the son, a chauffeur humiliated by serving rich white men, wants to invest the money in a liquor store with his friends Willy Harris and Bobo. For him, money is the only passport to manhood: "money is life," he tells Mama.
- **The house in Clybourne Park.** Mama (Lena) uses part of the money as a down payment on a house in Clybourne Park, a white neighbourhood, and entrusts the remaining $6 500 to Walter — $3 000 for Beneatha's medical studies, the rest for him to manage.
- **The betrayal.** Walter hands the entire sum to Willy Harris, who vanishes with it. The dream collapses; Beneatha's school fees are gone too.
- **Lindner's offer.** Mr Lindner, representing the Clybourne Park Improvement Association, has offered to buy the house back from the Youngers at a profit — a polite bribe to keep black people out of the neighbourhood.

KEY POINTS **The situation at the curtain of Act 3**

The money is stolen, the dream is dead, the house in Clybourne Park is still waiting — and Lindner's cheque is still on the table. Act 3 asks one question: will Walter sell the family's pride back to the people who despise them, or will he stand?

1.2 Act 3 Opens: Despair, Collapse and Bitterness

Act 3 opens about an hour after the catastrophe of Act 2. The stage directions describe a family in mourning without a corpse: Walter lies on his bed staring at nothing; Beneatha sits in open contempt of her brother. Hansberry's stage directions are crucial here — the lighting is gloomy, the mood funereal, and the family that once quarrelled with energy now quarrels with exhaustion.

Beneatha's bitterness is philosophically important. She declares that there is no longer anything to love in Walter: he is "no brother" of hers. Mama corrects her with one of the play's deepest lines, teaching that the true test of love is to love someone when he is at his lowest, not when he is admirable. This is Hansberry's thesis on family: love is not admiration; it is solidarity in failure.

Walter's collapse is total because his identity was entirely invested in the money. Having equated money with life, the loss of money feels to him like the loss of life itself. This is the psychological setup of the dilemma that follows.

1.3 Walter's Dilemma: The Moral and Psychological Stakes

DEFINITION **Dilemma**

A **dilemma** is a situation in which a character must choose between two equally weighty alternatives, each carrying a serious cost, so that the choice reveals the character's deepest values. In drama, the dilemma is the engine of the climax: the audience watches not what happens but who the character becomes through choosing.

Walter's dilemma in Act 3 is brutally simple:

- **Option A — Accept Lindner's money.** Walter telephones Lindner and invites him back, planning to perform the role of the humble, grinning black man and take the buy-out. Financially, this recovers something. Morally, it means agreeing that his family is not fit to live beside white people — it means selling Big Walter's legacy and the family's dignity.
- **Option B — Refuse and move.** Refusing keeps the family's pride but guarantees struggle: Clybourne Park will be hostile, money is gone, and the future is uncertain.

The psychological stake is Walter's manhood. Throughout the play he has defined manhood as money and power. Act 3 forces him to discover that manhood is actually responsibility and self-respect. The dilemma is therefore not really about money; it is about which definition of a man Walter will enact — and he must enact it in front of his son.

1.4 Asagai and Beneatha: The Parallel Awakening

While Walter sinks, Beneatha receives a counter-offer of identity. Joseph Asagai, her Nigerian suitor, responds to her despair (her medical dream died with the stolen money) with a long, gentle speech. He mocks her dependence on other people's money — money that was never hers — and invites her to come home to Africa with him, to become a doctor there and to build something real after colonialism falls.

Asagai's proposal does three things:

1. It restores Beneatha's sense of purpose: medicine is possible again, but now rooted in African service rather than American ambition.
2. It restores her identity: Asagai names her "Alaiyo" — "One for Whom Bread Is Not Enough" — affirming that her restless questioning is a gift, not a defect.
3. It provides a foil to Walter: where Walter responds to loss with self-destruction, Asagai responds to colonial devastation with rebuilding. Hansberry sets the two responses side by side so the audience can judge.

WARNING **Common mistake**

Do not present Asagai as merely a "romantic option." In GCE essays, candidates who reduce him to a boyfriend miss his function: he is the ideological alternative to Walter's materialism and the play's bridge between African-Americans and Africa.

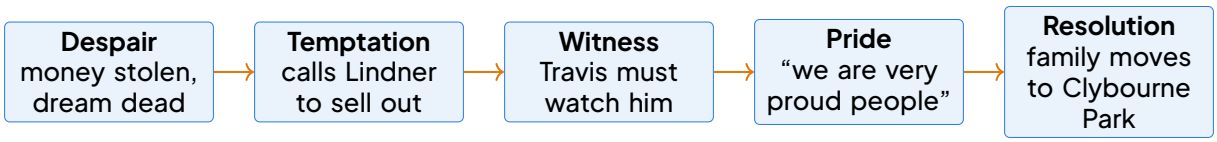
1.5 The Decision Scene: "We Are Very Proud People"

Lindner arrives, papers ready. Walter begins the performance he rehearsed — the shuffling, grateful Negro — and then stops. What stops him is the presence of his son **Travis**, whom Mama insists must stay and watch: she wants Walter to make his choice before the eyes of the next generation, exactly as Big Walter's choices were made before him.

Walter then delivers the play's turning point. He tells Lindner that his family are "very proud people," that his father earned that house almost brick by brick, and that they have decided to move into it. He acknowledges Lindner's offer — and declines it. Lindner, baffled, appeals to Mama and Ruth, but the family stands behind Walter, and he leaves defeated.

EXEMPLE **Analysing the transformation**

Notice the content of Walter's speech: he no longer talks about money at all. He talks about his father's labour, his sister's future as a doctor, and his son watching him. Hansberry signals the transformation by changing Walter's vocabulary — from "liquor store" and "deal" to "pride," "family," and "my son." In an essay, quoting this lexical shift is far stronger evidence than simply stating "Walter becomes mature."



Walter’s decision process in Act 3: each stage is a test, and the presence of Travis converts private temptation into public choice.

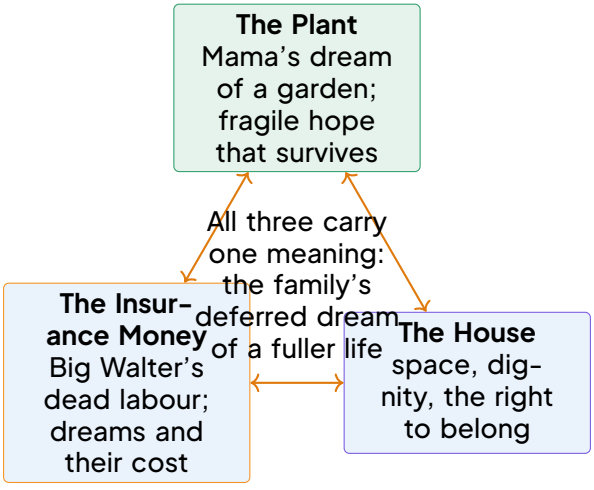
1.6 Resolution and Pride: Mama’s Plant and the Meaning of the Move

DEFINITION **Resolution (dénouement)**

The **resolution** or **dénouement** is the part of the plot in which the central conflicts are settled and the final meaning of the play emerges. It answers the question the climax raised: here, will the family move, and what will the move mean?

The play ends with the family leaving the cramped apartment for Clybourne Park. The last image is Mama returning to fetch her **plant** — the feeble, struggling little plant she has tended all through the play in a kitchen that never gets enough sunlight. She carries it out to plant it in real ground at last.

The move is deliberately not a fairy-tale triumph. Hansberry makes Ruth and Mama acknowledge that Clybourne Park will be hard: hostile neighbours, financial strain, Walter still without his dream job. What the family has won is not comfort but the right to struggle on their own terms. Mama’s earlier question — whether the family has finally come of age — is answered: they have, because they have chosen dignity over safety.



The symbolic triangle of the play: plant, insurance money and house are three carriers of a single meaning — the dream deferred and finally claimed.

1.7 Characterisation Techniques in Act 3

Hansberry's portrait of Walter is built with the dramatist's full toolkit:

- **Dialogue.** Walter's speech to Lindner is the climax of his verbal arc: the slangy hustler's talk of earlier acts gives way to measured, grave sentences. Beneatha's sarcasm and Mama's proverbial wisdom ("There is always something left to love") mark their distinct voices.
- **Stage directions.** Hansberry directs Walter's body as carefully as his words: the collapsed man on the bed, the rehearsed "performance" of humility, and finally the man who stands upright before Lindner. Movement is meaning on stage.
- **Symbolism.** The plant (dreams surviving in poor soil), light (the dark apartment versus the promised sunlight of the new house), and money (both opportunity and corruption) carry the themes physically.
- **Contrast and foil.** Asagai's hope against Walter's despair; Lindner's smiling racism against the family's open pride; Mama's faith against Beneatha's cynicism.
- **Role play within the play.** Walter literally rehearses a degrading "role" for Lindner — and refuses to perform it. Hansberry shows that dignity is partly the refusal of the roles others write for us.

METHOD **Tracing a character's transformation**

1. Identify the flaw. Walter equates manhood with money (quote: "money is life").
2. Locate the crisis. Willy's theft destroys the false identity (Act 2 ending).
3. Analyse the choice. Before Travis, Walter refuses Lindner (quote: "we are very proud people").
4. State the consequence. The family moves; Walter earns Mama's recognition that he has "come into his manhood."
5. Quote each stage. One short quotation per stage turns description into analysis — this is what earns top GCE marks.

WARNING **Do not oversimplify Walter**

Do not write that Walter simply "becomes good." His maturation is painful and ambiguous: he nearly commits the shameful act, he is saved partly by Mama's insistence that Travis watch, and his future remains uncertain. The GCE rewards candidates who show the process, not a magical conversion.

1.8 True-to-Life Representation: The Youngers as a Mirror

The Youngers are not idealised heroes; they are a working-class family drawn with documen-

tary honesty — cramped rooms, tired bodies, quarrels over money, generational conflict between Mama's faith and her children's modernity. This is why the play travels so well: a family in Bamenda, Buea or Douala arguing over savings, schooling and dignity recognises itself instantly. Hansberry's realism lies in showing that ordinary people facing ordinary pressures can produce extraordinary moral moments. Walter's stand before Lindner is great precisely because Walter is not great: he is flawed, foolish, selfish — and still capable of pride. That is what "true-to-life human representation" means, and it is the standard by which you should judge every character in this chapter, from Winston Smith to Chaucer's January to Achebe's Ikem.

WORKED EXAMPLE 1 **Worked GCE-style paragraph**

Question: "Walter's refusal of Lindner's offer is the true climax of A Raisin in the Sun." Discuss.

SOLUTION

Model paragraph: The climax of Hansberry's play is not the theft of the money but Walter's decision scene in Act 3, because it resolves the play's central conflict — the conflict between money and dignity. Walter enters the scene having equated the two: earlier he insists that "money is life," and his collapse after Willy's betrayal shows that his identity was entirely financial. Hansberry then stages the choice with deliberate theatrical pressure: Mama forces Travis to remain in the room, converting a private temptation into a public test before the next generation. Walter's refusal — his declaration that his family are "very proud people" — is therefore a redefinition of manhood, from the possession of money to the assumption of responsibility. The stage directions confirm the transformation: the man who was lying face-down in despair now stands upright and speaks for the whole family. The climax is moral rather than material: nothing external is gained, since the family still faces poverty and hostile neighbours, but everything internal is settled. Hansberry's realism lies precisely here — dignity is won without wealth, and the "dream deferred" does not dry up but is carried, like Mama's plant, into better soil.

DID YOU KNOW? **Exam tip — triumphant or merely hopeful?**

GCE questions on Act 3 frequently ask whether the ending is triumphant or merely hopeful. Argue both sides with evidence: triumphant, because Walter achieves manhood, the family unites, and Lindner is defeated; merely hopeful, because the money is gone, Clybourne Park is hostile, and no material problem is solved. The strongest answers conclude that Hansberry deliberately fuses the two: the family wins a moral victory whose practical cost is still to be paid — hope with its eyes open.

EXERCISE 1 **Practice**

1. Define dilemma and show, with two short quotations, how Walter's dilemma in Act 3 reveals his deepest values.
2. Explain the symbolic function of Mama's plant in the final scene. Why is it the last object to leave the apartment?
3. "Beneatha's storyline in Act 3 is a mirror of Walter's." Discuss with reference to Asagai's proposal.
4. Write a one-page essay plan answering: "The ending of A Raisin in the Sun is hopeful rather than triumphant." To what extent do you agree?

SOLUTION **Exercise 1 — guidance**

A dilemma is a choice between two equally weighty alternatives, each costly, which exposes a character's deepest values. Walter must choose between Lindner's buy-out (financial recovery at the price of self-respect) and refusal (dignity at the price of continued hardship). His earlier claim that "money is life" shows the value he begins with; his final declaration that the family are "very proud people" shows the value he ends with. The movement between the two quotations is the revelation the definition predicts.

KEY POINTS **Key points to remember**

- Act 3 turns on a dilemma: Lindner's money versus the family's pride, staged before Travis's eyes.
- Walter's transformation is shown through changed dialogue, stage directions and the refusal of a degrading "role."
- Asagai offers Beneatha the parallel path of identity and purpose — a foil to Walter's materialism.
- The resolution is realistic: pride is won, comfort is not; Mama's plant carries the dream into new soil.
- In GCE essays, trace transformation stage by stage and quote each stage; argue both "triumphant" and "hopeful" readings of the ending.

2 SECTION 2: A RAISIN IN THE SUN — CRITICAL SYNTHESIS: THEMES, DEVICES, CHARACTERISATION, PLOT, SETTING AND GCE TECHNIQUE

In Section 1 we followed Walter Lee Younger through the darkest hours of Act 3: the theft of the insurance money, the temptation to accept Lindner's offer, and the final decision to move into Clybourne Park because, as Walter tells Lindner, the family is made of "very plain people" who will nonetheless claim the house Big Walter earned "brick by brick." Now we step back from the single scene and look at the play as a whole, the way an examiner does. The GCE rarely asks "what happens in Act 3?"; it asks why Hansberry built the play as she did, and how her choices of theme, device, character, plot and setting produce meaning. This section gives you the complete critical toolkit for A Raisin in the Sun and the examination technique to deploy it.

2.1 Major Themes

A theme is not a topic; it is the judgement the play passes on a topic. Hansberry does not simply present "dreams"; she argues that deferred dreams deform the dreamer until dignity, not money, becomes the real measure of a life.

Dreams deferred. Every Younger carries a dream: Walter wants the liquor store and masculine self-respect; Beneatha wants to be a doctor and to find an identity; Mama wants a house with a garden; Ruth wants peace and a healthy home. The play's epigraph, Langston Hughes's poem Harlem ("What happens to a dream deferred? / Does it dry up / like a raisin in the sun?"), frames the whole action: the Youngers are the raisin, and the question is whether they will "dry up" or "explode." Walter's near-collapse in Act 3 is the explosion narrowly avoided.

Family and generational conflict. The play is a quarrel between generations about what survival means. Mama's generation endured; Walter's generation wants to advance; Beneatha's generation wants to redefine. Yet the conflicts never destroy the family, because love underlies every quarrel — Mama entrusts Walter with the remaining money precisely when she is most disappointed in him, telling him to be the head of the family from that moment.

Racial discrimination. Lindner and the Clybourne Park Improvement Association embody "polite" racism: no violence, only a cheque. Hansberry's insight is that discrimination in 1950s America worked through economics — housing, loans, jobs — as much as through open hatred.

Money and dignity. The insurance money is the play's engine, but Hansberry insists money is a means, never an end. Mama reminds Beneatha that for her generation, freedom "was life itself," while the younger generation talks only of money. Walter finally learns the lesson when he refuses Lindner.

Identity and heritage. Through Asagai and Beneatha, the play asks what it means to be African-American: assimilation (George Murchison's path) or reclamation of African roots (Asagai's path, symbolised by the Nigerian robes and Beneatha's natural hair).

The role of women. Mama, Ruth and Beneatha carry the family's emotional labour. Mama leads; Ruth endures (her pregnancy and her work in other people's kitchens); Beneatha rebels against being defined by marriage. Hansberry, writing in 1959, anticipates both the civil-rights and the feminist movements.

KEY POINTS **Themes at a glance**

Dreams deferred; family solidarity across generations; economic racism; money versus dignity; African identity versus assimilation; women's strength. For any essay, choose the two or three themes the question actually asks about — never list all six mechanically.

2.2 Literary Devices

Symbolism. Hansberry's realism is dense with symbols:

- Mama's plant: her stubborn, under-nourished dream of a garden and her care for her children; it is the last thing she retrieves at the end.
- Sunlight: the apartment has one small window through which the only natural light enters; light equals hope and space. Clybourne Park promises literal and social sunlight.
- Walter's eggs: Ruth's repeated "eat your eggs" reduces Walter's grand dreams to domestic routine — he complains that a man needs more than eggs, that he is a giant surrounded by ants.
- Beneatha's hair: cutting her straightened hair into a natural style declares her rejection of assimilation; George's mockery of it reveals his values.

Irony. The insurance money comes from Big Walter's death — the family can only advance because a man worked himself to death. Lindner's "welcoming committee" exists to keep the Youngers out. Walter, who despises "takers," nearly becomes one.

Foreshadowing. Ruth's early weariness and fainting anticipate the announcement of her pregnancy; the family's anxious waiting for the cheque prepares the conflict over its use; Walter's bitter talk of the world divided into "takers" and "tooken" anticipates both Willy's theft and Walter's own temptation to "take" Lindner's money.

Allusion. The title alludes to Hughes's Harlem; Asagai's nickname for Beneatha, Alaiyo — which he translates as "One for Whom Bread — Food — Is Not Enough" — alludes to the hunger for meaning beyond mere survival.

Realistic dialogue. Hansberry reproduces the rhythms of Black Chicago speech — Walter's slang, Mama's Southern idioms — so that social class is audible. Note how Walter's diction rises in dignity when he finally addresses Lindner as head of the family.

2.3 Characterisation of the Whole Cast

DEFINITION **Characterisation**

Characterisation is the set of techniques by which a dramatist builds a character in the audience's mind: what the character says (speech), what the character does (action), how the character appears (costume, posture), what others say about the character, and the playwright's stage directions. Direct presentation tells us what a character is; indirect

presentation shows us and lets us judge.

Mama (Lena Younger) is presented mostly through action and stage direction: her tending of the plant, her slapping Beneatha for denying God in her house, her quiet authority. She is the moral centre — faith, endurance, sacrifice — yet not perfect: she must learn to trust Walter with responsibility.

Walter Lee is built through speech and contrast: his soaring, repetitive dream-speeches against his slumped posture. He is a round, dynamic character — flawed (selfish, contemptuous of women) but capable of growth, which is why his Act 3 stand matters.

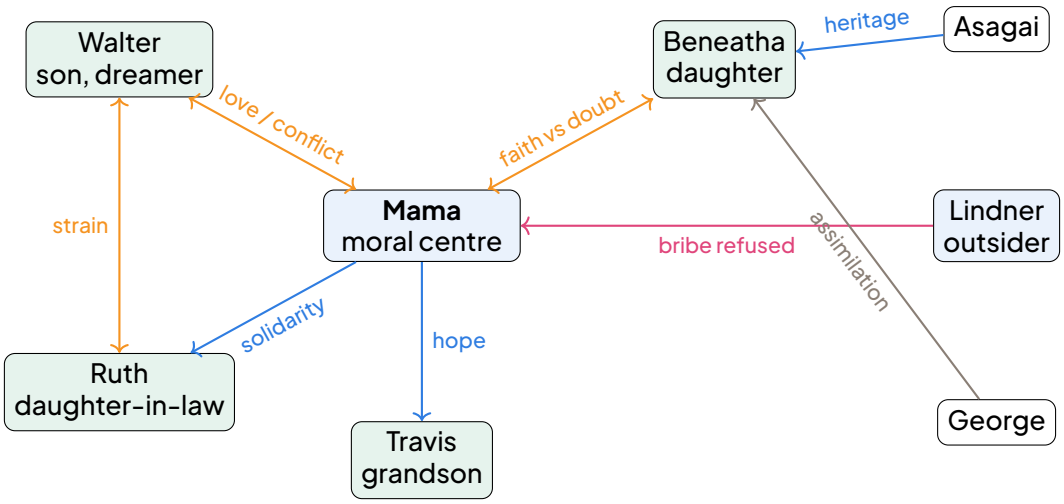
Ruth is characterised by weary routine (ironing, cooking eggs) and by what she suppresses: her consideration of abortion reveals a despair her quietness hides.

Beneatha is presented through intellectual speech and costume change (the Nigerian dress, the natural hair): searching, sharp-tongued, sometimes arrogant, genuinely idealistic.

Travis functions as the family's future — his sleeping on the sofa measures the apartment's inadequacy; his presence in the Lindner scene forces Walter to act honourably before his son.

Lindner is characterised by euphemism: his nervous, reasonable vocabulary ("our people," "the way we do things") shows how racism hides behind courtesy.

Asagai and George Murchison are foil characters: Asagai offers idealism and African identity; George offers money and assimilation. Beneatha's choice between them dramatises the identity theme.

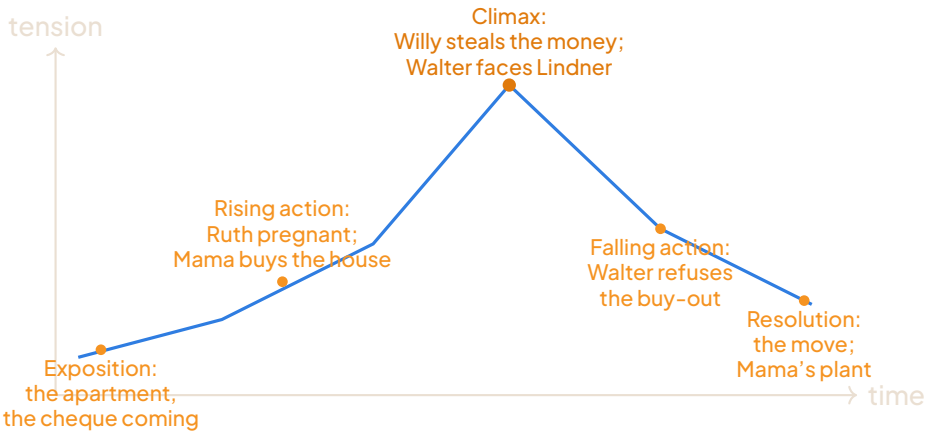


Character-relationship map centred on Mama: blue arrows mark solidarity, orange double arrows mark loving conflict, the pink arrow marks external racial pressure.

2.4 Plot Structure and Setting

The play obeys a near-classical unity: one room, one family, a few weeks. The single setting — a cramped Southside Chicago apartment in the 1950s, with a shared bathroom in the hall — is

both social document (overcrowded Black housing under segregation) and symbol (a space too small for the dreams inside it).



Freytag's pyramid applied to A Raisin in the Sun. Note that the climax is double: the external catastrophe (the theft) and the moral climax (Walter's decision).

WARNING **The most expensive mistake: retelling the story**

Narrating the plot earns almost no marks. Every sentence must serve the argument the question demands. If you write "Then Walter loses the money," ask yourself: what point does this prove? If none, delete it. Use plot events only as evidence inside an argument.

2.5 GCE Technique: From Question to Essay

METHOD **The PEEL paragraph**

1. Point: one argumentative sentence answering the question (e.g. "Hansberry uses Mama's plant to symbolise dreams that survive on almost nothing.").
2. Evidence: a short quotation or precise reference ("the plant, struggling in the one window's feeble light").
3. Explanation: show how the evidence proves the point — analyse language, stagecraft, context.
4. Link: return to the question's exact words and connect to your next paragraph.

A good GCE essay is five or six PEEL paragraphs framed by a brief introduction (interpret the question, state your line of argument) and a conclusion (synthesise, do not repeat).

Decoding command words. Discuss requires a balanced argument with a personal, justified

position; Examine/Analyse requires close attention to methods; Comment on the significance of requires you to link a scene or character to the whole play's meaning; Compare requires alternating treatment of both elements in every paragraph.

Planning in five minutes. Underline the command word and the key terms; jot three points; attach one quotation to each; order the points (strongest last); then write.

EXEMPLE **Exam tip: a quotation bank**

Memorise 8–10 short, versatile quotations per text and practise deploying them in different essay types. For this play: the Harlem epigraph; "eat your eggs"; "we are very plain people"; "brick by brick"; Mama on freedom being "life itself"; Asagai's "bread — food — is not enough"; Lindner's "our people." Each can serve essays on theme, character or technique.

2.6 Role Play: Performing the Lindner Scene

DEFINITION **Role play (pedagogical)**

Role play is a learning activity in which students assume a character's voice, posture and gestures in order to explore motivation and subtext — what the character means beneath what the character says.

EXPERIMENT **Testing interpretations through performance**

In groups of three, perform the second Lindner visit (Act 3). One student plays Lindner, one Walter, one observes. Perform the scene twice: first with Lindner played as openly contemptuous, then as genuinely nervous and self-deceiving. The observer notes which lines change meaning. Discuss: which reading better fits Hansberry's stage directions? Which makes Walter's refusal more heroic? This is exactly the kind of interpretive choice a GCE essay must argue for.

2.7 Worked Model Answer

WORKED EXAMPLE 2 **Model GCE essay (abridged)**

Question: "Mama, not Walter, is the true hero of A Raisin in the Sun." Discuss.
Plan: (1) Define heroism as moral growth, not mere centrality. (2) Mama's case: plant, house purchase, trust. (3) Walter's case: fall and Act 3 recovery. (4) Verdict: shared heroism, Walter's the greater arc.

SOLUTION

Introduction. Hansberry distributes heroism between two generations: Mama embodies an older heroism of endurance, Walter a newer heroism of self-mastery. The play's climax suggests the second completes the first.
Paragraph 1 (Point). Mama is the family's moral foundation. (Evidence) Her care for the "feeble" plant mirrors her care for her children, and her purchase of the Clybourne Park house converts Big Walter's death into the family's future. (Explanation) Hansberry presents her through action rather than speech, so that authority appears as habit, not rhetoric. (Link) Yet endurance alone cannot answer the question the play poses.
Paragraph 2 (Point). Walter, unlike Mama, must become heroic. (Evidence) Having lost the money and prepared to accept Lindner's offer, he finally declares that the family will move into the house his father earned "brick by brick." (Explanation) The presence of Travis turns the scene into an education in manhood; Walter's heroism is dramatic because it follows disgrace. (Link) Mama herself recognises this transfer of leadership when she tells Ruth that Walter "finally come into his manhood today," like "a rainbow after the rain."
Conclusion. Mama is the play's rock; Walter is its protagonist in the strict sense — the one who changes. Hansberry's answer to Hughes's question is that a dream deferred need not explode if dignity is recovered in time. The heroism is shared, but the arc — and therefore the dramatic hero — is Walter's.

EXERCISE 2 **Practice**

Answer in four PEEL paragraphs: "Examine the dramatic significance of the setting of A Raisin in the Sun." Begin by planning for five minutes exactly, and use at least three quotations from your quotation bank.

SOLUTION **Practice**

Strong answers treat the apartment as (1) social realism — overcrowded Southside housing under segregation, the shared bathroom, Travis on the sofa; (2) symbol — the single window and feeble light figuring deferred dreams; (3) dramatic engine — the pressure of space generating the conflicts over the cheque; and (4) contrast — the promised house with sunlight and a garden, making the resolution visible. Each point should be evidenced, explained and linked back to "dramatic significance," not merely described.

3 SECTION 3: NINETEEN EIGHTY-FOUR — PART 3, CHAPTERS 5–6 AND GENERAL OVERVIEW

In Section 2 we closed our study of A Raisin in the Sun by watching Walter Younger recover his dignity: threatened by poverty and racism, he finally refuses Lindner's money and chooses family pride over surrender. Hansberry leaves us with a human being who, though crushed, remains inwardly free. George Orwell's Nineteen Eighty-Four (published 1949) asks the terrifying opposite question: what happens when power does not merely threaten a man from outside, but invades his mind and rewrites it from within? In Part 3, Chapters 5 and 6, Orwell answers with the bleakest ending in twentieth-century fiction. This section studies those two chapters closely, then steps back for the **general overview** of the novel that the GCE frequently demands.

3.1 Part 3, Chapter 5: Room 101 — The Worst Thing in the World

From observation to understanding.

Imagine a man who fears snakes above everything else locked in a room full of snakes; imagine a claustrophobic man buried in a narrow box. Each of us carries a private terror so deep that, faced with it, we would do anything — including betraying the person we love most. Orwell's intuition is that a totalitarian state, which studies its citizens through total surveillance, knows each person's private terror and can weaponise it. This is the logic of **Room 101**.

DEFINITION **Room 101**

Room 101 is the place, deep inside the Ministry of Love, where the Party confronts each prisoner with his or her personal worst fear — "the worst thing in the world." Because the fear varies from individual to individual, Room 101 contains whatever each victim cannot endure. Its function is not to extract information or confession (those have already been obtained) but to complete the psychological destruction of the prisoner by forcing the ultimate betrayal of the self.

What happens in the chapter.

O'Brien tells Winston that everyone has something unbearable, something that cannot even be spoken of. For Winston, it is rats — a fear rooted in a childhood memory of a starving rat in the slum room where his mother and sister disappeared. A cage of starving rats is brought in; a mask-like device is fitted over Winston's face so that, at the release of a lever, the rats will attack his face and eyes. At the edge of madness, Winston understands that there is only one way to deflect the horror: to transfer it to another person. He screams that it should be done to Julia instead — "Do it to Julia! Not me!" — and means it with his whole being. At that instant the cage door is closed. The Party has won.

WARNING **The psychology of betrayal**

Do not reduce Room 101 to physical torture. Orwell's point is subtler and more fright-

ening: the Party does not want Winston's obedience — it already has that. It wants to destroy the inner loyalty that made him human. Earlier, Winston and Julia had promised each other that the Party could never make them stop loving each other, that "the inner heart" would remain inviolable. Room 101 proves them wrong. By making Winston genuinely wish the torture upon Julia, the Party breaks the last private bond. Love, the final refuge of freedom, is shown to be destructible. This is why O'Brien's victory is total: he has not silenced a rebel; he has unmade a lover.

3.2 Part 3, Chapter 6: The Chestnut Tree Café — "He Loved Big Brother"

The broken man.

Released, Winston spends his days in the Chestnut Tree Café, drinking the oily Victory Gin that the waiters bring without being asked. He is a hollow shell: fatter, greyer, his teeth partly gone, a varicose ulcer troubling him. The telescreen in the café never stops; he listens for the news of the war with the anxious devotion of a loyal citizen. He has a job on a sub-committee of a sub-committee — a sinecure, a meaningless post given to the purified.

Falsified memories.

Winston meets Julia once, briefly, in a park. Both confess that they betrayed each other; both feel nothing. The love that Part 2 celebrated is simply dead. More chillingly, Winston's own memory has become unreliable. He recalls a childhood scene of playing with his mother and sister, then dismisses it as a "false memory." The Party's conquest of the past, which he once resisted intellectually ("the past is unchangeable" was his heresy), is now accomplished inside his own skull. He traces in the dust on the table the old equation 2 + 2 = 5 — almost absent-mindedly, no longer as a lie he is forced to accept but as a thought that no longer troubles him.

The final horror.

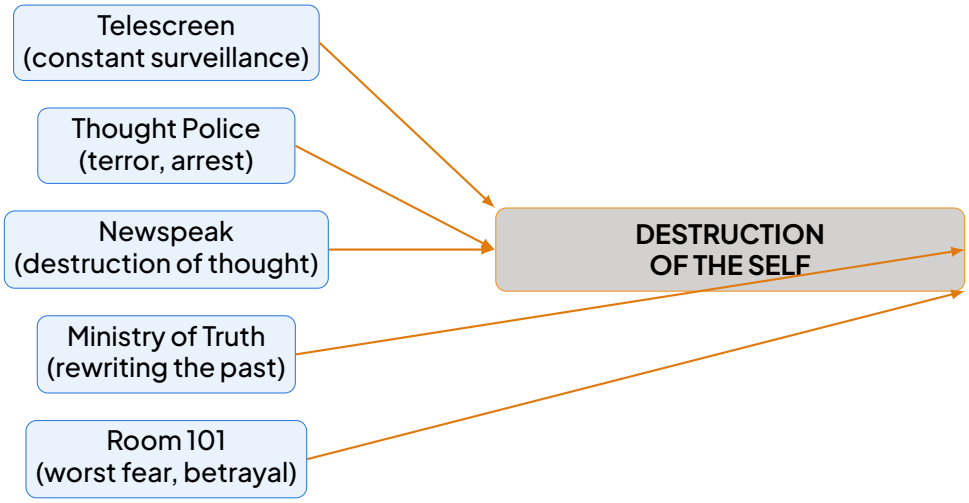
The novel ends as the telescreen announces a great victory. Winston gazes up at the enormous face of Big Brother and feels, at last, a pure and joyful devotion. The final sentence tells us that the long-hoped-for bullet was entering his brain — and that "he loved Big Brother."

KEY POINTS **Why the ending is the novel's darkest statement**

- The Party's aim, stated by O'Brien in Part 3, Chapter 3, is not to punish heresy but to convert the heretic: the prisoner must be made to love Big Brother before he is shot.
- The victory is therefore interior: the last private territory — thought, memory, love — is colonised.
- Winston's execution is almost incidental. The true death, the death of the self, has already occurred in Room 101.
- Orwell's warning: totalitarianism's ultimate ambition is not control of behaviour but annihilation of inner freedom.

3.3 The Party's Machinery of Control: A Synoptic View

To understand how Room 101 is possible, we must see it as the final instrument in an integrated machine of domination. Each organ of the Party attacks a different dimension of human life, and all converge on the destruction of the autonomous self.



The Party's machinery of control: five instruments converging on the annihilation of the autonomous individual.

- The **telescreen** abolishes privacy: every gesture and facial expression is watched, day and night.
- The **Thought Police** convert surveillance into terror: even a thought ("thoughtcrime") is punishable.
- **Newspeak** shrinks the language so that rebellious concepts become literally unthinkable.
- The **Ministry of Truth** rewrites newspapers and records so that the past always agrees with the Party's present line.
- **Room 101** finishes the work by breaking the last bond of love and loyalty.

3.4 General Overview of the Novel

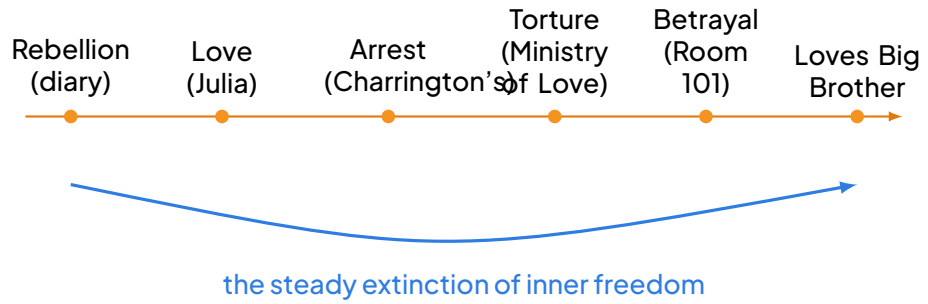
DEFINITION **Dystopia**

A **dystopia** is an imagined society characterised by oppression, dehumanisation and the crushing of the individual, presented by the author as a warning about tendencies already visible in the real world. It is the mirror-image of the utopia: where the utopia imagines the perfect society, the dystopia imagines the nightmarish one. Nineteen Eighty-Four, with Orwell's earlier Animal Farm, is the defining dystopia of the twentieth century, alongside works such as Aldous Huxley's Brave New World.

Plot summary and structure.

The novel is built in three parts, a structure that mirrors Winston's psychological journey:

Part	Content	Function
Part One	Winston Smith, a minor clerk at the Ministry of Truth in Oceania, secretly begins a diary, hates Big Brother, and dreams of rebellion.	Establishes the world of Oceania and the first stirrings of dissent.
Part Two	His love affair with Julia; their recruitment by O'Brien, who poses as a member of the underground Brotherhood; their arrest in the room above Charrington's shop.	Private rebellion through love; hope, then catastrophe.
Part Three	Imprisonment in the Ministry of Love; O'Brien revealed as Winston's torturer; interrogation, Room 101, release, and final conversion.	The systematic destruction and "cure" of the rebel.



Winston's arc: from secret rebellion to the love of Big Brother — a downward curve of the self.

Genre.

The novel is simultaneously a **dystopia**, a **political satire** of totalitarianism (Orwell had Stalin's Soviet Union and Hitler's Germany in mind), and a tragedy of the individual. Its famous appendix, "The Principles of Newspeak," extends the satire into linguistic philosophy and is an integral part of the text for GCE purposes.

Major themes revisited.

- **Totalitarianism**: power pursued for its own sake — O'Brien tells Winston the Party seeks power purely as an end, not as a means.
- **Surveillance**: the telescreen and the Thought Police make privacy, and therefore individuality, impossible.
- **Language and thought**: Newspeak embodies the thesis that to destroy a word is to destroy the idea it names.

- **Truth and history**: "Who controls the past controls the future; who controls the present controls the past." The mutability of records makes objective truth disappear.
- **Love and betrayal**: private love is the last form of rebellion, and Room 101 is designed precisely to kill it.
- **The proles**: Winston's hope that "if there is hope, it lies in the proles" remains ambiguous — the proles are free but unconscious, kept in poverty and distraction.

Characterisation overview.

- **Winston Smith**: the protagonist — a round character, introspective, physically frail, morally courageous but ultimately breakable; an ordinary man, not a conventional hero.
- **Julia**: pragmatic, sensual, rebellious from below rather than from ideology; round but deliberately limited — she falls asleep when Winston reads Goldstein's book.
- **O'Brien**: the intellectual face of the Party; round and terrifying, combining courtesy with absolute cruelty.
- **Big Brother**: possibly non-existent; a flat, symbolic figure — the manufactured image of power.
- **Parsons**: the flat, comic-horrific Party zealot, denounced by his own daughter.
- **Syme**: the flat intellectual who loves Newspeak and is vaporised precisely because he understands too much.

WARNING **Not mere science fiction**

A common mistake is to treat Nineteen Eighty-Four as a prediction about future technology. Orwell was not forecasting gadgets; he was satirising real mechanisms he had observed: propaganda, the rewriting of history, the cult of the leader, the corruption of language. The telescreen matters less than the habits of mind it creates. In the GCE, credit goes to candidates who discuss the novel as a warning about political method, not as fantasy.

DID YOU KNOW? **Orwell and our own world**

Orwell wrote the novel in 1948 and simply inverted the last two digits to name his future. Today, critics note how his insights illuminate debates about state propaganda, controlled media, and the manipulation of information — questions as relevant on the African continent as anywhere else. When a government monopolises radio and television, rewrites official history, or brands every critic an enemy of the nation, Orwell's Oceania stops looking like fiction. Quoting this relevance briefly and judiciously can earn enrichment marks in the GCE — but always anchor it in the text itself.

3.5 GCE Technique: Writing the "General Overview" Answer

METHOD **Structuring a general-overview essay**

1. Introduction: name author, date, genre (dystopia/political satire); state your line of argument.
2. Plot in miniature: four to six sentences maximum — the three-part arc from rebellion to conversion. Never retell at length.
3. Themes: select two or three, each illustrated by a precise episode (the diary, the Two Minutes Hate, Room 101, the Chestnut Tree Café).
4. Characterisation: show how Winston, Julia and O'Brien embody the novel's conflict between the individual and the Party.
5. Authorial purpose: conclude on Orwell's warning — the fragility of truth, language and love under total power.

Balance is everything: roughly one quarter plot, one quarter themes, one quarter characters, one quarter purpose and evaluation.

EXEMPLE **Exam tip — "Is Winston a hero?"**

This question recurs in various forms. Distinguish three categories:

- Hero: Winston is not one in the classical sense — he achieves nothing, converts no one, and is utterly defeated.
- Anti-hero: he is frail, thirty-nine, varicose-veined, often petty and self-deceiving — deliberately unheroic in physique and manner.
- The ordinary man as tragic figure: yet his desire for truth and love is heroic in context. Orwell's point is precisely that under totalitarianism even ordinary decency becomes a form of heroism — and even that heroism can be destroyed. A top-band answer argues that Winston is a tragic everyman: his defeat is the measure of the Party's evil, not of his weakness.

WORKED EXAMPLE 3 **Worked essay paragraph**

Question: "The real horror of Nineteen Eighty-Four lies not in physical torture but in the destruction of the inner life." Discuss with close reference to Part 3.

SOLUTION

Model paragraph:
Orwell reserves his deepest horror for the conquest of the mind. Physical suffering in the Ministry of Love — the beatings, the electric shocks, the starvation — is presented almost routinely; what matters is its purpose. O'Brien explains that the Party is not content with obedience or even confession: the heretic must be converted, made to see 2 + 2 = 5 as true, made to love Big Brother before the bullet comes. Room 101 is the supreme instrument of this inner conquest, for it attacks not the body but the bond of love: confronted with the rats, Winston does not merely say but genuinely wills that Julia suffer in his place. The final scene in the Chestnut Tree Café confirms the totality of the defeat. Winston no longer needs to be watched or threatened; he weeps with joy at the telescreen's victory bulletin, dismisses his own childhood memory as false, and loves Big Brother. The horror, therefore, is that the Party has made itself unnecessary: the prison is now inside the prisoner. Orwell's warning is that a power which colonises thought, memory and affection leaves nothing human to liberate.

EXERCISE 3 **Practice**

1. Explain, with close reference to Part 3, Chapter 5, why Room 101 is described as containing "the worst thing in the world." Why does its content differ from prisoner to prisoner?
2. Trace the stages by which the Party transforms Winston from rebel to devoted citizen. Which stage do you consider decisive, and why?
3. "Julia and Winston betray each other; only their betrayals differ." Discuss.
4. Write a general-overview essay plan on the theme: "Nineteen Eighty-Four is less a prophecy than a warning."

SOLUTION **Exercise 1 — guidance**

Room 101 contains "the worst thing in the world" because its content is defined subjectively: it holds whatever each individual prisoner fears most — for Winston, rats; for another, perhaps fire or drowning. This personalisation is the Party's refinement of terror. Universal tortures break the body at different speeds, but a man's own deepest fear breaks his will immediately and completely. The chapter shows that the purpose is not pain but betrayal: Winston saves himself only by wishing the horror onto Julia, thereby destroying the love that was his last inner freedom. Strong answers will note the childhood origin of the rat-fear, the mask-like cage, and the fact that O'Brien releases the lever only

after the betrayal is complete — proof that the torture was a means, and the betrayal the end.

KEY POINTS **Key points to remember**

- Room 101 = each prisoner's personal worst fear; its goal is betrayal, not confession.
- "Do it to Julia!" marks the death of love — the Party's true victory.
- The Chestnut Tree Café shows the finished product: a man whose memory, thought and feeling all belong to the Party.
- "He loved Big Brother": the annihilation of inner freedom is the novel's final horror.
- The novel is a dystopia and political satire in three parts; treat it as a warning about real totalitarian mechanisms, not as science fiction.
- For overview questions, balance plot, themes, characterisation and authorial purpose.

4 SECTION 4: THE MERCHANT'S TALE I — THE WEDDING, THE ENCLOSED GARDEN, AND THE INTRODUCTION OF MAY AND DAMYAN

4.1 Transition from Nineteen Eighty-Four to Chaucer's Merchant

In the previous section we examined how Orwell strips away illusion in the Ministry of Love, leaving Winston with a terrifying clarity about power and truth. Chaucer, writing more than five centuries earlier, uses a very different technique — comic irony — to expose the gap between what characters think they possess and what the reader knows they actually control. The Merchant's Tale opens with a marriage debate, moves through a lavish wedding, and then locks the young bride May inside an **enclosed garden** where desire, deception and divine parody will play out. As we study these episodes, keep in mind the Merchant's own bitter Prologue: he tells the pilgrims that he has been married only two months and already knows his wife to be "the worste that may be". His tale is therefore not a neutral story; it is a dramatisation of his own disillusionment. Every scene we analyse should be read as an illustration of his thesis that marriage brings sorrow.

4.2 The Marriage Debate: Placebo versus Justinus

January, a wealthy Lombard knight of sixty, decides to marry a young wife. He summons his friends to advise him. Two voices dominate:

- **Placebo** (Latin "I shall please") flatters January, praising marriage as a blessed state and assuring him that a young wife will be his earthly paradise.
- **Justinus** (Latin "the just one") warns that marriage is a heavy yoke and that a young wife will bring sorrow and care. He appeals to experience and to classical and biblical authority.

January, predictably, follows Placebo. The debate is not a genuine search for wisdom; it is a theatrical confirmation of January's already-fixed desire. Chaucer uses the names themselves as **ironic signifiers**: the sycophant is "pleasing", the wise man is "just", yet January chooses the former.

DEFINITION **Irony in the Marriage Debate**

Dramatic irony occurs when the audience or reader knows more than the character. Here the reader sees that January's "counsel" is a performance; the outcome is predetermined by his lust and vanity. The gap between January's self-image (prudent patriarch) and his actual motive (sexual appetite) creates the comic tension that drives the tale.

WARNING **Do Not Confuse the Speakers**

Candidates sometimes attribute Justinus's warnings to Placebo, or present the debate as balanced. Remember: Placebo flatters, Justinus warns, and January hears only what he wants to hear. The debate exists to expose January's self-deception, not to weigh marriage fairly.

4.3 The Wedding Ceremony: Liturgy Turned Satire

The wedding is described with mock solemnity. Chaucer borrows the language of the Church's marriage service and piles up biblical allusions to frame the union as holy. Yet the narrator's voice constantly undercuts the piety: no sooner has the priest blessed the bed than January hurries his bride into it. The haste from blessing to consummation reveals January's true priority. The liturgy becomes a **veneer** for possession. The feast that follows is a catalogue of excess — rare meats, music, wine — emphasising January's wealth and his view of May as another acquisition displayed before his guests.

KEY POINTS **Key Points on the Wedding**

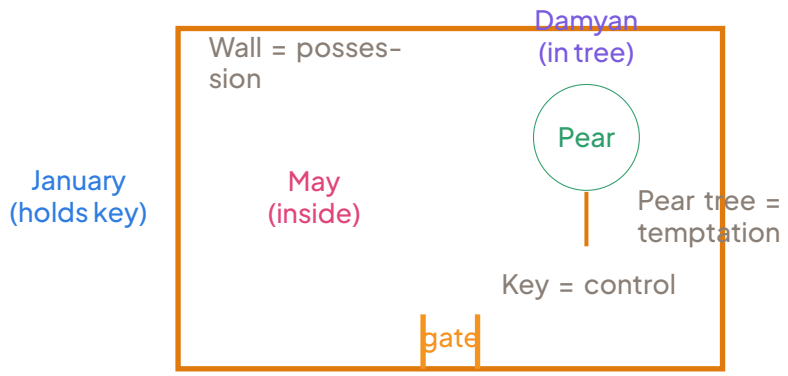
- The ceremony mimics sacred ritual but serves January's ego and appetite.
- The narrator's cynical asides signal that we are not to take the piety at face value.
- May is virtually silent throughout; her agency is erased before the tale even reaches the garden.

4.4 The Enclosed Garden (Hortus Conclusus)

After the feast January builds a magnificent walled garden, keeps the only key himself, and treats it as his private paradise where he takes May for his pleasure. The garden is a classic medieval symbol: the hortus conclusus represents the Virgin's purity, the bride's sealed virtue, and the husband's exclusive right. Chaucer, however, turns the symbol inside out.

DEFINITION **Hortus Conclusus (Enclosed Garden)**

A **hortus conclusus** is a walled garden, often with a single locked gate, used in medieval art and literature to signify virginity, marital fidelity and the husband's possession of his wife's sexuality. In The Merchant's Tale the garden becomes the literal and figurative space where that possession is violated.



Symbolic map of the enclosed garden: walls (possession), gate and key (control), pear tree (temptation). January holds the key; May is inside; Damyan will climb the tree.

The garden's description is lush: high stone walls, fresh flowers, a well, a laurel, and above all a pear tree heavy with fruit. The pear tree becomes the focal point of the adulterous plot. January's monopoly of the key is meant to guarantee May's fidelity; instead, May has a wax impression made of it, and the key becomes the very means by which Damyan is admitted.

METHOD **Analysing Irony in the Garden Episode**

1. State the character's belief. January believes the locked garden secures May's chastity.
2. State the reader's knowledge. The reader knows May has already agreed to meet Damyan and that the copied key enables the rendezvous.
3. Identify the effect. The gap produces dramatic irony that is both comic (January's blindness) and disturbing (May's entrapment in a patriarchal game).

4. Link to the Merchant's thesis. The garden illustrates the Merchant's claim, drawn from his own bitter experience, that marriage is a state of sorrow in which possession breeds betrayal.

4.5 May: Youth, Beauty, Silence and Calculation

May is introduced through January's eyes: fair, young, gentle, meek. She barely speaks before the garden scene. Her silence is not emptiness; it is a strategic performance. When Damyan feigns illness, May visits him, reads his love letter, and replies with a promise to do his will. Her calculation is evident:

- She recognises Damyan's "lovesickness" as a conventional courtly pose.
- She secretly takes an impression of the garden key in wax, turning January's instrument of control into her own opportunity.

WARNING **Do Not Moralise Simplistically Against May**

Examiners often see candidates condemn May as "wicked" or "lustful". The tale, however, invites a more nuanced reading: May is a young woman given in marriage to a man old enough to be her grandfather, granted no voice, who seizes the only agency the text allows her. Both condemnation and sympathy are textually supported. In your essays, acknowledge the Merchant's misogyny while also showing how Chaucer gives May a subtle intelligence.

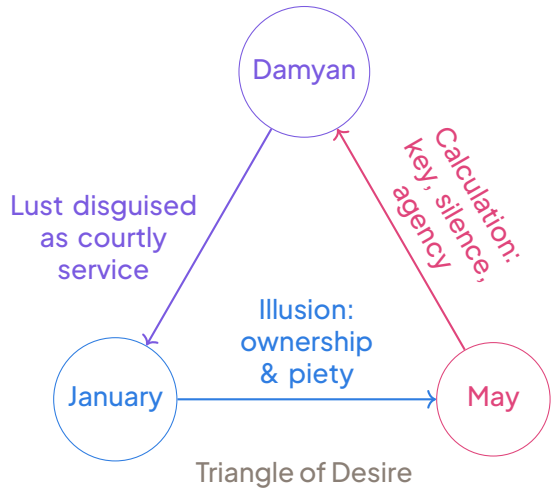
4.6 Damyan: The Parody of Courtly Love

Damyan, January's squire, falls "sick of love" — the classic **courtly love** malady: sleeplessness, pallor, poetic letters. Chaucer parodies the convention by making the love object his own master's young wife, and by having the "sickness" cured the moment May agrees to meet him.

DEFINITION **Courtly Love (Fin'amor)**

A literary code originating in the medieval courts of southern France, **courtly love** idealises an aristocratic, usually adulterous devotion: the lover suffers, serves the lady in secrecy, and elevates her to quasi-divine status. Chaucer uses the vocabulary (service, secrecy, suffering) but strips it of nobility, exposing it as a cover for lust.

Damyan's letter mimics the rhetoric of a courtly lover, yet its content is a crude request for sexual favours. The irony is sharpened when May, unimpressed by the pose, replies with blunt pragmatism.



Triangle of desire: January's illusion of possession, May's calculated agency, Damyan's lust masked as courtly love.

4.7 Irony and Satire: The Gap Between Illusion and Knowledge

The three episodes — debate, wedding, garden — form a rising scale of irony:

1. **Debate:** January thinks he seeks counsel; we see he seeks validation.
2. **Wedding:** The liturgy suggests sanctity; the narrator shows lust.
3. **Garden:** The wall promises fidelity; the copied key enables adultery.

Chaucer's satire targets not only January's folly but also the social structures that treat women as property and marriage as a transaction. In a Cameroonian context, one might compare bridewealth negotiations in which the groom's family believes it has secured a faithful wife, while the bride's own wishes are never consulted — a parallel that can enrich an essay, provided it is used to illuminate the text rather than to replace analysis of it.

WORKED EXAMPLE 4 **Worked Example: Explaining the Ironic Function of the Pear Tree**

Question: How does the pear tree function as an ironic symbol in the garden scene?

SOLUTION

Solution:

1. Identify the conventional symbol. In medieval iconography the fruit tree in an enclosed garden is associated with fertility, innocence and the Garden of Eden.
2. Show the subversion. Here the tree becomes the very spot where Damyan waits to possess May — a prop for adultery — while January believes it merely decorates his private paradise.

3. Connect to the Merchant's view. The tree becomes evidence that natural desire overrides human law and marriage vows, confirming the Merchant's bitter conviction, voiced in his Prologue, that wedlock brings only sorrow.
4. Conclude. The pear tree thus concentrates the tale's central irony: a symbol of innocence and grace turned into an instrument of betrayal.

4.8 True-to-Life Representation: Marriage as Transaction

Across cultures and epochs, marriage has often been a contract between families rather than a union of hearts. January's acquisition of a young bride mirrors the economic reality of many historical societies, including pre-colonial African kingdoms where bridewealth sealed alliances between lineages. Chaucer does not condemn the transaction outright; he dramatises its consequences — loneliness, deception, and the inevitable collision of appetite and law. This realism is what the syllabus calls **true-to-life human representation**: characters driven by recognisable motives — vanity, lust, the will to survive — rather than by idealised sentiment.

KEY POINTS **Linking to the Merchant's Prologue**

Every GCE question on The Merchant's Tale expects you to reference the Merchant's own voice. When discussing the garden, write, for example: "The enclosed garden enacts the Merchant's Prologue confession that his own wife is 'the worste that may be', because the very structure meant to guarantee fidelity becomes the instrument of betrayal." This explicit link raises your answer from narrative summary to critical analysis.

4.9 Consolidation Exercise

EXERCISE 4 **Practice Question**

Write a paragraph (150–200 words) analysing how Chaucer uses the wedding feast to develop the theme of possession. Include at least one short quotation and refer to the Merchant's Prologue.

SOLUTION **Exercise 1**

The wedding feast transforms the sacred liturgy into a display of January's wealth and control. The narrator's lavish catalogue of rare dishes and music itemises the bride alongside the exotic food, reducing May to another commodity on show. The speed with which January, once the priest has blessed the bed, hurries his bride into it underscores that possession, not piety, drives the union. This mirrors the Merchant's Prologue, where he

confesses that his own wife of two months is "the worste that may be", revealing that his tale projects his own bitter experience onto January's farcical marriage. Thus the feast is not a celebration but an inventory.

4.10 Summary of Key Concepts

KEY POINTS **Section 4 Essentials**

- The marriage debate establishes January's self-deception through dramatic irony: Placebo flatters, Justinus warns, January hears only what he wants.
- The wedding ceremony parodies liturgy to expose lust disguised as sacrament.
- The hortus conclusus inverts its traditional symbol of purity into a stage for adultery; the copied key turns control into opportunity.
- May's silence masks calculation; Damyan's courtly pose masks lust.
- Every episode should be tied back to the Merchant's Prologue thesis on the misery of marriage.

5 SECTION 5: THE MERCHANT'S TALE II — BLINDNESS, THE COUNTER-PLOT, THE PEAR TREE AND DIVINE INTERVENTION

In Section 4 we watched old January marry young May, build his walled garden of pleasure, and fall sick with desire for a wife who was already exchanging glances with the squire Damyan. The stage was set: a jealous old husband, a cunning young wife, a lovesick young man, and a private garden with a locked gate. In this section we follow the tale to its extraordinary climax. Chaucer now strikes his central metaphor — **blindness** — literally: January goes physically blind, and precisely at that moment he "sees" less than ever before. Around this paradox Chaucer builds a **counter-plot** of deception, a comic deus ex machina in the persons of Pluto and Proserpina, and one of the most famous scenes in all medieval literature: the pear tree. Our task is to read these episodes closely, to understand the tale as a **fabliau**, and to synthesise its themes for the GCE examination.

5.1 January's Physical Blindness: Causes and Consequences

From observation to meaning.

Notice what happens in everyday life when a person loses one faculty: the others become sharper, but also more anxious. A man who cannot see his wife will listen for her, question her, and cling to her. Chaucer exploits exactly this psychology.

At the height of his uxorious happiness, January is struck blind. Chaucer presents the blindness as a sudden affliction of age — the natural decay of an old body that has been abused by lechery. But the timing is deeply ironic: January loses his sight just when there is something he most needs to see, namely the affair ripening between May and Damyan.

The consequences are double:

- **Increased jealousy.** Deprived of sight, January becomes pathologically possessive. He keeps his hand on May at all times; he will not let her move anywhere in the house or garden without his grip upon her. The blindness intensifies the very fault — jealous surveillance — that already defined his marriage.
- **Increased vulnerability.** The more tightly he holds May, the more he depends on her guidance — and the easier it becomes for her to guide him exactly where she wants him to go: to the foot of the pear tree.

WARNING **Do not misread the cause**

January's blindness is not presented as a divine punishment pronounced by any Christian voice in the poem. It is the natural consequence of age and self-indulgence, used by Chaucer as an ironic device. Avoid essays that claim "God blinded January to punish his lust" — the text supports irony, not sermon.

5.2 Physical versus Moral Blindness

Here lies the thematic heart of the tale, and one of the most frequently examined ideas at the GCE.

DEFINITION **Moral blindness**

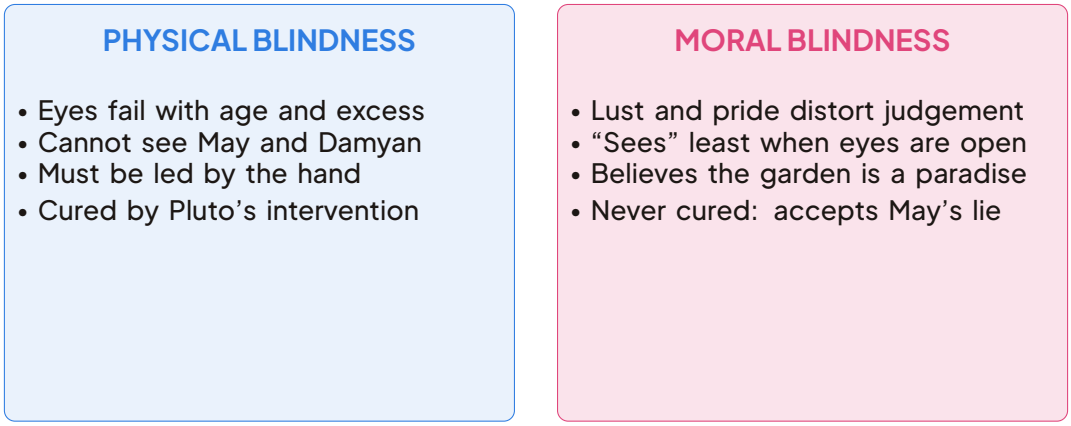
Moral blindness is the inability to perceive truth about oneself, one's situation, or other people, despite having functioning physical sight. It includes self-deception, wilful ignorance, pride and lust that distort judgement.

The paradox Chaucer constructs is precise: **January "sees" least when his eyes are open.** Before he goes blind, with perfect eyesight, he cannot see that his marriage is an absurdity, that May does not love him, that Damyan is a rival under his own roof, and that his "paradise" of a garden is a trap of his own making. His lust and self-flattery blind him more completely than any physical affliction. When he later loses his physical sight, the metaphor simply becomes flesh.

EXEMPLE **The paradox in action**

- Sighted January calls his marriage a "paradys" and believes May's flattery — moral blindness.

- Blind January clutches May's hand, believing possession equals fidelity — deeper moral blindness.
- Sight restored, January looks up and sees May and Damyan in the tree — yet within moments he accepts her absurd explanation. Even with sight returned, moral blindness wins: he prefers a comforting lie to a painful truth.



Parallel-column diagram: physical blindness versus moral blindness in The Merchant's Tale.

KEY POINTS **Key point for essays**

The restoration of January's physical sight at the climax is the tale's bitterest joke: he regains his eyes but not his understanding. True blindness in the tale is moral, and it is incurable because it is voluntary — January chooses self-deception.

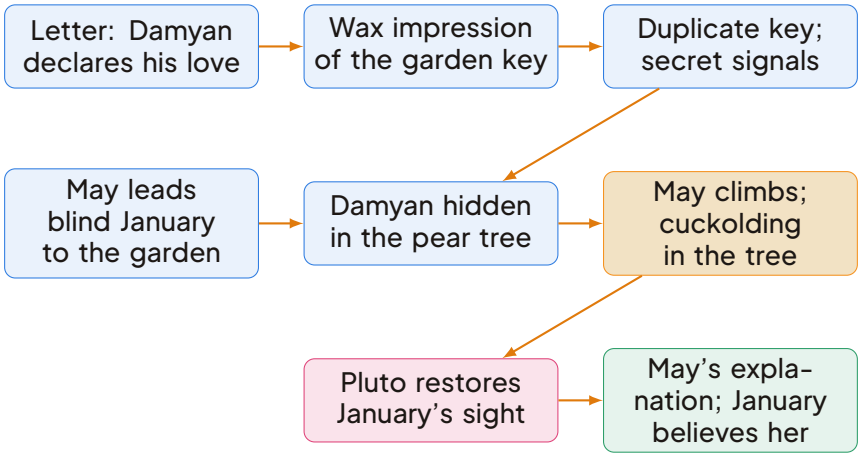
5.3 The Counter-Plot: May and Damyan's Conspiracy

DEFINITION **Counter-plot**

A **counter-plot** is the secret scheme devised by the opponents of the deceived or dominant character, running beneath the main plot and driving the tale towards its climax. In a fabliau, the counter-plot is the engine of the trick.

While January plots to possess May, May and Damyan plot against him. Chaucer constructs their conspiracy with the precision of a military operation:

1. **The letter.** Damyan, sick with love, writes May a letter declaring his passion. May reads it — and disposes of it in the privy, a fabliau detail of comic realism — and answers him favourably.
2. **The wax impression of the key.** The garden gate is locked and January keeps the key. May secretly takes an impression of the key in warm wax; Damyan has a duplicate key forged. The "paradise" is breached from within.
3. **The signals.** May and Damyan arrange signs by which she will communicate with him even in January's presence — gestures and glances invisible to the blind husband who holds her hand.
4. **The assignation.** May signals Damyan to enter the garden and climb the pear tree in advance; she then manoeuvres January into the garden and engineers the final scene.



Sequence chart of the counter-plot: from the letter to May's triumphant explanation.

Observe the artistry: every element of January's fantasy is turned against him. The garden he built for his own pleasure becomes the theatre of his shame; the wife he imprisoned becomes his gaoler; the key he guarded is copied under his nose.

5.4 The Pear Tree Episode

The climax proper. May tells January she longs for the fruit of a pear tree in the garden — a craving she attributes to her (possibly feigned) pregnancy, a detail that adds both comedy and a hint that the child may not be January's. The tree is too high; January must stoop and let her climb on his back. She climbs — straight into the arms of Damyan, waiting in the branches. There, in the tree, above the bowed back of the blind husband, the cuckolding is consummated.

The scene is the perfect emblem of the whole tale: January literally supports, on his own bent back, the act that dishonours him. The pear tree — with its echoes of the Tree of Knowledge in Eden — parodies the Fall: this garden too contains a tree, a woman, and a loss of innocence, but everything is degraded into farce.

METHOD **Analysing a climax**

To analyse any narrative climax at the GCE, proceed in three steps:

1. Convergence: identify the plot lines that meet. Here: January's garden fantasy, the May–Damyan counter-plot, and the gods' wager all converge at one tree.
2. Reversal: identify the peripeteia — the sudden turn. Here: Pluto restores January's sight at the very moment of the cuckolding, so the hidden sin becomes visible.
3. Payoff: identify the comic or ironic resolution. Here: Proserpina's counter-gift lets May talk her way out, so the revelation changes nothing — the deepest irony of all.

5.5 Divine Intervention: Pluto and Proserpina

At this point Chaucer introduces, with audacious comedy, two pagan deities: **Pluto**, king of the underworld, and his queen **Proserpina**. They have been following January's marriage, and they take sides along gender lines:

- **Pluto**, outraged by May's treachery, declares he will restore January's sight so that the husband may witness his wife's infidelity — a champion of deceived husbands.
- **Proserpina**, equally indignant on behalf of women, vows to give May — and all women after her — the gift of a ready answer: however plainly a wife is caught, she will always find a plausible excuse.

The result is a divine stalemate, a comic wager between the sexes played out through human puppets.

WARNING **Pluto and Proserpina are not Christian providence**

A frequent GCE error is to read this episode as God's judgement. It is not. Chaucer borrows classical mythology as comic machinery: the gods function like the deus ex machina of classical theatre, and their quarrel is a satirical gender debate — a medieval "battle of the sexes" — not a theological statement. Note also the Merchant-narrator's cynicism: in his world, pagan gods, not the Christian God, preside over marriage.

5.6 The Climax in the Tree and the Restoration of Sight

At the instant of the cuckolding, Pluto keeps his promise: January's eyes are opened. He looks up — and sees his wife with Damyan in the tree. He cries out in outrage. But Proserpina keeps hers: May, caught in the most flagrant position imaginable, does not panic. She explains, with magnificent impudence, that she was told his sight could only be cured if she would "struggle with a man upon a tree" — and that she did it entirely for his sake. She even turns the attack on him: his sight is newly restored and therefore unreliable; he must be mistaken about what he thinks he saw.

And January — preferring comfort to truth — accepts the explanation. The tale ends with husband and wife reconciled, the cuckold embracing his own deception.

WORKED EXAMPLE 5 **Analysing the climax of the pear tree scene**

Question (GCE style): "The pear tree episode is the dramatic and thematic climax of The Merchant's Tale." Discuss.

SOLUTION

Plan and model development. Step 1 — Convergence. Three lines of action meet at the tree: (i) January's fantasy of the garden as his private paradise; (ii) the May–Damyan counter-plot (letter, wax key, signals); (iii) the wager of Pluto and Proserpina. The scene is therefore structurally inevitable — everything in the tale has been moving towards it.
Step 2 — Reversal. Pluto restores January's sight at the precise moment of the adultery. The hidden becomes visible; the blind husband sees. This is the peripeteia.
Step 3 — Payoff. Proserpina's gift defeats Pluto's: May's "struggle with a man upon a tree" explanation converts certain proof into accepted innocence. The reversal is itself reversed.
Thematic payoff. The episode dramatises the tale's central thesis: sight is not insight. January's eyes are cured; his judgement is not. The climax thus fuses plot and theme — the mark of a true climax — and the examiner should be told so explicitly.

5.7 The Tale as a Fabliau — and Chaucer's Elevation of the Genre

DEFINITION **Fabliau**

A **fabliau** is a short comic tale in verse, popular in medieval French literature, featuring trickery, sexual comedy, obscenity and satire, usually at the expense of bourgeois, clerical or foolish old characters. Typical ingredients: a lustful old husband (senex amans), a young wife, a clever lover, an ingenious trick, and poetic justice.

The Merchant's Tale contains every ingredient: the senex amans January, the young wife May, the lover Damyan, the trick of the key and the tree, the sexual comedy, and the duping of the fool. Yet Chaucer elevates the genre:

- **Psychological depth.** January is not a flat comic butt; his self-deception is analysed with almost tragic subtlety.
- **Literary allusion.** The garden parodies the Song of Songs and Eden; the gods parody classical epic machinery.
- **Narratorial irony.** The bitter Merchant tells the tale against his own marriage, layering cynicism over comedy.
- **Moral resonance.** Beneath the farce runs a serious meditation on sight, illusion and mar-

riage.

DID YOU KNOW? **Poetic justice — or its parody?**

In a simple fabliau, the trickster triumphs and the fool is punished — that is the "justice". Chaucer complicates it: May triumphs, yes, but her victory depends on January's willingness to be deceived. The final poetic justice is therefore double-edged: everyone gets what they deserve, including a husband who deserves to remain blind.

5.8 Synthesis of Themes

- **Marriage.** The tale is the bitterest contribution to the "marriage debate" of The Canterbury Tales: marriage without love, based on lust and purchase, produces only trickery.
- **Illusion versus reality.** January's "paradise" is illusion; the garden is really a trap. Language itself — May's ready answers — manufactures illusion.
- **Sight and blindness.** Physical sight is restored; moral sight is not. The tale's governing metaphor.
- **Gender and power.** May, apparently the property of her husband, ends by controlling what he sees and believes; Proserpina defeats Pluto. Female "maistrye" wins, but through deception, not dignity.
- **Age and youth.** January's folly is to believe wealth can defeat time; youth (May, Damyan) defeats age through wit, not force.

METHOD **Exam tip: the "physical vs moral blindness" essay**

This is a recurrent GCE theme. Prepare a balanced plan:

1. Introduction: define both terms; state the thesis — January's real blindness is moral.
2. Paragraph 1: sighted January blind to the absurdity of his marriage (quotation: his praise of marriage as a "paradys").
3. Paragraph 2: the wax key and signals — deception under open eyes.
4. Paragraph 3: physical blindness intensifies jealousy and dependence.
5. Paragraph 4: the pear tree and the "struggle with a man upon a tree" — sight restored, insight refused.
6. Conclusion: Chaucer's point — wilful self-deception is the only incurable blindness.

Memorise at least four short quotations or precise paraphrases, one per body paragraph.

EXERCISE 5 **Practice**

1. Explain how the wax impression of the key symbolises the failure of January's attempt to possess May.
2. "Pluto and Proserpina turn the climax into a debate between the sexes." Discuss with close reference to the text.
3. Write a paragraph showing how the pear tree scene parodies the Garden of Eden.

SOLUTION **Exercise 1**

The key is the emblem of January's jealous ownership: he alone may enter the locked garden, as he alone claims to possess May. The wax impression shows that possession is an illusion — the barrier is breached from within, by the very person it was meant to confine, and through her own initiative. Symbolically, May duplicates the instrument of her imprisonment and converts it into an instrument of freedom; the garden of January's paradise becomes the garden of his shame. The detail also displays the fabliau logic of the tale: every defence the jealous husband erects becomes the means of his defeat.

KEY POINTS **Section summary**

January's physical blindness literalises his lifelong moral blindness; May and Damyan's counter-plot (letter, wax key, signals) turns his own garden against him; the pear tree concentrates all plot lines into one comic climax; Pluto and Proserpina's wager ensures that restored sight changes nothing; and Chaucer, while using every convention of the fabliau, raises it into a profound study of illusion, marriage and the wilful refusal to see.

6 SECTION 6: THE MERCHANT'S TALE III — REVIEWS, LITERARY APPRECIATION AND GCE MASTERY

In Section 5 we followed the counter-plot to its scandalous climax in the pear tree and watched Pluto and Proserpina quarrel over January's restored sight. We now step back from the story to do what every GCE candidate must do in the examination hall: review the whole material, appreciate it critically, and convert knowledge into marks. Revision is not re-reading; it is reorganising what you know so that any question — on character, setting, device, theme or style — can be answered in about forty-five minutes with precision and evidence. This section therefore covers the syllabus lessons on the review of characters, the review of setting, the review of literary devices, literary appreciation of style and themes, and the approach to GCE questions.

6.1 Review of Characters in The General Prologue

The **General Prologue** is Chaucer's portrait gallery. Before any tale is told, Chaucer introduces about thirty pilgrims gathered at the Tabard Inn in Southwark, and the way he paints them is itself a lesson in **characterisation**. Observe first that Chaucer does not tell us what to think; he shows us a sleeve, a brooch, a habit of speech, and lets us judge. This is the technique you must be able to name and illustrate in the examination.

EXEMPLE **Five portraits to master**

- The Knight — the idealised portrait: a worthy, chivalrous crusader who has fought in many campaigns yet remains as meek and modest as a maid. Chaucer describes his stained, plain tunic rather than his glory: character is shown through dress and deed, not praise.
- The Prioress (Madame Eglentyne) — a nun whose tender heart weeps for a trapped mouse while her refined table manners and her coral rosary with the motto Amor vincit omnia ("love conquers all") suggest worldly vanity. The portrait is gently ironic: is her tenderness piety or sentimentality?
- The Wife of Bath — gap-toothed, red-stockinged, five times widowed, somewhat deaf, a veteran pilgrim. Chaucer builds her through accumulated physical and biographical detail; she is vitality itself, and a forerunner of May's sexual self-confidence.
- The Pardoner — a church official selling pardons and fake relics (pig's bones passed off as saints' relics). His portrait is satirical: the description of his stringy yellow hair and glaring eyes externalises moral corruption.
- The Merchant — forked beard, Flemish beaver hat, always talking of his profits, secretly in debt. Crucially, the Prologue presents him as pompous and self-important, and the prologue to his own tale reveals that he has been married only two months and already bitterly regrets it — the **dramatic link** that motivates his sour tale of marriage.

KEY POINTS **Chaucer's portrait techniques**

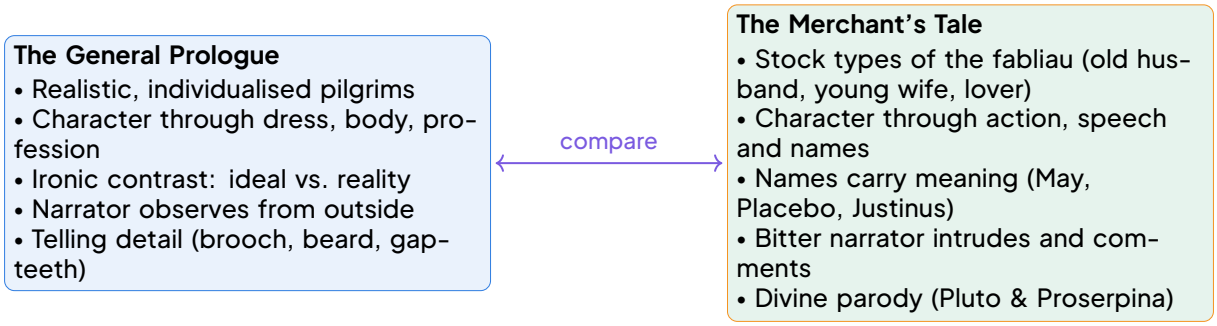
Chaucer characterises through: (1) physical description (face, body, clothing); (2) profession and behaviour; (3) speech and reported opinion; (4) ironic contrast between what a pilgrim should be and what he or she is; (5) selective, telling detail — one small feature (the Merchant's forked beard, the Prioress's brooch) that implies a whole personality. In the examination, always pair the technique with the detail that proves it.

6.2 Review of Characters in The Merchant's Tale

The tale's cast is smaller and more sharply functional — each character exists to advance the satire on marriage and deception. Notice how the method changes: where the Prologue paints

individuals, the Tale manipulates types.

- **January** — the sixty-year-old knight of Pavia who marries, he claims, for holiness, but in fact for lust. His name ironically suggests winter; he embodies self-deception, lechery and possessiveness. His literal blindness in middle age mirrors his lifelong moral blindness.
- **May** — the young bride, named for spring. Outwardly submissive, she is calculating: she copies the garden key in wax, arranges the tryst, and invents the pear-tree excuse on the spot. She is the Wife of Bath's philosophy put into action.
- **Damyan** — the lovesick squire who burns in silence, writes a love letter, and finally receives May's answer. He is the conventional courtly lover degraded into a mere adulterer waiting in a tree.
- **Placebo** — the flatterer whose name means "I shall please"; he tells January exactly what January wants to hear. A satire on yes-men in every court and every government.
- **Justinus** — "the just one"; the voice of experience who warns January against hasty marriage. The debate between the two brothers dramatises flattery versus truth.
- **Pluto and Proserpina** — the fairy king and queen who intervene at the climax: Pluto restores January's sight, Proserpina supplies May with her excuse. Their quarrel parodies the human marriage debate on a divine level.



Comparison of Chaucer's characterisation techniques in the two set texts.

6.3 Review of Setting

Setting in Chaucer is never decoration; it carries meaning. Train yourself to ask of every place and season: what does it stand for?

The General Prologue. The frame is the **pilgrimage**: the Tabard Inn at Southwark, the road to Canterbury, and the season — April, with its sweet showers that pierce the drought of March. Spring symbolises renewal, fertility and spiritual longing; the pilgrimage itself is both a real journey and an image of life's journey towards the sacred. The inn, a place of eating, drinking and bargaining, anchors the poem in ordinary social life.

The Merchant's Tale. The action moves to **Lombardy** (Pavia), to January's palace, and above all to the **enclosed garden** — a private paradise with a locked gate, evoking both the Garden of Eden and the hortus conclusus (enclosed garden) of medieval love poetry. The garden, meant

to be January's exclusive pleasure-ground, becomes the site of his cuckolding: the setting itself turns against its maker. The pear tree inside it completes the irony, recalling the forbidden tree of Genesis.

6.4 Review of Literary Devices I and II

KEY POINTS **Devices you must be able to identify and illustrate**

- Irony — January prays for a young, "fair" wife and gets one who outwits him; the gods "help" by restoring his sight at the worst possible moment.
- Satire — of old lechers, of flatterers (Placebo), of bad theology used to justify lust, of marriage itself as the embittered Merchant sees it.
- Imagery — the seasons (January/May), the garden, the key, the pear tree; biblical echoes (Eden, the Song of Songs).
- Allusion — to Genesis, to classical myth (Pluto and Proserpina), and to learned authorities on marriage such as Theophrastus, invoked during the debate between January's counsellors.
- Symbolism — the garden (Eden corrupted, a false paradise), the pear tree (the Tree of Knowledge degraded into a trysting place), the keys (possession and its betrayal — May copies the key in wax).
- Parody — January's wedding-night song and his courtship parody the Song of Songs; the gods' quarrel parodies the human marriage debate.
- Contrast — age/youth, winter/spring, sight/blindness, flattery/truth (Placebo/Justinus).
- Narrative voice — the bitter Merchant-narrator intrudes with personal asides about his own unhappy marriage, fusing teller and tale.

6.5 Literary Appreciation: Focus on Style

DEFINITION **Literary appreciation**

Literary appreciation is a reasoned personal response to a text's themes, style and effects, supported by close reference to evidence from the text. It is not a summary and not a list of devices: it is an argued judgement — how the writer's choices create meaning, and how well they succeed.

Chaucer's style in these texts rests on four pillars. First, **language**: Middle English enriched by French and Latin vocabulary, capable of moving from the courtly to the crude within a few lines

— the register always serves the satire. Second, **tone**: a smiling, tolerant irony in the General Prologue becomes the Merchant's bitter, corrosive mockery; noticing this shift is the key to comparing the two texts. Third, **versification**: rhyming couplets of iambic pentameter (the heroic couplet), whose neat closures are perfect vehicles for witty, epigrammatic judgements. Fourth, the **dramatic link between teller and tale**: the Merchant, two months married and miserable, tells a tale that poisons the very idea of marriage — the tale is his revenge.

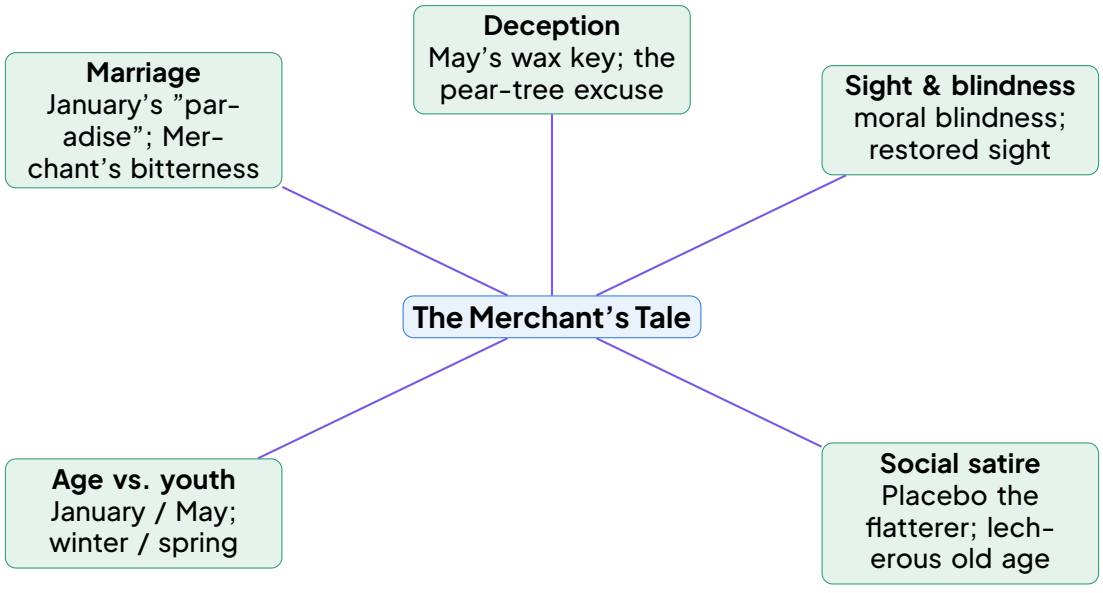
METHOD **The four-step appreciation grid**

For any passage or whole-text appreciation question, work through four steps:

1. Content — what happens, what is said, what themes are engaged? (one or two sentences only)
2. Form — genre, structure, versification, narrative voice, position in the work.
3. Devices — identify two or three devices (irony, imagery, symbolism, contrast) and quote or closely paraphrase the evidence.
4. Personal evaluation — judge the effect: is it comic, moving, satirical, successful? Justify your judgement.

Steps 3 and 4 carry the most marks; steps 1 and 2 merely set them up.

6.6 Literary Appreciation: Focus on Themes



Mind-map of the major themes of The Merchant's Tale with supporting evidence.

Comparing Prologue and Tale on theme: **marriage** appears in the Prologue through the Wife of

Bath (five husbands, proudly) and the Merchant (two months, bitterly); the Tale then dramatises the Merchant's view. **Deception** is hinted at in the Prologue's hypocrites (the Pardoner) and becomes the Tale's engine. **Sight** — moral versus physical — is the Tale's central irony. **Social satire** unites both texts: Chaucer's Church, court and marriage bed are all judged by the same smiling, deadly irony.

6.7 Approaching GCE Questions

WARNING **The revision dump**

In revision answers, do not dump everything you know. A question on irony is not an invitation to retell the plot or list every character. Select only what the question demands, and let every paragraph begin with a point that answers the question directly.

Instruction words. Discuss = present a balanced argument with evidence. Examine/Analyse = break the topic into parts and show how they work. Compare = treat the two texts together by criteria. Comment on/Appreciate = apply the four-step grid. To what extent = take a position and defend it, acknowledging the counter-argument.

PROPERTY **Exam technique for comparison questions**

For compare questions, organise by **criteria** (theme by theme, device by device), not by text (all of A, then all of B). A criterion-based plan forces genuine comparison in every paragraph and is what examiners reward. (No proof is examinable; the technique itself must be demonstrated in your essays.)

WORKED EXAMPLE 6 **Worked GCE-style question**

Question: "Compare Chaucer's treatment of deception in the General Prologue and in The Merchant's Tale." Provide an essay plan and one model paragraph.

SOLUTION

Plan (criterion-based):

1. Introduction: deception as a unifying concern — social hypocrisy in the Prologue, marital trickery in the Tale.
2. Criterion 1 — who deceives: the Pardoner (fake relics, false absolution) vs. May and Damyan (the wax key, the tree).
3. Criterion 2 — how deception is exposed: the narrator's irony in the Prologue vs. dramatic action and divine intervention in the Tale.
4. Criterion 3 — Chaucer's attitude: amused tolerance of human weakness vs. the Mer-

chant's bitter cynicism.

5. Conclusion: the same satirical eye, but a darker heart in the Tale.

Model paragraph (Criterion 1): In the General Prologue, deception is professional: the Pardoner carries pig's bones which he sells as saints' relics, exploiting the faith of simple people for money. Chaucer exposes him not through plot but through the narrator's dry catalogue of his tricks. In the Tale, deception becomes domestic and sexual: May presses January's garden key into warm wax so that Damyan can have a copy made, transforming the symbol of January's possession into the instrument of his betrayal. Where the Pardoner deceives strangers for profit, May deceives a husband for desire — and Chaucer's tone shifts accordingly from amused irony to something sharper and more cynical.

EXERCISE 6 **Ten-minute plans**

Write a ten-minute essay plan (introduction, three criterion-based points, conclusion) for each of these past-style questions:

1. "Examine the role of the gods in The Merchant's Tale."
2. "Discuss Chaucer's use of setting in the General Prologue and The Merchant's Tale."
3. "'Chaucer laughs at his characters but never hates them.' To what extent is this true of the texts you have studied?"
4. "Comment on the significance of names in The Merchant's Tale."
5. "Compare the Wife of Bath and May as portraits of women."

SOLUTION **Exercise 1**

Indicative guidance. Q1: the gods as a parody of human marriage; Pluto restores sight (ironic "help"); Proserpina arms May with her excuse — divine intervention deepens, not resolves, the satire. Q2: April and the pilgrimage as renewal and frame; Lombardy, the palace and the garden as a false Eden; settings carry thematic meaning. Q3: largely true of the Prologue (gentle irony toward the Prioress), less true of the Merchant's bitterness toward January — argue both sides. Q4: January (winter), May (spring), Placebo ("I shall please"), Justinus ("the just") — names as instant characterisation and irony. Q5: both sexually confident and experienced; the Wife speaks openly, May acts secretly; Chaucer's sympathy versus the Merchant's cynicism. In every plan, begin each point with a sentence that answers the question directly, and attach one piece of textual evidence to each point.

WARNING **Final exam tips**

- Practise 10-minute essay plans for at least five past GCE poetry questions before the exam; planning speed is a trainable skill and saves you in the hall.
- Quote short phrases you are certain of (Amor vincit omnia, the wax key, the April showers); a wrong quotation costs more than a careful paraphrase.
- Always name the effect of a device, not just the device: "irony" alone earns little; "irony which exposes January's self-deception" earns marks.

With this mastery of review, appreciation and examination technique for Chaucer, the chapter now turns to prose: Chinua Achebe's Anthills of the Savannah, beginning with the author's relevant biography and the historical-political framework of the novel.

7 SECTION 7: ANTHILLS OF THE SAVANNAH — ACHEBE'S BIOGRAPHY AND THE HISTORICAL-POLITICAL FRAMEWORK

In Section 6 we completed our mastery of The Merchant's Tale, learning to synthesise themes, review literary devices and approach GCE questions on Chaucer with confidence. We now turn from medieval England to contemporary West Africa, and from poetry to prose, as we open our study of Chinua Achebe's Anthills of the Savannah (1987). Before reading a single chapter of the novel, the examiner expects you to understand who Achebe was, why he wrote, and what historical realities stand behind his fictional state of Kangan. This section therefore builds the biographical and historical foundation on which every later chapter analysis will rest.

7.1 Chinua Achebe: A Relevant Biography

DEFINITION **Post-colonial literature**

Post-colonial literature is writing that examines the political, cultural and psychological aftermath of colonialism: how formerly colonised peoples rebuild identity, govern themselves, and confront the new failures — corruption, dictatorship, neocolonialism — that arise after the foreign ruler departs.

Chinua Achebe was born in **1930** in **Ogidi**, in south-eastern Nigeria, into an Igbo family that had converted to Christianity. He grew up, as he often explained, at the crossroads of cultures: traditional Igbo storytelling, proverbs and oral performance on one side, the English language and mission-school education on the other. This double heritage became the engine of his art. He studied at University College, Ibadan (then affiliated to the University of London), and worked for the Nigerian Broadcasting Service before devoting himself fully to writing.

His first novel, Things Fall Apart (1958), made him world-famous and earned him the informal title of **father of African literature** in English. Its importance was revolutionary: for the first time, a widely read novel told the story of the colonial encounter from the African side, in dignified, proverb-rich English, answering the distorted picture of Africa found in colonial fiction such as Conrad's Heart of Darkness or Cary's Mister Johnson. Achebe's other major novels — No Longer at Ease (1960), Arrow of God (1964), A Man of the People (1966) and Anthills of the Savannah (1987) — trace Nigeria's journey from the pre-colonial village to the corrupt post-independence state. He died in **2013**, having taught for many years in Nigeria and the United States.

DID YOU KNOW? **The novelist as teacher**

Achebe famously described the novelist as a **teacher**: the writer, he argued, has a duty to help his society "regain belief in itself and put away the complexes of the years of denigration." For Achebe, literature is never mere entertainment; it is a moral and civic act. Keep this idea in mind — it is the key to his purpose in Anthills of the Savannah, where he examines what intellectuals, soldiers and women owe to their nation.

7.2 From Things Fall Apart to Anthills: Achebe's Evolution

Achebe's five novels can be read as one long national story. Things Fall Apart dramatises the **colonial encounter**: the arrival of the British and the destruction of Igbo society, embodied in the tragic hero Okonkwo. No Longer at Ease and A Man of the People move into the early independence era and already sound a note of alarm — bribery, cynical politicians, a betrayed electorate. Notably, A Man of the People ends with a military coup; shortly after its publication, Nigeria experienced real coups in January and July 1966, and many readers marvelled at Achebe's prophetic insight.

Anthills of the Savannah, published after a gap of more than twenty years, represents the mature stage of this evolution: **post-colonial disillusionment**. The enemy is no longer the white coloniser. The enemy is within: the military dictator, the compromised intellectual, the silenced press, the abandoned peasantry. The question has shifted from "How did the stranger destroy us?" to "Why have we destroyed ourselves — and how can we rebuild?"

KEY POINTS **Achebe's artistic journey**

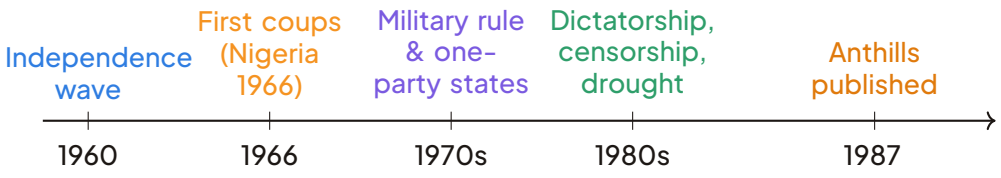
- Things Fall Apart (1958): the colonial encounter; Africa answers back.
- A Man of the People (1966): corruption of the independence elite; ends in a coup.
- Anthills of the Savannah (1987): post-colonial disillusionment; military dictatorship examined from inside the palace.

7.3 The Historical Framework: Coups, Dictatorships and One-Party States

To understand Kangan, you must first understand Africa between roughly **1960 and 1990**. The wave of independence that swept the continent around 1960 raised immense hopes. Within

a few years, however, many new states collapsed into instability. The pattern repeated itself across West Africa and beyond:

1. **Military coups**: armies seized power from civilian governments, claiming to rescue the nation from corrupt politicians. Nigeria itself experienced coups in 1966 and several times afterwards, and spent much of the period under military rulers.
2. **One-party states and dictatorships**: elected parliaments were dissolved, constitutions suspended, and power concentrated in one man — often a soldier promoted by his own coup.
3. **Suppression of dissent**: newspapers were censored or closed, critics detained without trial, and universities and unions harassed.
4. **Neglect of the rural poor**: while the capital glittered, remote provinces suffered drought, bad roads and official indifference.



Timeline of the historical framework behind Anthills of the Savannah: from the independence wave of 1960 to the novel's publication in 1987.

Achebe lived through all of this. He witnessed the Nigerian civil war (the Biafran war, 1967–1970), served the Biafran cause in diplomatic and humanitarian roles, and watched successive military regimes misgovern his country. Anthills of the Savannah is the fruit of that long, painful observation.

7.4 Kangan: A Fictional West African State

Achebe sets his novel not in Nigeria but in **Kangan**, an imaginary West African country. This is a deliberate artistic choice. Kangan allows him to compress the experience of many African states — Nigeria, Ghana, Uganda and others that passed through coups and military rule — into one representative nation. The reader recognises the reality, but no single government can claim the portrait as a personal attack.

DEFINITION **Roman à clef elements**

A **roman à clef** ("novel with a key") is fiction whose characters and events deliberately echo real persons and situations. Anthills of the Savannah is not a strict roman à clef — Sam, Chris, Ikem and Beatrice are not portraits of specific individuals — but it contains roman à clef elements: the coup-born regime, the sycophantic cabinet, the censored newspaper and the drought-stricken province all mirror recognisable African political realities of the 1960s–1980s.

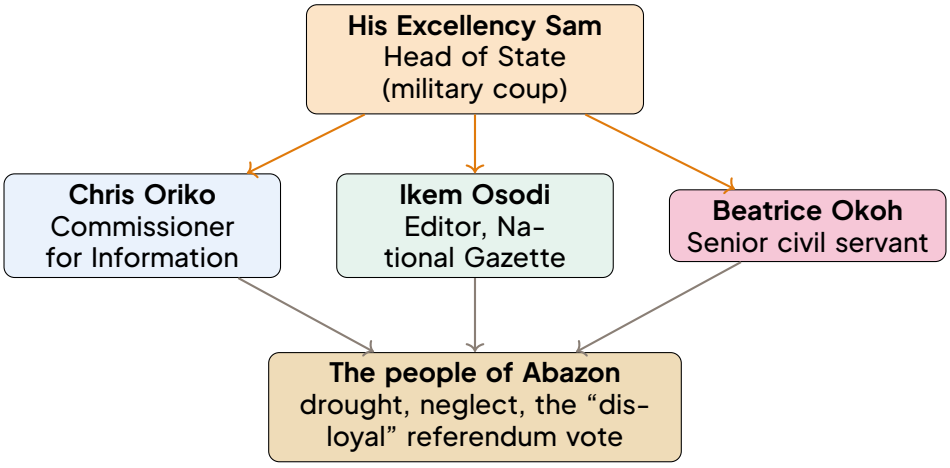
WARNING **Say Kangan, not Nigeria**

A frequent and costly mistake in GCE essays: writing "Nigeria" where the text says Kangan. Kangan is fictional. You may write: "Kangan, a fictional West African state clearly modelled on the military regimes of countries such as Nigeria…" — but your analysis must always return to the text's own names and details.

7.5 The Political Context of the Novel

The novel opens inside the machinery of power. **His Excellency Sam** — a Sandhurst-trained soldier — has come to power through a coup and has gradually hardened into a dictator. Three features of his regime structure the whole plot:

- **The referendum**: Sam seeks to be declared President for Life through a national referendum. When the province of **Abazon** votes against him, his vanity turns to vindictiveness.
- **The Abazon crisis**: Abazon, a poor, drought-stricken region, is punished for its "disloyal" vote. Its people send a delegation to the capital to beg for water and roads — and are kept waiting, humiliated, at the gates of power. Abazon becomes the moral measuring-rod of the regime: how a government treats its weakest citizens reveals its true nature.
- **The inner circle**: Sam's oldest friends now serve him — **Chris Oriko** as Commissioner for Information, **Ikem Osodi** as editor of the state-owned National Gazette, and **Beatrice Okoh** as a senior civil servant. The novel asks what happens to friendship, truth and conscience when power becomes absolute.



Kangan's power structure: authority flows downward from His Excellency through the cabinet, the state media and the civil service to the neglected people of Abazon.

7.6 Achebe's Purpose and True-to-Life Representation

Achebe's purpose in Anthills of the Savannah is diagnostic and moral. He examines the **fail-**

ure of leadership: Sam is not a monster but an ordinary, once-charming man corrupted by absolute power and flattery — a far more frightening and truthful portrait. He also examines the **responsibility of intellectuals** (Ikem's journalism, Chris's compromises), of **soldiers** (the coup-maker who forgets why he seized power), and of **women** (Beatrice, who emerges as the novel's moral centre and hope of renewal).

This is **true-to-life human representation** at its finest — the very subject of our chapter. The characters are fictional, yet every Cameroonian or Nigerian reader of the 1980s recognised them: the cabinet meeting where ministers compete in sycophancy, the editor who must choose between his job and the truth, the province punished for voting "wrong". Achebe's realism lies not in copying individuals but in capturing systems, pressures and temptations that are universally recognisable.

7.7 Linking Biography and Context to GCE "Background" Questions

GCE Paper 2 regularly sets background questions such as: "Discuss the political setting of Anthills of the Savannah" or "How does Achebe's experience of post-independence Africa shape the novel?"

METHOD **Using background knowledge in essays**

1. Start from the text: identify the passage, character or theme the question targets.
2. Deploy context selectively: bring in biography or history only where it illuminates the point (e.g. the referendum echoes real life-president schemes in post-independence Africa).
3. Pair every contextual claim with textual evidence: name the scene, the character, the chapter.
4. Analyse, don't narrate: explain how the context deepens meaning — never let history replace literary analysis.
5. Respect the fiction: write "Kangan", not "Nigeria".

WORKED EXAMPLE 7 **Worked GCE-style paragraph: the political setting**

Question: "The political setting of Anthills of the Savannah reflects the realities of post-independence Africa." Discuss.

SOLUTION

Model paragraph: Achebe grounds his fiction in the political history of post-independence Africa, where the hopes of the 1960s collapsed into coups and one-man rule. Kangan, his fictional West African state, is governed by His Excellency Sam, a soldier who seized power and now seeks, through a national referendum, to be made

President for Life — a scheme instantly recognisable to readers who watched real African presidents-for-life entrench themselves in the decades after independence. Achebe's own experience of Nigeria's coups and military regimes gives the portrait its authenticity: the cabinet meeting of Chapter 1, where ministers compete to flatter Sam rather than advise him, dramatises the sycophancy that sustains dictatorship. Crucially, Achebe measures the regime by its treatment of the powerless: the drought-stricken province of Abazon, punished for voting against the President, embodies the neglected rural masses of the continent. Thus the political setting is not decorative background but the novel's moral framework — the arena in which friendship, truth and conscience are tested.

EXERCISE 7 **Practice: background and text**

Write two paragraphs answering: "Show how Achebe's biography and the history of post-independence Africa contribute to the meaning of Anthills of the Savannah." Each paragraph must contain one contextual point and one precise textual reference.

SOLUTION **Practice: background and text**

A strong answer might argue: (1) Achebe's self-conception as a teacher explains the novel's moral design — Ikem's editorials and his fate dramatise the duty of the intellectual to speak truth to power, a duty Achebe himself embraced by criticising Nigerian misrule. (2) The history of coups and one-party states explains the plot's machinery: Sam's referendum, the censorship of the National Gazette, and the punishment of Abazon all mirror documented practices of African military regimes of the 1960s–1980s, while Kangan's fictional status universalises the warning. Credit any answer that pairs context with textual evidence and writes "Kangan" rather than "Nigeria".

KEY POINTS **Key points of Section 7**

- Achebe (Ogidi, 1930–2013), author of Things Fall Apart, is the "father of African literature" and conceives the novelist as a teacher.
- His art evolved from the colonial encounter to post-colonial disillusionment: in Anthills, the enemy is internal — dictatorship and failed leadership.
- The historical framework is the Africa of coups, one-party states, censorship and neglected provinces (1960s–1980s).
- Kangan is a fictional state with roman à clef elements; never call it Nigeria in an essay.
- The regime's pillars: Sam's life-presidency referendum, the Abazon crisis, and the in-

ner circle of Chris, Ikem and Beatrice.

- Background questions demand context plus textual evidence in every paragraph.

With this biographical and historical foundation in place, we are ready to enter the novel itself. In Section 8 we step inside the Cabinet meeting of Chapter 1, follow Ikem's editorial, and watch the first cracks appear in the friendship between Sam, Chris and Ikem.

8 SECTION 8: ANTHILLS OF THE SAVANNAH — CHAPTERS 1–6: CABINET, EDITORIAL, FRIENDSHIP, PRESS AND THE PEOPLE'S VOICE

In Section 7 we met Chinua Achebe, the novelist as teacher and moral witness, and situated Anthills of the Savannah (1987) within the turbulent history of post-independence Nigeria — a history that echoes loudly in Cameroon's own experience of one-party rule, military coups and the struggle for a free press. We now step inside the novel itself. The opening chapters plunge us into two interlocking worlds: the cabinet room of the Presidential Palace in Bassa, where His Excellency rehearses his growing paranoia, and the newsroom of the National Gazette, where Ikem Osodi crafts editorials that sting like whips. Between them moves Chris Oriko, the Commissioner for Information, trying to mediate a friendship that power is steadily dissolving. These chapters are a masterclass in **true-to-life representation**: every dialogue, every proverb, every shift of narrative perspective feels like a scene we might witness in Yaoundé or Douala.

WARNING **A Note on Quotation Discipline**

Anthills of the Savannah is a long novel and GCE candidates often misquote it. In this course we quote only short phrases that are safe, and otherwise paraphrase. In the examination, an accurate paraphrase with a precise chapter reference earns more credit than an invented "quotation". Train yourself to write: "as the Abazon elder tells Chris in his great speech on the story…" rather than fabricating lines.

8.1 Chapter 1 — The Cabinet Meeting: Power, Paranoia and the Abazon Question

The novel opens not with a bang but with a silence — the heavy, performative silence of a cabinet meeting. His Excellency (Sam) presides, a man who has internalised the dictator's first rule: trust no one. The ministers perform sycophancy like a ritual dance; only Chris Oriko, the Commissioner for Information, and one or two others show flickers of independent thought. Achebe's satire is surgical: we watch ministers compete to agree with the Head of State before he has even finished speaking.

DEFINITION **Sycophancy in the Dictator's Court**

Sycophancy is the practice of flattering powerful people in order to gain advantage or simply to survive. In Anthills, it is not merely a moral failing but a survival strategy: ministers praise the Head of State's "vision" while privately fearing him. Achebe shows that sycophancy corrodes language itself — words lose their meaning and become instruments of appeasement. This is why the recovery of truthful language (Ikem's editorials, the elder's proverbs) is the novel's central moral project.

The political centre of the chapter is the **Abazon question**. Abazon, a drought-stricken province, has sent a delegation of elders to the capital to plead for help — water, roads, relief. His Excellency refuses to receive them, interpreting their peaceful petition as political rebellion, especially because Abazon voted against him in the referendum that made him President for life. The delegation's patient, dignified presence in the city embodies the **voice of the common people** — unarmed but morally formidable.

EXEMPLE **Reading the Cabinet Scene**

Notice three details a GCE answer should mention:

- Setting as character: the sealed, air-conditioned cabinet room symbolises an elite insulated from the dust and heat of Abazon.
- Dialogue as exposure: each minister's speech reveals cowardice; characterisation is achieved almost entirely through what is said and left unsaid.
- Sam's suspicion of Chris: already in this chapter the Head of State watches his old friend with distrust — the first visible crack in the trio.

8.2 Chapter 2 — Ikem's Editorial: The Crusading Journalist and the "Hymn to the Sun"

If Chapter 1 is the world of power, Chapter 2 is the world of the **word**. Ikem Osodi, editor of the state-owned National Gazette, is introduced through his craft. His most famous piece, the lyrical Hymn to the Sun, is a prose-poem inspired by the sun-scorched people of Abazon: it celebrates the dignity and endurance of ordinary folk while implicitly indicting a regime that hoards resources and abandons its own citizens.

DEFINITION **Editorial**

An editorial is a newspaper article expressing the publication's official opinion on an issue. In Anthills, Ikem's editorials are not mere opinions; they are acts of resistance. He uses the Gazette as a platform to speak truth to power, knowing each edition may be his last.

Ikem's style is lyrical, satirical and deeply rooted in Igbo oral tradition. He believes the writer in

Africa must be "the complaining voice" of the people — a teacher, not a courtier.

KEY POINTS **Key Features of Ikem's Writing**

- Proverbial and oral resources: draws on Igbo wisdom to legitimise critique.
- Direct address and solidarity: speaks to and for ordinary people, not over their heads.
- Irony and satire: mocks the regime's grandiose titles and empty rhetoric.
- Moral courage: written despite censorship pressure and the known fate of outspoken journalists.

8.3 Chapter 3 — How Friends Become Enemies: The Corrosion of the Trio

This chapter is the emotional and structural heart of the first movement. Through recollection, Achebe reconstructs the schoolboy bond between Sam, Chris and Ikem, formed at **Lord Lugard College**, the elite colonial boarding school where the three met. They were brilliant, idealistic, inseparable — the future leaders of their nation, or so it seemed. Sam went on to military training at Sandhurst in England; Chris into the civil service; Ikem into literature and journalism. When the military coup brought Sam to power, his two old friends joined his government, believing they could steer it towards justice.

PROPERTY **The Three Responses to Dictatorship**

Achebe maps three archetypal responses onto the trio (a framework examiners reward):

- Sam (Power): embraces the logic of the strongman; power becomes an end in itself; paranoia isolates him.
- Ikem (Word): chooses the intellectual's vocation — witness, critique, prophecy; refuses compromise.
- Chris (Compromise): tries to mediate, to "work from within"; his tragedy is that compromise with tyranny proves impossible.

The breakdown is not sudden but processual. Trace it in stages:

1. **Shared idealism** at Lord Lugard College.
2. **Divergent paths** after school: army, civil service, journalism.
3. **The coup** that brings Sam to power — Chris and Ikem initially serve him in good faith.
4. **Gradual estrangement:** Sam demands absolute loyalty; Ikem refuses to self-censor; Chris tries to bridge the gap.
5. **Open rupture:** Sam begins to treat Chris's loyalty as suspect and Ikem's independence as treason.

WORKED EXAMPLE 8 **Essay Question: "Trace the process by which the friendship between Sam, Chris and Ikem disintegrates in the opening chapters of the novel."**

Plan:

1. Introduction: the trio as a microcosm of post-colonial leadership — soldier, administrator, writer.
2. Stage 1 — Schoolboy unity at Lord Lugard College: shared privileges, shared dreams.
3. Stage 2 — Early solidarity after the coup: Chris and Ikem serve Sam's government hopefully.
4. Stage 3 — First cracks: Ikem's editorials, Sam's growing paranoia, Chris's uneasy mediation.
5. Stage 4 — The Abazon delegation as catalyst: Sam reads dissent as treason; Ikem publicises the people's cause; Chris is caught between them.
6. Stage 5 — Suspicion hardens into surveillance and accusation; intimacy ends.
7. Conclusion: the tragedy is not simple betrayal but the structural impossibility of friendship under dictatorship — power tolerates no equals.

Evidence to embed (paraphrase + chapter reference):

- The schoolboy bond at Lord Lugard College (Ch. 3).
- Sam's refusal to receive the Abazon elders and his reading of their petition as rebellion (Ch. 1).
- Ikem's Hymn to the Sun and his defiant editorials (Ch. 2).
- Sam's instructions that Chris be watched — loyalty replaced by surveillance (early chapters).

SOLUTION

Model opening paragraph: The disintegration of the friendship between Sam, Chris and Ikem is the spine of the first movement of Anthills of the Savannah. Achebe is careful to show that the collapse is a process, not an event. The three men begin as schoolmates at Lord Lugard College, bound by privilege and idealism; the coup that elevates Sam at first unites them in service. But power redefines the terms of friendship: Sam demands loyalty where he once sought counsel, Ikem's editorials turn from support to critique, and Chris's mediation comes to look, to the suspicious Head of State, like conspiracy. By the time surveillance replaces trust, the reader understands Achebe's bleak thesis — dictatorship does not merely break friendships; it makes friendship structurally impossible, because absolute power admits no equal.

8.4 Chapter 4 — The Role of the Press: The National Gazette as Contested Space

The newsroom scenes are among the most vivid in African literature. Achebe, who worked for years in broadcasting, knows the rhythms of deadlines, the smell of newsprint, the tension between political appointees and professional journalists. The National Gazette is **state-owned**, yet Ikem guards its editorial independence fiercely, turning a government mouthpiece into the nearest thing Kangan has to a public conscience.

EXPERIMENT **Guided Analysis: The Newsroom as a Mirror of African Governance**

Re-read the newsroom material in the early chapters and note:

- Physical details: the worn, under-resourced offices mirror the decay of public institutions under the regime.
- Language mix: standard English, Pidgin and proverb — the linguistic reality of the Nigerian (and Cameroonian) workplace.
- Power dynamics: political pressure from above, professional pride from below, and Ikem standing firm at the centre.

Task: Write one paragraph explaining how Achebe uses the newsroom setting to dramatise the struggle for free expression in a one-party state. Begin with a topic sentence, give two textual details, and end by linking the scene to the theme of language as power.

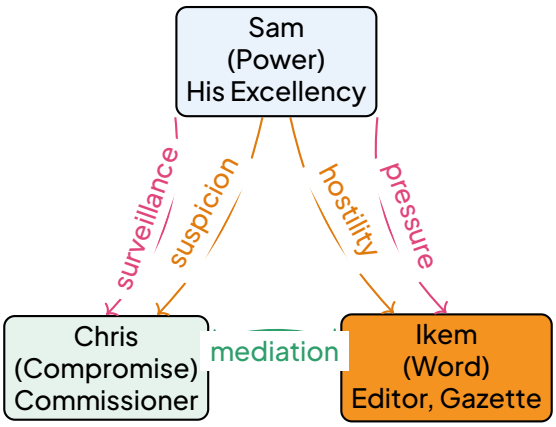
WARNING **Common Mistake: Confusing the Gazette with a Free Press**

Do not write that the National Gazette is an independent newspaper. It is state-owned, and Chris, as Commissioner for Information, is technically Ikem's boss. Ikem's heroism lies precisely in wresting a space for truth inside a state instrument. GCE examiners penalise candidates who miss this nuance.

8.5 Chapters 5–6 — Chris's Dilemma and the Voice of the People

Chris's dilemma is the dilemma of every decent person inside a corrupt system: stay and try to mitigate the damage, or resign and lose all influence? His contact with the Abazon delegation — ordinary, dignified people whom his own government treats as enemies — begins to strip away his self-deception. He sees that his "mediation" has so far protected the regime more than the people.

Meanwhile the regime's suspicion closes in. Sam's communications with Chris shift from the familiarity of old friendship to the menace of a master addressing a suspect servant. Chris realises that surveillance has penetrated even his private life — the point at which political disagreement becomes personal danger.



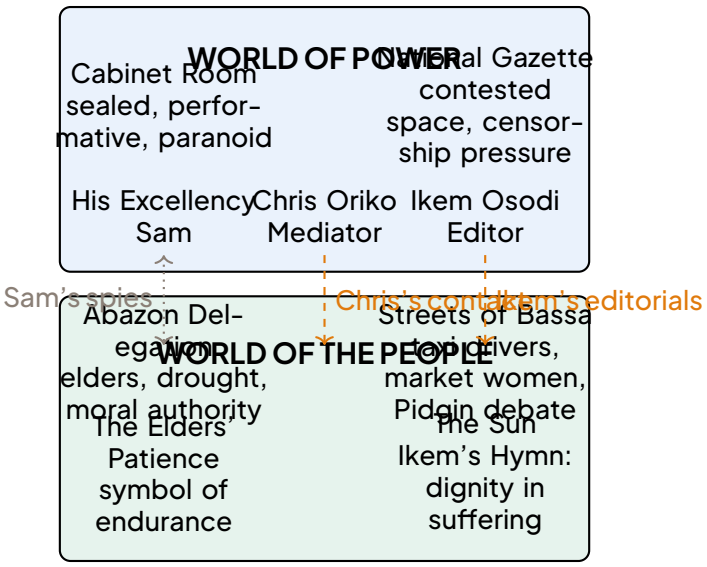
The triangle of trust in Chapters 1–6: green marks Chris's mediation; pink marks the regime's turn to surveillance and open pressure.

Simultaneously, the novel widens its lens to the **world of the people**: taxi drivers debating fuel shortages in Pidgin, market women trading rumour and news, the Abazon elders waiting patiently in the capital. Achebe uses **shifting points of view** — we see through Chris's eyes, then Ikem's, then an omniscient narrator who dips into the consciousness of ordinary citizens.

DEFINITION **Point of View (Narrative Perspective)**

Point of view is the narrative perspective through which events are filtered. Achebe rotates the focalisation among Chris, Ikem, Beatrice (later) and an omniscient voice that accesses the "common people". This technique:

- prevents any single authoritative voice (a democratic form for a democratic theme);
- forces the reader to assemble the truth from fragments;
- mirrors the novel's thesis that no single perspective can grasp the whole of a nation's crisis.



Two worlds in Chapters 1–6: the insulated elite above, the resilient populace below, and the fragile channels between them.

8.6 Narrative Technique in Chapters 1–6: A Toolkit for GCE Analysis

Achebe's craft in these chapters is a model for **literary appreciation**. Master the following method and apply it to every chapter of every set text.

METHOD **Chapter-by-Chapter Study Method**

For each chapter, make a structured note-card:

1. Events: What happens? (Bullet points, chronological.)
2. Characters revealed: Who speaks? What do we learn about their psychology?
3. Themes advanced: Power, truth, friendship, alienation, resistance, language.
4. Key moment: One scene or speech that encapsulates the chapter's core (paraphrase it accurately).
5. Narrative device: Point of view, proverb, Pidgin, flashback, irony, symbol.

Example for Chapter 3:

- Events: recollection of the schooldays at Lord Lugard College; the coup; the early days of Sam's rule.
- Characters: Sam's charisma and insecurity; Ikem's idealism; Chris's pragmatism.
- Themes: friendship versus power; colonial legacy; the corruption of youthful ideals.
- Key moment: the recognition that the old school bond cannot survive the new distri-

bution of power.

- Device: retrospective narration; irony in the gap between schoolboy dreams and adult reality.

DID YOU KNOW? **Cameroonian Parallel: The Cabinet Scene in Our Context**

Cameroonian students will recognise the cabinet scene: the leader's long silences, the ministers' choreographed praise, the sudden sidelining of a dissenting voice. Cameroon's own history — the one-party decades, the press laws, the debates over decentralisation and the Anglophone crisis — gives Anthills an uncomfortable immediacy. When you write about Kangan, you are also holding up a mirror to our own public life. Examiners reward candidates who show this relevance briefly and always return to the text.

8.7 True-to-Life Representation: The Cabinet Room and the Newsroom as Mirrors

Achebe's achievement in these chapters is to make the particular universal. The cabinet room is any African cabinet room where the leader's mood dictates policy. The newsroom is any state-owned newspaper where the editor walks a tightrope. The details — the worn offices, the Pidgin banter, the proverb that cuts through bureaucracy — are not decorative; they are evidence. This is the meaning of the chapter's title: characters are not symbols pasted onto a page but **true-to-life human representations**, drawn from observed behaviour and rendered with psychological precision.

KEY POINTS **Examinable Takeaways for Chapters 1–6**

- The trio (Sam, Chris, Ikem) structures the novel's exploration of power, compromise and resistance.
- Friendship's disintegration is a process, not an event — trace it through five stages.
- Ikem's editorials (especially the Hymn to the Sun) are the novel's moral compass; analyse their style (proverb, irony, direct address) as well as their content.
- Point of view rotates — do not attribute the omniscient narrator's insights to Achebe personally.
- Two worlds (elite / people) are juxtaposed spatially and linguistically; the novel's hope lies in their convergence.
- GCE favourite topics: "How friends become enemies", "The role of the press", "Chris's dilemma", "The Abazon delegation as symbol of the people".

8.8 Worked Exercise: Analysing the People's Voice

EXERCISE 8 **The Abazon Delegation as Moral Centre**

Answer the following questions in full sentences, with chapter references.

1. Why does His Excellency refuse to receive the Abazon delegation, and what does this refusal reveal about his understanding of power?
2. Contrast the language of the cabinet room with the language of the streets and the delegation. What is Achebe suggesting about truthful and corrupt speech?
3. "The Abazon elders are more powerful unarmed than the regime is with all its soldiers." Discuss this view with reference to Chapters 1–6.
4. Explain how Chris's contact with the delegation begins to change him. What does this suggest about Achebe's idea of moral awakening?

SOLUTION **Exercise: The Abazon Delegation as Moral Centre**

1. Refusal and its meaning: Sam refuses to receive the elders because he reads their petition as political defiance — Abazon voted against him in the referendum. This reveals a conception of power as personal: any request that does not flatter him is treason. A genuine leader hears petitions; a tyrant hears only loyalty or rebellion.
2. Contrast of languages: The cabinet room speaks in euphemism, flattery and evasion — language that conceals. The streets and the elders speak in Pidgin, proverb and direct statement — language that reveals. Achebe suggests that corrupt power corrupts speech, and that the recovery of truthful language is the first act of resistance (this is why Ikem the wordsmith matters).
3. Discussion: The elders possess moral power: patience, dignity, legitimacy, the sympathy of the reader and of characters like Chris and Ikem. The regime possesses only coercive power, which must be constantly exercised and therefore constantly displayed as insecure. The novel's structure supports the statement: the delegation's presence haunts the cabinet long after they are turned away, and their cause inspires Ikem's finest writing. (A balanced answer may concede that moral power alone does not bring water to Abazon — Achebe is no naive idealist.)
4. Chris's awakening: Contact with the delegation forces Chris to see Abazon as people rather than as a "file". His self-image as a useful mediator collapses; he begins to measure his service by its effects on the powerless. Achebe suggests that moral awakening comes not from argument but from encounter — meeting the people one's policies affect. This prepares Chris's later transformation (Section 10).

8.9 Transition to Section 9

We have now walked through the first movement of the novel: the cabinet's paranoia, the editor's courage, the friendship's slow death, the press under siege, and the people's quiet endurance. In Section 9 we follow the narrative into Chapters 7–12, where Beatrice Okoh enters fully, the friendship collapses into open betrayal, Ikem is silenced, and the state's violence steps out of the shadows. Keep your note-cards ready — the pattern of chapter-by-chapter analysis you have built here will serve you through the rest of the novel and into the examination hall.

9 SECTION 9: ANTHILLS OF THE SAVANNAH — CHAPTERS 7–12: BEATRICE'S CIRCLE, BETRAYAL, CENSORSHIP AND THE DEATH OF IKEM

In Section 8 we followed the widening crack inside the **cabinet**: Ikem's defiant editorials, the Abazon delegation's humiliation, and Chris's growing unease as he tries to mediate between his two oldest friends. In Chapters 7 to 12, Achebe moves the camera away from the Presidential Palace and into the private world of **Beatrice Okoh**, before bringing the political tension to its terrible climax: the destruction of Ikem Osodi. These chapters teach us two essential GCE lessons. First, that the personal and the political cannot be separated in a dictatorship — a dinner party can be as revealing as a cabinet meeting. Second, that a regime which fears **words** will always end by killing the man who speaks them.

9.1 Chapters 7–8: Beatrice's Flat, Her Circle and the Dinner Party

Observation. Imagine a young woman in Bassa, living alone in her own flat, holding a senior post in the civil service, receiving men as friends rather than as suitors or masters. In the Kangan of the novel — as in many African societies of the period — this is already a quiet revolution. Beatrice's flat becomes a kind of alternative court: a space where intelligence, wit and honesty circulate freely, in sharp contrast with the fear and flattery of the Palace.

Beatrice Okoh is a **Senior Assistant Secretary** in the Ministry of Finance, a London-educated woman, and the girlfriend of Chris Oriko. Through her flat and her friendships we meet the novel's network of women and younger characters, and we see the trio of friends — Sam, Chris, Ikem — from the outside, through a woman's lucid eyes. Achebe's decision to filter whole chapters through Beatrice's **point of view** is itself a statement: the nation must be seen not only from the Palace and the newsroom, but also from the home, where the consequences of power are actually lived.

EXEMPLE **The Dinner Party**

Beatrice hosts a small dinner at her flat. The conversation ranges over the state of the nation, the arrogance of His Excellency, and the behaviour of men in power. What strikes the reader is Beatrice's double vision: she mocks the men's vanity — she teases Chris and remembers Sam's awkwardness — yet she also recognises her own complicity. She admits that women like her have sometimes helped to inflate the male ego they criticise. This self-awareness is what makes her a **thematic centre** of the novel and not a decorative

girlfriend.

Tradition and female power. Achebe anchors Beatrice's modernity in something much older. Her first name connects her to her community's traditions, and the novel surrounds her with the mythology of **Idemili**, the deity (associated with the python and with water) whose cult embodies a female principle of power, balance and restraint. Beatrice is repeatedly linked to the figure of the **priestess**: she is the one who senses danger before the men do, who interprets, who mediates, and who will eventually preside over the naming ceremony at the novel's close. Achebe's point is subtle: genuine female power is not a Western import; it has deep roots in African tradition, and the modern educated woman can recover it. The novel thus answers a question the men never ask: where does moral authority live when politics has gone rotten? Achebe's answer is — with the women, and with the storytellers.

WARNING **Do Not Marginalise Beatrice**

A frequent GCE error is to treat Beatrice as a minor love interest — "Chris's girlfriend" — and to write essays on women in the novel that mention her only in passing. In fact she is one of the novel's three consciousnesses (with Chris and Ikem); several chapters are filtered through her point of view, and the novel ends in her hands. Neglecting her in an essay on women, tradition or hope in Anthills of the Savannah costs candidates heavily on the "knowledge of text" criterion.

Beatrice's characterisation rests on four pillars:

- **Education and professional competence** — she is a product of both Kangan and London, at ease in two worlds.
- **Independence** — she lives alone, loves Chris without being possessed by him, and refuses to be anyone's ornament.
- **Lucidity** — she diagnoses the men's arrogance early; she sees that Sam's transformation into "His Excellency" has poisoned the friendship long before Chris admits it.
- **Self-criticism** — unlike the men, she examines her own role in sustaining the very attitudes she condemns.

9.2 Chapters 9–10: The Breakdown of Friendship — Truth vs Power

Observation. When a friendship breaks between ordinary people, they simply stop calling each other. When it breaks between the Head of State and his two oldest friends, the whole nation trembles, because the quarrel is fought with newspapers, decrees and security men.

The confrontation between Sam and his friends reaches its point of no return. Sam, now fully enclosed in the role of **His Excellency**, interprets every criticism as disloyalty and every independent opinion as treason. Chris, as Commissioner for Information, is ordered to bring the National Gazette to heel — that is, to silence Ikem. Chris's refusal to do so wholeheartedly, and Ikem's refusal to censor himself, complete the **breakdown of the friendship** that began in their

schooldays at Lord Mayor's Lodge and is now ending in blood.

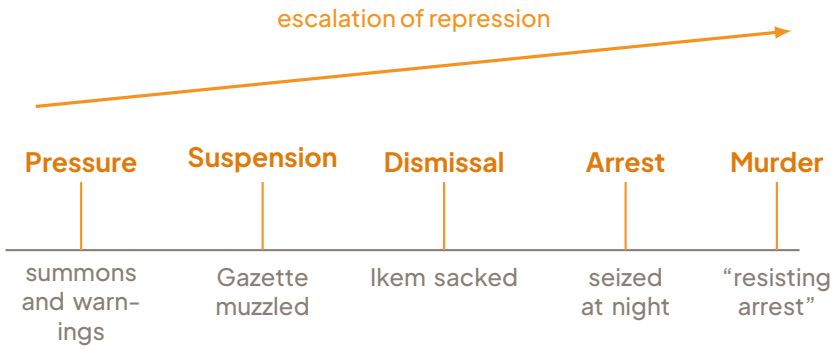
DEFINITION **Censorship**

Censorship is the suppression or control of speech, writing or information by those in power, in order to protect their authority from criticism. In Anthills of the Savannah it is the central weapon of the Kangan regime: the Gazette is muzzled, editors are summoned and threatened, and finally the inconvenient voice itself — Ikem — is suspended, dismissed and destroyed. Achebe shows that censorship is never only about newspapers: it is about controlling what a whole nation is allowed to think.

The regime's fear of words is almost superstitious. Sam does not fear guns — he fears **editorials**, poems and speeches, because words create the stories by which people judge their rulers. Ikem's suspension and then dismissal from the Gazette mark the moment when disagreement is reclassified as crime.

EXEMPLE **Truth vs Power in Practice**

Ikem's position can be summarised in his conviction that the writer's duty is to tell the truth to power — to be the nation's conscience, not its praise-singer. Sam's position is the opposite: the press exists to serve the state, and the state is himself. Between these two positions there is no compromise, and Chris is crushed trying to stand between them. In an essay, dramatise this as a triangle: Sam (power without truth), Ikem (truth without power), Chris (the mediator, loyal to both, destroyed by both).



The escalation ladder of the Kangan regime's repression: each failure of pressure produces a harsher stage, ending in murder disguised as law enforcement.

9.3 Chapters 11–12: Betrayal and the Death of Ikem

The Abazon speech. Invited to address students, Ikem speaks — and the regime's machinery of distortion goes to work. His words about the plight of Abazon and the duties of rulers are

twisted by the state media into an accusation that he incited the crowd and insulted the Head of State. The **betrayal** is double: the state betrays the truth of what he said, and Sam betrays the friend he once was. Ikem is arrested at night, and the official announcement claims he was shot while resisting arrest — the classic lie of every police state, which Achebe gives us in its naked, bureaucratic cynicism.

DEFINITION **The Martyr Figure**

A **martyr figure** is a character whose death for truth, justice or a cause gives moral meaning to a narrative. The martyr does not win in the plot but wins in the theme: his death exposes the wickedness of what killed him and obliges the survivors — and the reader — to take a stand. Ikem Osodi is the martyr of Anthills of the Savannah: silenced as a journalist, murdered as a man, he becomes more powerful dead than alive, because his death converts private corruption into public shame.

METHOD **Analysing a Character's Death**

To write a first-class paragraph on the death of a major character such as Ikem, proceed in four steps:

1. Causes — who kills him, and why? (The regime, because his words threatened its legitimacy.)
2. Narration — how is the death told? (Indirectly, through announcement and reaction; Achebe denies us the scene itself, imitating the secrecy of state murder.)
3. Symbolic weight — what does the death mean? (The murder of the word, of friendship, of the nation's conscience; the poet killed by the emperor.)
4. Effects on others — what changes? (Chris is radicalised and must flee; Beatrice becomes the bearer of memory; the reader's judgement on Sam becomes final.)

WORKED EXAMPLE 9 **GCE-Style Paragraph: The Significance of Ikem's Death**

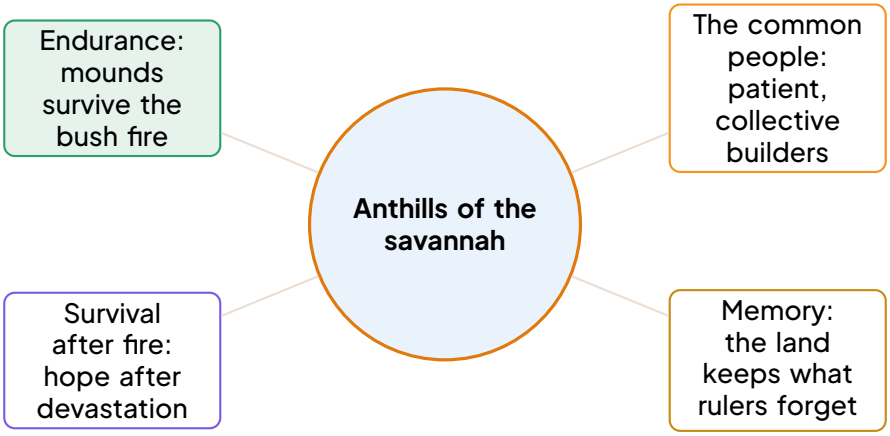
Question: "The death of Ikem Osodi is the turning point of Anthills of the Savannah." Discuss.

SOLUTION

Model paragraph. Ikem's death is the hinge on which the whole novel turns, because it transforms a political quarrel into a moral catastrophe. Before it, the conflict between Sam and his friends could still be read as a crisis of loyalty that dialogue might repair; after it, the regime stands exposed as a murderer of its own best citizens. Achebe heightens the effect by refusing to narrate the killing directly: we receive it through the offi-

cial lie that Ikem was "shot while resisting arrest", a formula whose bureaucratic calm is more chilling than any description of violence. Symbolically, the murder of the editor is the murder of the word itself — the regime that feared editorials has killed the editorialist, confirming Ikem's own teaching that words are the one weapon tyranny cannot tolerate. Structurally, the death propels the second half of the novel: Chris is forced into flight and towards his own death, while Beatrice inherits the role of witness and priestess who will preside over the fragile hope of the naming ceremony. Ikem thus dies in the plot but triumphs in the theme: his martyrdom judges Sam, awakens Chris and sanctifies the novel's closing faith in the common people.

9.4 Symbolism and Style: Anthills, Sun, Drought and Rain



Symbol web around the title image: the anthills of the savannah as endurance, the common people, survival and memory.

The title image, evoked in these chapters, comes from the sight of **anthills** standing blackened but intact after a bush fire has swept the savannah. The rulers pass like the fire; the people, like the anthills, endure. Around this central symbol Achebe organises a coherent pattern of **natural imagery**:

Image	Literal presence	Symbolic meaning
Sun	The pitiless heat over Kangan	Oppressive, unblinking power; exposure
Drought	The dry season; Abazon's water crisis	Political sterility; the people's abandonment
Rain	Longed for, delayed, finally associated with renewal	Relief, cleansing, the hope that ends the novel
Anthills	Mounds surviving the savannah fire	The endurance of the common people

Notice the stylistic economy: Achebe does not tell us that the regime is sterile and the people

resilient; he makes the weather and the landscape say it. This is the "showing, not telling" that examiners reward when you comment on style.

EXPERIMENT **Role Play: Dramatising Ikem's Abazon Speech**

In groups of four, stage Ikem's address and its aftermath:

1. Speaker — delivers a two-minute version of the speech, insisting on the dignity of Abazon and the duty of rulers to serve.
2. State radio announcer — "reports" the speech, deliberately distorting two of its sentences into provocation.
3. His Excellency — reacts to the report, deciding on arrest.
4. Chorus of students — comments on what was actually said versus what was reported.

Then discuss: what rhetorical features (direct address, proverbs, appeals to shared suffering) made the speech dangerous to the regime? How does performing the distortion help you understand Achebe's theme of **censorship**? This exercise trains exactly the skills GCE questions on "truth vs power" demand.

KEY POINTS **Key Points of Chapters 7–12**

- Beatrice's flat is an alternative moral space; she is a **thematic centre**, linked to the deity **Idemili** and the priestess role.
- The friendship collapses because Sam demands loyalty instead of truth; **censorship** of the Gazette is the regime's central weapon.
- Ikem's Abazon speech is distorted, and he is arrested and murdered — "shot while resisting arrest" — becoming the novel's **martyr**.
- His death is the structural turning point: it radicalises Chris and consecrates Beatrice as witness.
- Symbolism: anthills (endurance of the people), sun and drought (sterile power), rain (renewal).

EXERCISE 9 **Practice**

1. "Beatrice Okoh is the moral centre of Anthills of the Savannah." Discuss with close reference to Chapters 7 and 8.
2. Trace the stages by which the Kangan regime moves from pressure to murder in its

treatment of Ikem. What does this escalation reveal about the nature of the regime?

3. Write a paragraph analysing the symbolic function of drought and rain imagery in the novel.

SOLUTION **Exercise 1 — guidance**

A strong answer will: (i) present Beatrice's independence and education; (ii) analyse the dinner party as a space of free speech opposed to the Palace; (iii) explain the Idemili/priestess connection and its rooting of female power in tradition; (iv) note her self-criticism, which distinguishes her from the men; (v) conclude that her point of view shapes the reader's judgement and that the novel's hope is finally entrusted to her. Quote or closely paraphrase her observations on male arrogance, and avoid the trap of reducing her to "Chris's girlfriend".

10 SECTION 10: ANTHILLS OF THE SAVANNAH — CHAPTERS 13–18 AND CRITICAL SYNTHESIS

In Section 9 we witnessed the unravelling of the trio's friendship: Ikem's editorial provoked the regime, the Cabinet meeting exposed the moral bankruptcy of the leadership, and the state's machinery of censorship and violence claimed Ikem's life. Chris, once the compliant Commissioner for Information, is now a fugitive. The narrative shifts from the corridors of power to the dusty roads of the north, and finally to a compound where women gather to name a child. This section traces that descent and ascent, showing how Achebe transforms personal tragedy into a collective vision of renewal.

10.1 Chapters 13–14: The Fall of the Commissioner and Chris on the Run

EXPERIMENT **The Commissioner's Last Days**

Chapter 13 opens with Major Ossai's brutal interrogation of Chris. Ossai, the embodiment of mindless military power, slaps Chris and threatens him with the "green bottle" — a symbol of the regime's arbitrary cruelty. Chris realises that the "green bottle" is not merely a weapon but a metaphor: the regime bottles up the people's aspirations and then shatters the bottle on their heads. Chris escapes with the help of his driver, Emmanuel, and the sympathetic soldier, Abdul. The flight north begins: disguise as a trader, a bus journey through checkpoints, the constant fear of recognition. Chapter 14 deepens the portrait of a man stripped of official identity, forced to rely on the kindness of ordinary people — the very "masses" he once ignored from his air-conditioned office.

KEY POINTS **Key Developments in Chapters 13–14**

- Major Ossai rises as the regime's enforcer; his violence is indiscriminate and personal.
- Chris's flight is both physical and moral: he sheds the Commissioner's skin to recover his humanity.
- The bus journey becomes a microcosm of Kangan: soldiers extort bribes, passengers endure in silence, but solidarity emerges in shared suffering.
- Chris meets Braimoh, a former student leader, who challenges him: "You people at the top… you don't know we exist." This encounter catalyses Chris's final education.

10.2 Chapters 15–16: Chris in Abazon — Reception, Demonstration, and Death

EXPERIMENT **Abazon: The People's Judgment**

Chris arrives in Abazon, the drought-stricken region the regime has neglected. The people receive him not as a fugitive official but as a witness. Students organise a demonstration demanding water and justice; Chris speaks to them, acknowledging his complicity: "I have been part of the system that brought you this suffering." The demonstration is dispersed by a drunken policeman who shoots Chris dead. The irony is devastating: Chris survives the regime's assassins only to be killed by a random agent of the very chaos the regime created.

DEFINITION **Open / Ironic Ending**

An **open/ironic ending** is a conclusion that resolves the protagonist's personal arc while leaving the nation's political future uncertain. The irony lies in the discrepancy between the intended target of state violence (Chris as a political threat) and the actual agent of his death (a drunken policeman acting on impulse). The regime's climate of lawlessness claims its own former servant.

WARNING **The "Green Bottle" Scene — Not Mere Symbolism**

Do not treat the "green bottle" as a decorative symbol. In Chapter 13, Ossai smashes a green bottle on the table and threatens to use the jagged edge on Chris. Later, the drunken policeman who kills Chris is described as holding a green bottle. The recurrence binds the regime's calculated torture to the street-level violence it spawns. In an exam, argue that the green bottle represents the continuity of violence from the presidential

lodge to the village bar.

WORKED EXAMPLE 10 **Analysing the Irony of Chris's Death**

Question: How does Achebe use irony to underscore the novel's central themes in Chris's death? Solution:

1. Situational irony: Chris flees the regime's planned assassination (Ossai's hit squad) but dies at the hands of a drunken policeman — a nobody empowered by the regime's breakdown of order.
2. Dramatic irony: The reader knows Chris has achieved moral clarity ("I am no longer a Commissioner; I am a human being"), but the policeman sees only a stranger to rob.
3. Thematic irony: Chris dies for the people of Abazon (he came to witness their suffering), yet his death changes nothing immediately. The regime persists. This forces the reader to locate hope not in heroic sacrifice but in the slow, communal work of the naming ceremony.
4. Exam tip: Quote Chris's final thought: "The only thing worth dying for… is the truth." Then contrast with the sordid reality of his death — shot in a scuffle over a bottle. The gap is the irony.

10.3 Chapters 17–18: Women as Survivors — The Naming Ceremony

EXPERIMENT **The Compound: A Counter-Politics**

After Chris's death, the narrative returns to Beatrice's compound. Elewa (Ikem's partner) has given birth to a baby girl. Beatrice, Elewa, and Aina (Chris's lover) gather with other women to name the child. The men — Emmanuel, Abdul, the students — wait outside. The ceremony is conducted entirely by women. They name the baby Amaechina — "May the path never close." This is not a retreat into tradition; it is a deliberate act of **counter-politics**: the women claim the power to name the future, a power the male politicians have abused.

PROPERTY **The Naming Ceremony as Structural Inversion**

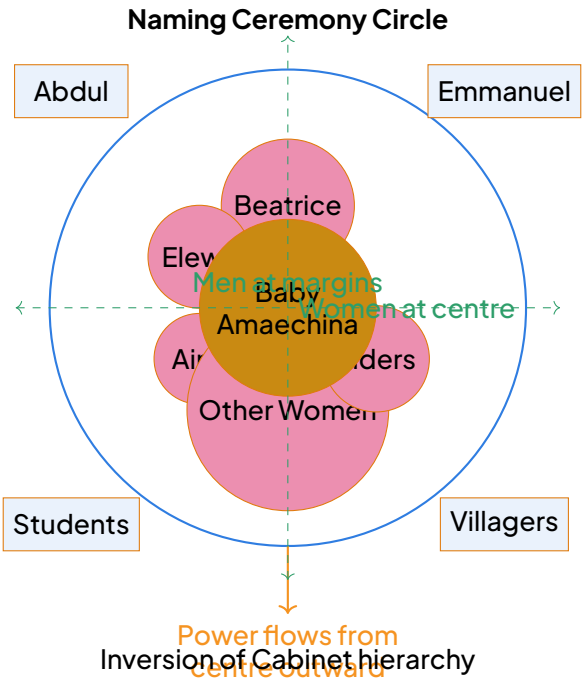
- Spatial inversion: The Cabinet room (Chapter 1) was male, hierarchical, sterile. The compound circle is female, communal, generative.
- Linguistic inversion: Official language (English, bureaucratic, deceptive) yields to

Igbo proverbs, pidgin, and the language of the body (ululation, dance).

- Temporal inversion: The regime's time is the eternal present of crisis. The ceremony invokes ancestors and future generations — "the path never closes."

WARNING **Warning: The Naming Ceremony Is Not Escapism**

A common student error is to read the ending as a comforting retreat into "African tradition" away from political reality. Wrong. Achebe writes in The Education of a British-Protected Child: "The story is our escort; without it we are blind." The ceremony is political action: it asserts that the nation's continuity depends on women's reproductive and narrative labour, not on the "big men" who trade the country's future for personal gain. In your essays, argue that Beatrice's final words — "We have done something… we have named the child" — are a declaration of agency in the face of state failure.



The naming ceremony circle: women at the centre (pink), baby at the core (gold), men at the margins (blue). The dashed lines show the structural inversion of the Cabinet's male hierarchy.

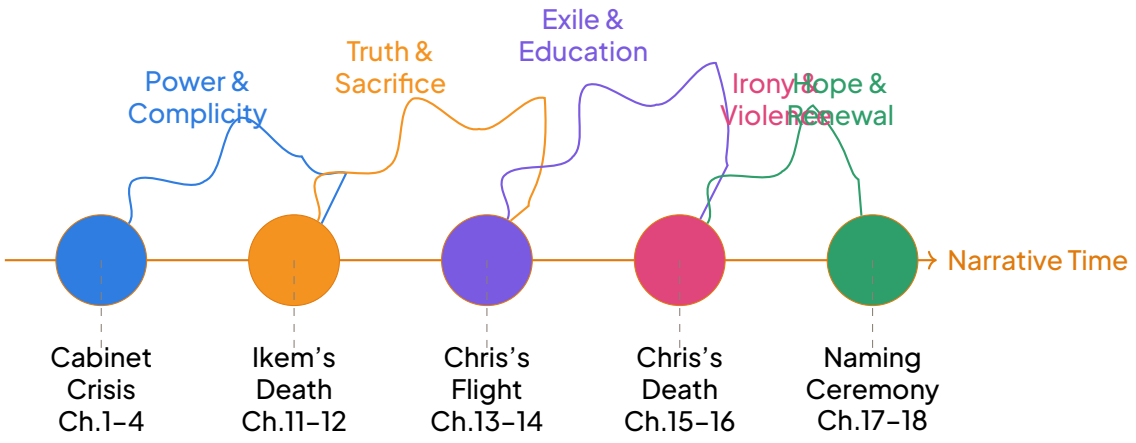
10.4 Narrative Structure and Plot Development

DEFINITION **Triple Focalisation**

Achebe employs **triple focalisation**: the narrative shifts among three consciousnesses — Chris (the insider-outsider), Ikem (the idealist intellectual), and Beatrice (the grounded witness). This technique prevents a single authoritative perspective and mirrors the novel's argument that truth is polyphonic.

KEY POINTS **Movement of the Plot: Three Spaces**

- The Cabinet Room (Chapters 1–4): Enclosed, air-conditioned, male, performative. Language masks power.
- The Street / The Road (Chapters 5–16): Open, dusty, dangerous, mixed. Language becomes testimony (Ikem's editorials, Chris's conversations on the bus).
- The Compound (Chapters 17–18): Domestic, female, generative. Language becomes ritual (naming, proverbs, song).



Plot arc of Anthills of the Savannah: from Cabinet crisis through Ikem's death, Chris's flight and death, to the naming ceremony. The coloured arcs trace the thematic trajectory from power to hope.

10.5 Thematic Exploration and Author's Style

KEY POINTS **Major Themes in the Final Chapters**

- Leadership Failure: The "big men" (Sam, Ossai, the Cabinet) confuse power with ser-

vice. Chris's journey exposes the emptiness of their rhetoric.

- Corruption as Atmosphere: Not just bribes but a climate where a drunken policeman can kill with impunity.
- Role of Women: Beatrice, Elewa, Aina embody **survivance** — the capacity to endure and create meaning. They are not "characters" in the male plot; they are the plot's alternative logic.
- Power of Story: "The story is our escort." The naming ceremony is a story enacted. Achebe's novel itself performs this function for the reader.

PROPERTY **Achebe's Stylistic Toolkit in Chapters 13–18**

- Proverbs: "When the moon is shining the cripple becomes hungry for a walk." (Chris on the bus) — desire for justice persists even in the disabled body politic.
- Pidgin: The bus conversations, the policeman's slang — ground the narrative in the linguistic reality of Kangan (Nigeria).
- Irony: The "green bottle" recurrence; Chris's death by a nobody.
- Symbolism: The drought in Abazon (political aridity); the baby girl (future unconstrained by patriarchal succession); the anthill (resilience, collective labour).
- Free Indirect Discourse: Slides between narrator and character consciousness, especially in Beatrice's final reflections.

10.6 Revision of Sample GCE Past Questions (Papers 1 and 2)

METHOD **Prose Appreciation Steps — For Paper 2 Context Questions**

1. Locate the extract precisely: Chapter, situation, speaker, addressee. (e.g., "Chapter 17, Beatrice speaking to Elewa after the naming ceremony.")
2. Summarise the content: What is happening? What is being said? (2–3 sentences max.)
3. Analyse language and devices: Diction, imagery, tone, syntax, proverb use, pidgin, irony, symbolism. Link each device to its effect.
4. Evaluate significance to the whole work: How does this passage develop character, theme, or structure? Does it echo or contrast with earlier moments?

5. Conclude with a judgement: What does the passage reveal about Achebe's vision?

EXEMPLE **Model Plan: Paper 2 Context Question**

Question: Read the following extract from Chapter 18 (the naming ceremony) and comment on its significance to the novel as a whole. Plan:

1. Context: Chapter 18, Beatrice's compound, after Chris's death. Women name Elewa's daughter Amaechina. Men excluded.
2. Content: Beatrice reflects on the ceremony's meaning; the women's ululation; the baby's name "May the path never close."
3. Language/Devices:
   - Proverb: "The world is a dancing masquerade…" — fluidity of identity.
   - Pidgin/English code-switching — inclusivity.
   - Symbolism: Baby girl (patriarchy disrupted), circle (communal equality).
   - Irony: Men wait outside — inversion of Cabinet.
4. Significance:
   - Thematic climax: women as survivors / counter-politics.
   - Structural climax: movement from Cabinet to compound complete.
   - Author's vision: story as escort; hope rooted in female community, not male heroics.
5. Conclusion: The passage is the novel's ethical centre. It does not "solve" Kangan's politics but insists on the moral ground from which a solution must grow.

EXEMPLE **Model Plan: Paper 1 Essay Question**

Question: "In Anthills of the Savannah, Achebe suggests that the only hope for the nation lies in the hands of women." Discuss. Plan:

1. Introduction: Thesis — the novel does not offer a simple "women save the nation" fable; rather, it contrasts male power politics (destructive) with female communal practice (generative), locating hope in the latter's ethos, not its immediate political efficacy.
2. Male failure: Sam, Ossai, the Cabinet — violence, isolation, sterility. Chris's complicity and late awakening.

3. Ikem's limitation: His intellectual heroism is masculine, individualistic; he cannot bridge the gap to the masses.
4. Women's alternative: Beatrice's evolution from "priestess" to active agent; Elewa's grounded resilience; Aina's bridge between worlds. The naming ceremony as praxis.
5. Nuance: The women do not seize state power. Their hope is **longue durée** — cultural, narrative, reproductive. The novel ends with "the path never closes," not "the revolution succeeds."
6. Style as argument: Proverbs, pidgin, triple focalisation, structural inversion — the form enacts the content.
7. Conclusion: Achebe redefines hope as the persistence of community and story, not the capture of the state. Women embody this persistence.

WORKED EXAMPLE 11 **Worked Prose Appreciation: Extract from Chapter 17**

Extract: "Beatrice watched the women… She felt a sudden sharp pang of envy… She wanted to be part of it, to be one of them, to ululate and dance and be a woman among women." (Chapter 17) Appreciation:

1. Context: Beatrice, middle-class, educated, has always felt alienated from "traditional" women. Now, after Chris's death, she craves the communal solidarity she once despised.
2. Characterisation: Beatrice's envy is not petty; it is a recognition of her own lack. Her journey from observer to participant mirrors Chris's journey from Commissioner to human being.
3. Language: "Sharp pang" — physical metaphor for emotional realisation. "Ululate and dance" — verbs of embodied ritual, contrasting with her earlier static "priestess" role. Repetition of "woman among women" — identity claimed through community.
4. Themes: Female solidarity as survival; class barrier broken by shared grief; the personal as political.
5. Significance: This moment prepares the reader for Beatrice's active role in the naming ceremony. It completes her arc: she stops interpreting the story and starts living it.

10.7 Guidelines in Prose Appreciation (Paper 1 and Paper 2)

DEFINITION **Prose Appreciation**

Prose appreciation is a structured commentary on a prose passage covering content (what happens), characterisation (who speaks, how they are revealed), style (language, devices, narrative technique), and significance (contribution to themes, structure, and the work's overall vision). It is not a paraphrase; it is an argument about how the passage means.

METHOD **Checklist for Prose Appreciation — Exam Conditions**

1. Contextualise: Chapter, moment, speaker. (1 minute)
2. Annotate: Underline 5–6 key words/phrases/devices. (2 minutes)
3. Structure your response: Context → Content → Style/Devices → Significance. (Plan 3 minutes)
4. Write: Integrate quotations; avoid "the author uses…" — say "Achebe uses… to show…". (15–20 minutes)
5. Check: Did I answer the specific question? Did I link to the whole novel? (2 minutes)

WARNING **Common Traps in Prose Appreciation**

- Paraphrase trap: Retelling the story without analysis. Solution: Every sentence must contain an analytical verb (reveals, underscores, ironises, contrasts, echoes).
- Device-spotting trap: Listing metaphors without explaining their effect. Solution: "The metaphor of the 'green bottle' binds state torture to street violence, showing…"
- Context vacuum: Analysing the extract as a standalone piece. Solution: Always reference at least one other moment in the novel (echo, contrast, development).
- Ignoring narrative voice: Forgetting that the narrator mediates. Solution: Note free indirect discourse, irony, focalisation shifts.

DID YOU KNOW? **Achebe's Own Reading of the Ending**

In a 1988 interview, Achebe said of the naming ceremony: "It is a very small thing, naming a child. But in a society where the big things have gone wrong, the small things become absolutely crucial." This is the key to the novel's politics: the "small things" — story, nam-

ing, female community — are the only things the regime cannot fully colonise. They are the anthills that survive the savannah fire.

EXERCISE 10 **Practice Questions for Self-Testing**

- Paper 2 style: Comment on the significance of the "green bottle" motif in Chapters 13 and 15.
- Paper 1 style: "Chris's journey is the moral centre of the novel." How far do you agree?
- Paper 1 style: Discuss Achebe's use of triple focalisation in Anthills of the Savannah.
- Paper 2 style: Analyse the passage in Chapter 16 where Chris addresses the Abazon students. How does it reflect his transformation?
- Paper 1 style: "The novel's ending is hopeful but not optimistic." Discuss with reference to the naming ceremony.

SOLUTION **Exercise 1 — Green Bottle Motif**

Context: Chapter 13 (Ossai threatens Chris); Chapter 15 (drunken policeman holds a green bottle before shooting Chris). Analysis: The motif creates a structural parallel between state violence (Ossai) and its social consequence (the policeman). The bottle is green — colour of the regime's uniforms, colour of the "green" that should be life (Abazon's crops) but is shattered. The jagged edge = the regime's broken promises turned into weapons. Significance: It demonstrates Achebe's thesis: tyranny does not stay in the palace; it poisons the well. Chris's death by the bottle proves that the Commissioner cannot escape the system he served.

KEY POINTS **Final Synthesis: What the Novel Leaves Us**

- The "anthills" survive the savannah fire: story, community, female labour.
- Chris dies, but his death is not in vain if it teaches us to read the "green bottle" signs in our own societies.
- Beatrice's final act — naming — is the writer's act: to name is to claim a future.
- For the GCE: master the triple focalisation, the structural inversion (Cabinet → Compound), and the irony that hope is born not from the hero's survival but from the women's circle.

EXPERIMENT **Exam Simulation: Timed Prose Appreciation**

Set a timer for 25 minutes. Choose the extract from Chapter 18 where Beatrice says: "We have done something… we have named the child." Write a full appreciation following the 5-step method. Then compare with the model plan above. Repeat weekly until the steps are automatic.

11 SECTION 11: A DANCE OF THE FORESTS — SOYINKA'S BIOGRAPHY, BACKGROUND AND THE GATHERING OF THE TRIBES

11.1 From Achebe's Kangan to Soyinka's Forest: A Natural Transition

In Section 10 we closed our study of Anthills of the Savannah with the naming ceremony of baby Amaechina — a fragile ritual of hope performed in the ruins of a broken nation. Achebe's method was realist: he showed us a cabinet meeting, an editorial, a military checkpoint, and let us draw our own conclusions about power and betrayal. With Wole Soyinka's A Dance of the Forests we remain in West Africa and we remain preoccupied with the same great question — can a nation build a worthy future on a dishonest past? — but the method changes completely. Soyinka does not give us a realistic cabinet; he gives us a sacred forest, lame messengers, quarrelling gods, and dead ancestors who refuse to stay buried. Where Achebe holds up a mirror, Soyinka lights a ritual fire. Yet both writers insist on what this chapter calls **true-to-life human representation**: characters whose flaws, self-deceptions and moral choices are recognisably, uncomfortably human, whether they appear in a presidential palace or among the spirits of the dead.

11.2 Wole Soyinka: A Relevant Biography

Akinwande Oluwole Soyinka was born in 1934 in Abeokuta, in western Nigeria, into a Yoruba family steeped in both Christian schooling and traditional culture. This double inheritance — the mission school and the shrine, Shakespeare and the orishas — is the single most important key to his art. He studied at University College Ibadan and later at the University of Leeds in England, then worked with the Royal Court Theatre in London before returning to Nigeria, where he founded theatre companies and wrote the plays that made his reputation.

Three facts about Soyinka's life matter directly for this play and for the GCE:

- He is a **playwright, poet, essayist and political activist** at once. His art has never been separated from his public courage.
- He was **imprisoned without trial** by the Nigerian federal military authorities during the civil war period (from 1967 to 1969) for his outspoken attempts to mediate and his denunciation of atrocities. His prison writings testify to a lifelong refusal to flatter power.
- In **1986** he became the first African to receive the **Nobel Prize in Literature**, an honour that confirmed African drama's place on the world stage.

DID YOU KNOW? **The Writer Who Would Not Keep Quiet**

Soyinka's life illustrates a pattern we have now seen across our syllabus: like Ikem Osodi in Anthills of the Savannah, Soyinka believed that the writer's duty is to speak truth to power. Unlike Ikem, he survived his governments. His career reminds us that African literature is not entertainment alone; it is often an act of civic courage.

11.3 Background to the Play: A Warning, Not a Celebration

A Dance of the Forests was written for and performed at **Nigeria's independence celebrations in 1960**. This single fact is the foundation of almost every background question the GCE has asked on the play, so master it thoroughly.

The Nigerian authorities expected a festive pageant — a play glorifying the heroic African past to match the mood of national rejoicing. Soyinka gave them the opposite. Instead of celebrating glorious ancestors, his play drags the ancestors back on stage and puts them on trial. Instead of flattering the new nation, it warns that the crimes of the past — slavery, war, corruption, the betrayal of the weak — are alive in the present, committed by the very people now celebrating their freedom. The play's famous logic is that the living invited noble forefathers and received their own crimes in person.

WARNING **Not a Celebration of Tradition**

A very common examination error is to write that Soyinka "celebrates African tradition" in this play. He does not. Soyinka uses Yoruba tradition — its gods, its cosmology, its ritual forms — as an instrument of criticism directed at both the past and the present. The ancestors are not idealised; they are guilty. The living are not innocent; they are the same people reborn. Tradition in this play is a courtroom, not a museum.

KEY POINTS **Exam Tip: The 1960 Context**

Background questions on A Dance of the Forests almost always require the 1960 independence context. Prepare a short, solid paragraph: written for independence celebrations; expected to praise; chose instead to warn; the new nation must confront the crimes of its history or repeat them. This paragraph earns marks in Paper 2 essays on background, theme and relevance.

11.4 Yoruba Cosmology and Mythology in the Play

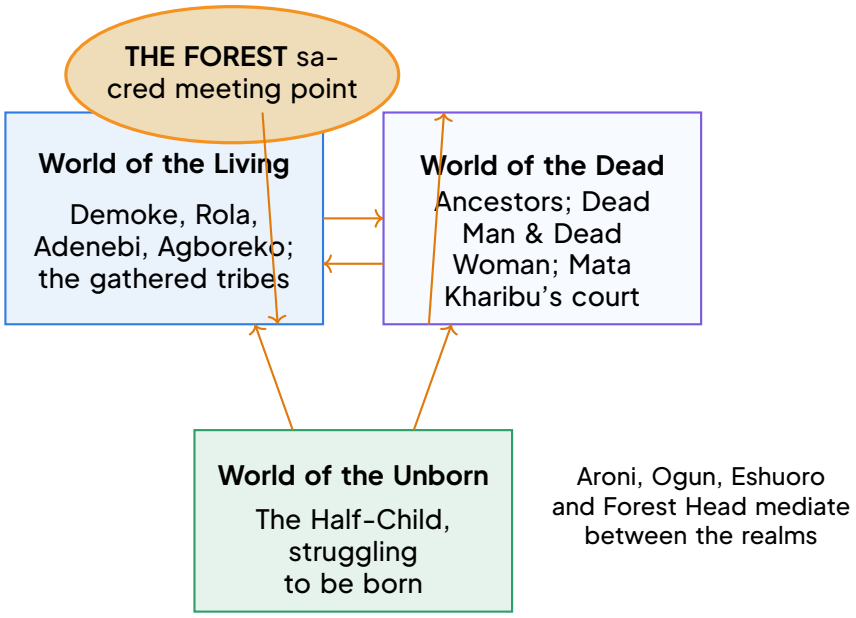
To read Soyinka without understanding his cosmology is to watch a masquerade and see only cloth. Yoruba thought imagines existence as a set of interrelated realms, constantly in communication:

DEFINITION **Yoruba Cosmology (as used in the play)**

Yoruba cosmology is the traditional Yoruba conception of the universe as a network of interrelated realms — the world of the **living**, the world of the **dead** (the ancestors), and the world of the **unborn** — mediated by gods (orishas) and spirits, with sacred spaces such as the forest serving as meeting points where the boundaries between the realms grow thin.

The principal supernatural figures you must know are:

- **Ogun**: the Yoruba god of iron, war, creativity and destruction — patron of carvers, hunters and drivers. Demoke, the carver, is his devotee. Ogun embodies the double edge of creation and violence.
- **Eshuoro**: a vengeful forest spirit, associated with mischief and malice, who resents the human presence and demands punishment during the trial.
- **Forest Head** (Obaneji in disguise): the supreme, patient judge of the forest, who presides over the confrontation between the living and their past.
- **Aroni**, the Lame One: the limping messenger and master of ceremonies who conducts the dead to the living.



Yoruba cosmology in A Dance of the Forests: three interrelated realms, with the forest as the sacred meeting point where the living are made to face the dead.

11.5 The Opening: The Gathering of the Tribes

The play opens with a festive occasion. The tribes of the living have assembled — drumming, dancing, feasting — to celebrate their community and, above all, to welcome back their glo-

rious ancestors, whom they have formally invited to grace the festival. This is the moment of national self-congratulation: the living expect noble, heroic forefathers whose splendour will reflect credit on themselves.

DEFINITION **The Gathering of the Tribes**

The **Gathering of the Tribes** is the festive assembly of the living that opens A Dance of the Forests. Summoned to celebrate communal glory, the tribes formally invite their illustrious ancestors to join the feast — and this summons triggers the play's central reversal: instead of glorious forefathers, the forest sends back the **Dead Man and the Dead Woman**, two restless spirits who embody the unacknowledged crimes of the past.

The reversal is devastating and deliberate. The Dead Man and the Dead Woman are not heroes; they are victims and accusers, returned from the court of Mata Kharibu some four centuries earlier, where they suffered the very evils — slavery, war, the abuse of power — that the living still practise. The living are horrified and try to drive them away. That gesture of rejection is the whole play in miniature: a community that wants celebration without memory, pride without repentance.

METHOD **Approaching Mythological Drama**

When a GCE question confronts you with Soyinka's dense symbolism, proceed in this order:

1. Identify the human situation first. Ask: who are these people, what do they want, what are they afraid of? (The tribes want glory; they fear guilt.)
2. Then decode the symbolic layer. Ask: what does the forest, the god, the mask or the dance stand for? (The forest = the collective conscience; the dead = repressed history.)
3. Then read the ritual layer. Ask: what ceremony is being performed or parodied — a festival, a trial, a dance, a sacrifice — and what does its failure or success mean?
4. Finally, connect to the 1960 context and to universal human behaviour. This is where the top marks are earned.

11.6 Aroni the Lame One

It is **Aroni**, the Lame One, who escorts the dead into the human gathering. He is the play's master of ceremonies and guide: he arranges the summons, directs the spirits, and leads the human quartet into the forest when the time comes for judgement. His **limp** is significant. In Yoruba thought, the messenger who travels between realms is often marked — physically imperfect — because he belongs fully to neither world. Aroni's lameness is the visible sign of his office: he walks with one foot, so to speak, among the living and one among the dead. When you meet him in a quotation, identify him as the threshold figure, the conductor of the confrontation the

living cannot escape.

11.7 The Central Situation: Confronting the Past

Strip away the gods and the masks, and the play's situation is starkly simple and true to life:

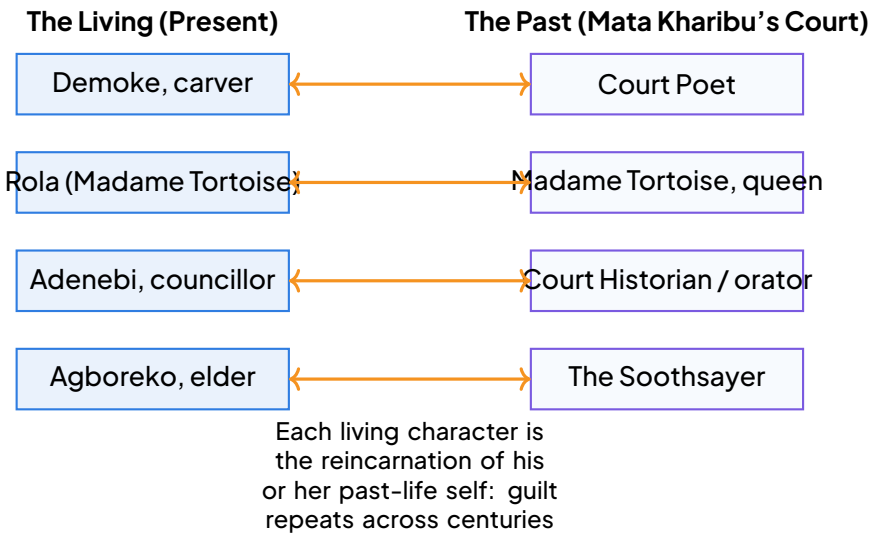
KEY POINTS **The Central Situation**

The living must **confront the crimes of their past** before they can build a future. The four human characters are chosen to face the dead because each of them is personally guilty — and each is the reincarnation of a figure from Mata Kharibu's court. The past is not behind them; it is inside them. Until they acknowledge it, the future (symbolised by the Half-Child) cannot be born.

11.8 Characterisation of the Human Quartet

Soyinka gives us four representative living characters, each a recognisable social type, each carrying a personal guilt, and each doubled by a past-life counterpart in the flashback to Mata Kharibu's empire:

- **Demoke**: a carver and poet, devotee of Ogun, gifted but violent; he pushed his apprentice Oremole to his death from the top of the araba tree. He embodies the artist's creative-destructive double nature.
- **Rola**: a woman of notorious sexual appetite, nicknamed Madame Tortoise; in her past life she was the queen whose vanity drove men to destruction. She embodies beauty corrupted into cruelty.
- **Adenebi**: a corrupt councillor and orator, responsible for the deaths of sixty-five people burned in a lorry he had illegally licensed. He embodies the eloquent, thieving politician of the new era.
- **Agboreko**: the Elder of the Sealed Lips, the proverb-speaking elder who senses more than he says; he embodies the compromised wisdom of tradition.



The doubling of characters: each member of the human quartet has a counterpart in the court of Mata Kharibu, four centuries earlier.

This doubling is Soyinka's boldest stroke of **characterisation**. It tells us that the corrupt councillor of 1960 is the same soul as the flattering court historian of the old empire; that history does not merely repeat itself — we repeat ourselves.

11.9 True-to-Life Representation: The Play as a Mirror

Why does a play full of gods and spirits belong to a chapter on true-to-life human representation? Precisely because Soyinka's supernatural machinery is aimed at the most realistic target imaginable: **post-independence African self-deception**. The gathered tribes who expect glorious ancestors are every nation at its independence day, every community at its jubilee, every family at its reunion — determined to celebrate, unwilling to remember. The play is a mirror held up to that universal human reflex. Its relevance extends far beyond Nigeria in 1960: any society — Cameroon included — that marks its national day with parades while refusing to examine its history is the audience Soyinka had in mind.

WORKED EXAMPLE 12 **Worked GCE-Style Question**

Question: "A Dance of the Forests was written for a celebration, yet it is not a celebratory play." Discuss the validity of this statement with close reference to the opening of the play.

SOLUTION

Plan and model answer. Step 1 — Context. The play was commissioned for Nigeria's 1960 independence celebrations, an occasion that demanded praise of the African past. Step 2 — The reversal. At the Gathering of the Tribes, the living invite their glorious ancestors; the forest, through Aroni the Lame One, sends instead the Dead Man and the Dead

Woman — embodiments of the crimes of Mata Kharibu's age: slavery, war and tyranny. Step 3 — Interpretation. The living recoil and try to drive the dead away, dramatising the new nation's desire for glory without guilt. Soyinka thus converts a festival into a summons to judgement: the message is that a people who will not confront their past are condemned to repeat it, as the doubling of Demoke, Rola, Adenebi and Agboreko with their past-life counterparts proves. Conclusion. The statement is valid: Soyinka used the celebratory occasion to deliver a warning, making the play an act of national self-examination rather than self-praise.

EXERCISE 11 **Practice**

1. Explain the significance of Aroni's limp to his role in the play.
2. In a short paragraph, show how the Gathering of the Tribes reflects the mood — and the blindness — of a newly independent nation.
3. Match each member of the human quartet to his or her past-life counterpart and state what this doubling reveals about Soyinka's view of history.

SOLUTION **Exercise n°1**

1. Aroni's limp marks him as a threshold figure who belongs to neither realm fully; as the lame messenger he alone can move between the living and the dead, which is why he conducts the Dead Man and Dead Woman to the feast and later leads the quartet into the forest. 2. The tribes assemble in festivity, expecting heroic ancestors whose glory will reflect on them; the arrival of the accusing dead exposes their refusal to remember, mirroring a new nation that celebrates freedom while ignoring the crimes that stain its history. 3. Demoke–Court Poet; Rola–Madame Tortoise; Adenebi–Court Historian; Agboreko–Soothsayer. The doubling shows that human guilt is recurrent: the same moral failures reappear across centuries, so the past must be confronted, not buried.

12 SECTION 12: A DANCE OF THE FORESTS — STRUCTURE: HUMAN WORLD, ARONI'S INVITATION, ENTRY INTO THE FOREST AND THE FLASHBACKS

12.1 From Background to Architecture: Why Structure Matters

In Section 11 we met Wole Soyinka, the historical moment of the Nigerian independence cele-

brations of 1960, and the opening assembly in which the living, the dead and the gods gather. We now turn from who wrote the play and why to how the play is built. This is not a merely technical question. In A Dance of the Forests, structure is meaning: Soyinka constructs the play as a journey from the familiar human world into the forest of the spirits and back again, so that the audience experiences, physically, the play's central argument — that the present cannot be understood, let alone healed, until it has confronted the past.

WARNING **Why examiners love structure questions**

Questions such as "Discuss the dramatic structure of A Dance of the Forests" or "How does Soyinka's handling of time contribute to the meaning of the play?" recur frequently at the GCE Advanced Level. Candidates who can only retell the plot in chronological order score poorly; candidates who can divide the play into labelled **movements**, state the function of each, and show how they interlock score highly. Master the map in this section.

12.2 Structure 1 — Part One: The Human World in the Present

The play opens in the world we recognise: a clearing near a village, during a festival — the **Gathering of the Tribes**, modelled on the independence celebrations. Into this festive space Soyinka introduces three living human beings whose quarrelling immediately poisons the atmosphere: **Demoke** the carver, **Rola** the prostitute (known as Madame Tortoise in the town), and **Adenebi** the council orator. With them is **Obaneji**, a strangely knowing figure who is in fact the Forest Head in disguise — a detail the audience only fully appreciates later, and a fine example of Soyinka's taste for concealed identities.

The quarrels.

The humans bicker, accuse and expose one another. This is deliberate: before any spirit appears, Soyinka shows us that the "glorious" present of the new nation is already riddled with vanity, lust and violence. Demoke, we learn, carved the great totem for the festival — and pushed his apprentice **Oremole** from its top to his death. Rola has driven men to ruin and death through her sexual cruelty. Adenebi, the respectable official, is corrupt to the bone.

The lorry 'incident'.

The emblematic episode of Part One is the story of the lorry — "the incinerator". Adenebi, in his official capacity, took a bribe to pass an unroadworthy lorry as fit; the lorry then carried a crowd of passengers to a fiery death. The incident does three things at once:

- It exposes **corruption** concretely — not as an abstract vice but as a contract, a bribe, a signature, and burnt bodies.
- It links Adenebi's public respectability to private crime, Soyinka's bitter comment on the new elite of independent Africa.
- It establishes the play's moral logic: every character carries a hidden crime that the forest will bring to light.

The exposure of Rola's past.

Rola's history is similarly dragged into the open: her lovers have fought and died over her, and

she has treated human lives as disposable. Together, the revelations of Part One answer the question the festival refuses to ask: what exactly is the new nation celebrating?

KEY POINTS **Function of Part One**

Part One (the human world, present time) establishes the **festive occasion**, introduces the **guilty trio** (Demoke, Rola, Adenebi), and exposes their crimes — murder, destructive lust, and murderous corruption. Its function is accusation: the present is put on notice before the forest puts it on trial.

12.3 Structure 2 — The Transition: Aroni's Invitation

Between the human world and the forest stands a hinge, and the hinge has a name: **Aroni**, the lame one, messenger of the Forest Head.

The luring of the guilty trio.

Aroni does not arrest the three humans; he lures them. Through flattery, mystery and the promise of refuge from the townspeople who have begun to turn on them, he draws Demoke, Rola and Adenebi away from the festival and into the forest. The method matters: Soyinka suggests that guilty people walk into judgement willingly, because guilt itself is a kind of summons. The trio flee human accusation and run straight into spiritual accusation.

The role of the Forest Head.

Behind Aroni stands the **Forest Head**, the ancient, patient deity of the forest who has orchestrated the whole design. It is he who answered the humans' request for glorious ancestors by sending them instead the **Dead Man and Dead Woman** — two accusers returned from the grave, whose presence turns the festival of self-congratulation into an occasion of reckoning. It is he who will preside over the trial in Part Two. The Forest Head is not a vengeful god; he is a judge-teacher, determined to make the living see what they are.

METHOD **Analysing structure — a four-step method**

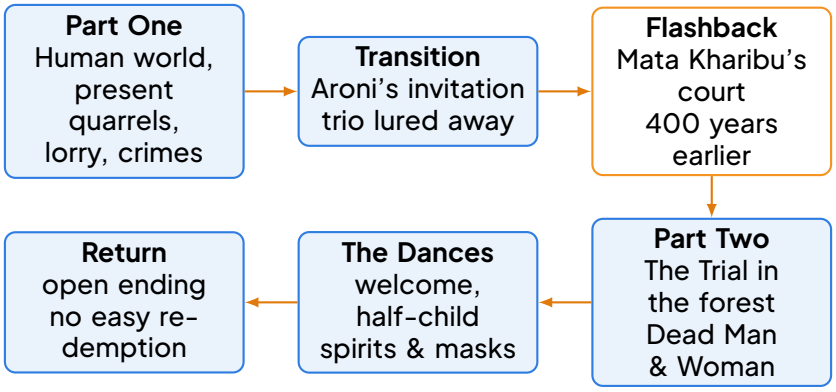
1. Divide the play into movements (human world → transition → forest/trial → dances → return).
2. Label each movement with its setting, time-frame and dominant register (realism, ritual, dance).
3. State the function of each movement (accusation, summons, judgement, revelation, ambiguous release).
4. Show the interlocking: how each movement causes the next — the crimes of Part One provoke the invitation; the invitation leads to the trial; the trial issues in the dances and the open ending.

12.4 Structure 3 — Part Two Begins: Entry into the Forest

The crossing into the forest is a crossing of everything at once, and the candidate must be able to name each shift.

- **Shift of space:** from the open, social clearing of the village to the dense, enclosed, sacred forest — the domain of the Forest Head, of spirits, and of memory.
- **Shift of time:** the linear "now" of the festival dissolves; the past becomes present. Time in the forest is **cyclical**, not linear.
- **Shift of dramatic register:** realistic dialogue gives way to **music**, **drumming**, **dance** and **masks**. Meaning is no longer carried by argument alone but by rhythm, movement and spectacle — the resources of Yoruba ritual theatre.

This triple shift is Soyinka's dramaturgical signature. The forest is not a place on a map; it is a state of judgement, and the change of theatrical language tells the audience that ordinary rules no longer apply.



The six interlocking movements of A Dance of the Forests. Note that the flashback (orange) sits inside the forest movement: the past is revealed only after the crossing.

12.5 Flashback 1 — The Past: Mata Kharibu's Empire, 400 Years Ago

Deep in Part Two, the play performs its boldest structural stroke: a full **flashback** to the court of **Mata Kharibu**, some four centuries earlier.

DEFINITION **Flashback**

A **flashback** is a dramatic scene that interrupts the present action to show earlier events. In A Dance of the Forests the flashback does more than supply information: it reveals the past incarnations of the living characters, so that the audience watches the same souls committing the same crimes in an earlier life.

The court, the war, the trade in men.

Mata Kharibu's court is a machine of power. The king wages a needless war over a trivial affront — a stolen wife — and demands that his subjects die for his pride. Around the court flourish flattery, sycophancy and the **trade in men**: human beings are bought, sold, and spent like goods. A warrior who refuses to fight in an unjust war is punished by being sold into slavery; his pregnant wife is handed over to the king's cruelty. The picture is unsparing: the African past, Soyinka insists, was not a golden age of innocence. It contained its own tyrants, its own corruption, its own contempt for human life.

12.6 Flashback 2 — The Characters in the Past: The Same Crimes Repeated

The flashback's true force lies in **doubling**: the same actors reappear in past roles, and each past role mirrors the present one.

DEFINITION **Doubling**

Doubling is the use of the same actor or character in two (or more) roles across different times or worlds of the play. Its function here is to show the continuity of human failing: the crime is not new, only the costume has changed.

Present self	Past incarnation	Repeated crime
Rola	**Madame Tortoise**, the queen	Sexual cruelty; men destroyed for her vanity
Demoke	The **Warrior**	Violence; entanglement in bloodshed (though he resists the unjust war)
Adenebi	The **Courtier** / Historian	Corrupt counsel; falsifying and flattering power
—	The **Poet**	The artist trapped between truth and the court

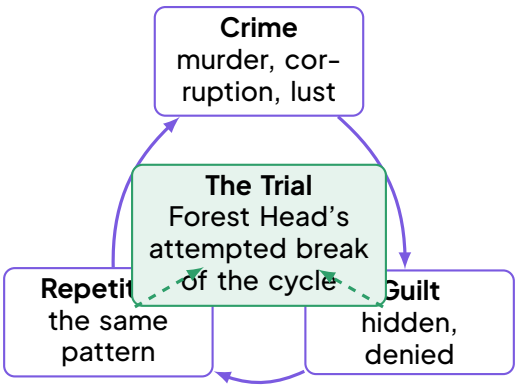
The **Poet** deserves special attention: he represents the artist-intellectual in the court of power — the figure Soyinka himself embodies — torn between telling the truth and surviving the tyrant. The pattern is unmistakable: the same crimes, the same weaknesses, four hundred years apart. History, in this play, is a wheel.

WARNING **Do not treat the flashback as a history lesson**

A frequent examination error is to summarise Mata Kharibu's court as if it were background information about old Africa. Its function is judgement of the present: every detail of the past is a mirror held up to the festival of 1960. Always answer the question "why is this scene here?" — not merely "what happens in it?"

12.7 The Cyclical Vision of History: 'The Same Pattern'

From the doubled flashback emerges the play's philosophy of history: a **cyclical vision** in which crime produces guilt, guilt is repressed, and repression produces repetition. Soyinka wrote the play partly against the Negritude celebration of a glorious, innocent African past. His answer is severe: there was no innocent past; the rot is old; and unless the cycle is consciously broken — through acknowledgement, trial and ritual cleansing — independence merely dresses old crimes in new flags.



Soyinka's cyclical vision of history. The trial in the forest is the attempt to break the wheel — its partial success explains the play's deliberately open ending.

12.8 Dramatic Techniques: Flashback, Doubling, Ritual, Drumming and Dance

Soyinka's structure is carried by a battery of techniques the examiner expects you to name and evaluate:

- **Flashback:** collapses four centuries into one stage-evening, making past and present judge each other.
- **Doubling of roles:** turns casting into argument — the audience sees recurrence in the same face.
- **Ritual:** the trial, the sacrifices and the dances borrow the forms of Yoruba religious ceremony, giving the political critique sacred weight.
- **Drumming and dance as narrative:** in the forest, the drum does not merely accompany the action; it is action — summoning spirits, marking transitions, and expressing what words cannot. Dance carries the plot where dialogue fails, above all in the dances of welcome and unwelcome and the apparition of the half-child.

EXPERIMENT **Role play: the doubling exercise**

Divide the class into groups of three. Each group takes one character (Rola, Demoke or Adenebi) and prepares two short performances of the same moment of temptation:

once in the present (the festival, the lorry contract, the quarrel) and once in the past (Mata Kharibu's court). Keep the same gestures and vocal habits in both versions. Then discuss: what did you feel when the "same person" committed the "same crime" in a different century? This is precisely the cyclical structure made physical — and it will fix the doubling technique in your memory far better than any summary.

WORKED EXAMPLE 13 **Worked GCE-style question**

Question: "The flashback to Mata Kharibu's court is the structural centre of A Dance of the Forests." Discuss.

SOLUTION

Plan and model paragraph. Introduction: define the flashback and state the thesis — the scene is central because it converts the play from satire of the present into a philosophy of history. Body 1 — placement: the flashback sits at the hinge of Part Two, after the entry into the forest, so that judgement of the present passes through revelation of the past. Body 2 — doubling: Rola/Madame Tortoise, Demoke/the Warrior, Adenebi/the Courtier repeat their crimes; structure itself argues that history is cyclical. Body 3 — ideology: the scene rejects the myth of a glorious African past (war, the trade in men, the crushed Poet), which is the play's answer to the independence celebrations. Conclusion: the flashback is central not because it is long but because every other movement — the quarrels of Part One, the trial, the dances, the open ending — derives its meaning from it.
Model sentence: "By casting the same actors as their four-hundred-year-old selves, Soyinka makes the stage itself argue his thesis: the crime is never new, only the costume; and until the cycle is confronted in the forest, the festival of the present is a celebration of nothing."

EXERCISE 12 **Consolidation**

1. Draw, from memory, the six-movement structural map of the play and annotate each movement with its function.
2. Explain, in one paragraph each, the dramatic purpose of (a) the lorry incident and (b) Aroni's method of luring rather than arresting the trio.
3. "Doubling is Soyinka's most economical dramatic device in the play." Write two paragraphs in support, naming the doubled roles.
4. Why is the ending called "open"? Connect your answer to the cycle diagram of crime, guilt and repetition.

SOLUTION **Exercise 1**

Your map should read: Part One (human world, present — accusation and exposure of crimes) → Transition (Aroni's invitation — summons) → Flashback (Mata Kharibu's court — revelation of the past and of doubled roles) → Part Two proper (the trial before the Forest Head — judgement) → the dances (ritual working-out, the half-child) → the return (open ending — no guaranteed redemption). Full credit requires the function of each movement, not merely its content: the interlocking logic — crimes provoke summons, summons leads to trial, trial issues in dance and ambiguous release — is what examiners reward.

KEY POINTS **Key points of Section 12**

- The play moves in six interlocking movements; the flashback sits inside the forest movement.
- Part One exposes the crimes of Demoke, Rola and Adenebi (murder, destructive lust, the lorry corruption).
- Aroni lures the guilty trio; the Forest Head orchestrates the whole design.
- Entry into the forest shifts space, time and register (music, dance, masks).
- The flashback to Mata Kharibu's court, with doubled roles, embodies Soyinka's **cyclical vision of history** and his rejection of a glorious, innocent African past.
- Structure questions are frequent: always divide, label, state functions, and show interlocking.

13 SECTION 13: A DANCE OF THE FORESTS — THE TRIAL: ACCUSATION, PROSECUTION, DEFENCE AND THE JUDGE

In Section 12 we followed the living trio — Demoke, Rola and Adenebi — from the human world of the present, through Aroni's invitation, into the forest, and backwards through the flashbacks that revealed their past lives in Mata Kharibu's empire. We saw that each of them carries an ancient guilt: Demoke was the poet who let the apprentice fall; Rola was Madame Tortoise, the devourer of men; Adenebi was the corrupt Court Historian. The flashbacks have assembled the evidence. Now the play moves to its central ritual event: the **trial** of the living by the dead, presided over by Forest Head. This is the heart of Part Two, and it is where Soyinka fuses courtroom procedure with masquerade, dance and spirit possession to create what we call **ritual drama**. Understanding who accuses, who prosecutes, who defends, and who judges — and why — is essential for any GCE essay on this play.

13.1 Trial 1 — The Accusation: The Dead Man and the Dead Woman

The trial begins not with a judge's gavel but with a haunting. The **Dead Man** and the **Dead Woman** — the couple whom Aroni, the Lame One, has brought back from the realm of the dead — step forward to present their grievances against the living. They are not random ghosts. In the flashback to Mata Kharibu's empire, we learned who they were: the Dead Man was the **Warrior** who refused to lead an unjust war for Mata Kharibu and was enslaved and castrated for his refusal; the Dead Woman was his pregnant wife, given away like property, who died with her unborn child.

Their accusation is therefore double. They accuse the specific living persons before them — for the dead couple's tragedy is bound up with the moral cowardice of the court in which Demoke, Rola and Adenebi lived their former lives — and they accuse the whole community of the living, whose "Gathering of the Tribes" festival celebrates the nation's past while refusing to confront its crimes. The dead couple are the **wronged ancestors**: the unquiet past that will not stay buried.

DEFINITION **Ritual drama**

Ritual drama is theatre that draws on religious ceremony — masks, dance, drumming, chants, spirit possession — to enact a communal cleansing or renewal rather than merely to tell a story. In A Dance of the Forests, the trial of the living is staged as ritual drama: the courtroom is also a sacred grove, the witnesses are spirits, and the verdict is meant to purify the community, not simply to punish individuals.

Notice the dramatic power of Soyinka's choice. In an ordinary courtroom play, the accused speak in their own defence. Here, the dead speak first, and the living are largely speechless — their guilt has already been dramatised in the flashbacks, so the audience is the true jury. The Dead Woman's condition — dead with her unborn child — also plants the seed of the play's climax: the **Half-Child**, the unborn future that the living will later refuse to welcome.

KEY POINTS **The Dead Couple as symbols**

- They embody the **unquiet past**: crimes committed by ancestors and leaders that the present generation wants to forget.
- They embody victims rather than villains: the Warrior resisted an unjust war; his wife was treated as a chattel.
- Their presence converts a festival of celebration into a tribunal of conscience.
- They foreshadow the Half-Child — the future born of an unacknowledged past.

13.2 Trial 2 — The Prosecution: Eshuoro's Case

If the dead couple supply the moral accusation, **Eshuoro** supplies the legal fire. Eshuoro is a god — the orisha associated with the forest's vengeful energies — but in the trial he behaves

like an embittered plaintiff and a thundering state prosecutor rolled into one. His grievance is personal and ancient: he resents **Ogun**, his rival, and he resents the way the forest and its creatures have been treated. His cult, we must remember, is a **cult of violence**: his followers demanded vengeance on Demoke for killing Oremole (Eshuoro's devotee), and it was Eshuoro's pressure that helped drive Demoke into the forest in the first place.

Eshuoro's prosecution speech is a masterpiece of Soyinka's satire. He deploys all the tricks of legal and religious rhetoric: inflated language, appeals to precedent and authority, righteous indignation, the demand for blood to answer blood. Yet the audience can see what his eloquence conceals — his case is driven less by love of justice than by jealousy of Ogun and appetite for vengeance. Soyinka is satirising two institutions at once: the courtroom, where fine words can dress up revenge as law, and organised cult, where divine authority can be claimed for purely human malice.

DEFINITION **Prosecution and defence (dramatic sense)**

In a trial scene, the **prosecution** is the speech (or speaker) that sets out the case against the accused — the charges, the evidence, the demand for punishment. The **defence** is the opposing speech that answers the charges, offers justification or mitigation, and pleads for mercy or acquittal. In drama, these opposed speeches do more than advance the plot: they articulate the play's moral debate, forcing the audience to weigh vengeance against justice, guilt against redemption.

WARNING **Eshuoro is not "the devil"**

A common mistake is to label Eshuoro simply as "Satan" or "evil". Soyinka's cosmology is Yoruba, not Christian. Eshuoro is a legitimate orisha with a genuine grievance — the forest has been wronged, and blood has been shed. What Soyinka criticises is not his existence but his perversion of justice into vengeance and his manipulation of cult and legal language. In the exam, present him as an ambivalent, satirised figure, not a cartoon villain.

13.3 Trial 3 — The Defence: Ogun's Intervention

Against Eshuoro rises **Ogun** — and here Soyinka gives us his most personal and complex deity. Ogun, the Yoruba god of iron, of the forge, of the road and of war, is the **patron of Demoke**: Demoke is a carver, a worker in wood and a climber of heights, and Ogun is the god of all who shape hard materials and dare dangerous passages. It is therefore fitting that Ogun speaks for the defence.

Ogun's defence does not deny the charges. This is crucial. He does not claim that Demoke, Rola and Adenebi are innocent — the flashbacks have proved otherwise. Instead, Ogun pleads mitigation and possibility: the living are guilty, but they are also human, and humanity's value lies precisely in its capacity to create, to suffer, to recognise guilt and to change. Ogun himself is the proof of this ambivalence, for he is both **creator and destroyer**: the god who clears the road and forges the tools is also the god of the blade that kills. In Yoruba myth, Ogun himself once slaughtered in a moment of possession and rage — he knows destruction from the inside,

and that is why he can plead for those who destroy.

KEY POINTS **The ambivalence of Ogun**

- Ogun = iron: the tool (creation) and the weapon (destruction) in one symbol.
- He is Soyinka's own patron deity, and the playwright gives him a tragic self-knowledge: the creative act always risks bloodshed.
- His defence of Demoke is a defence of fallible humanity: guilty, but capable of recognition and renewal.
- Contrast with Eshuoro: Ogun seeks purification; Eshuoro seeks punishment.

DID YOU KNOW? **Soyinka and Ogun**

Wole Soyinka has repeatedly described Ogun as his personal muse — the "first artist" of Yoruba cosmology, who dared to cross the abyss between gods and men. Soyinka's 1965 poem "Idanre" and many of his essays return to Ogun's paradox: the god whose creative courage is inseparable from his destructive rage. When Ogun defends Demoke, it is almost the playwright defending the artist — and the artist's dangerous tools — before the tribunal of history.

13.4 The Judge: Forest Head

Presiding over the whole tribunal is **Forest Head** (also called Obaneji in his human disguise), the ancient, disguised sovereign of the forest. His authority is absolute but quiet. Where Eshuoro rants and Ogun pleads, Forest Head listens, questions and directs. He is the one who summoned the dead at the community's own request — the humans asked for "illustrious ancestors" to grace their festival, and Forest Head, with dark irony, sent them the ancestors they deserved: the victims of their history.

His verdict is the moral centre of the play, and it must be stated precisely. Forest Head does not acquit the living. He does not declare them innocent, and he does not let them return to their festival with clean hands. Nor, however, does he hand them over to Eshuoro's vengeance. His judgement exposes their guilt and then imposes a **purification**: the living must pass through the dances of the forest, confront the spirits, and be offered the Half-Child — the chance to redeem the future. His purpose is cleansing, not punishment; diagnosis, not execution.

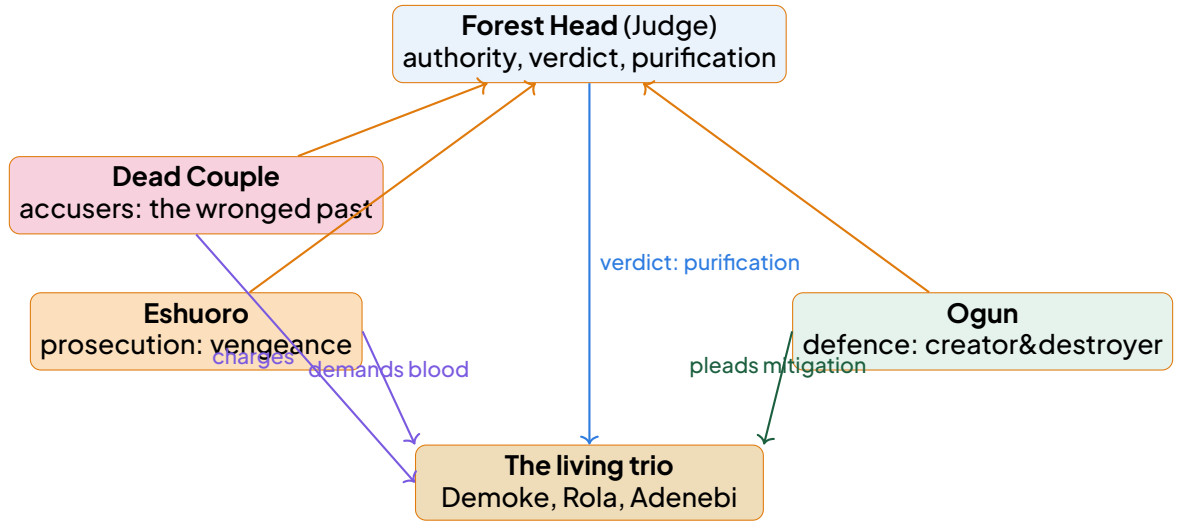
WARNING **The verdict is not an acquittal**

Many candidates write that Forest Head "forgives" or "frees" the accused. This is wrong. His judgement confirms their guilt — Demoke's blood-guilt, Rola's destructiveness, Adenebi's corruption — and then prescribes a painful ritual of purification. The play's

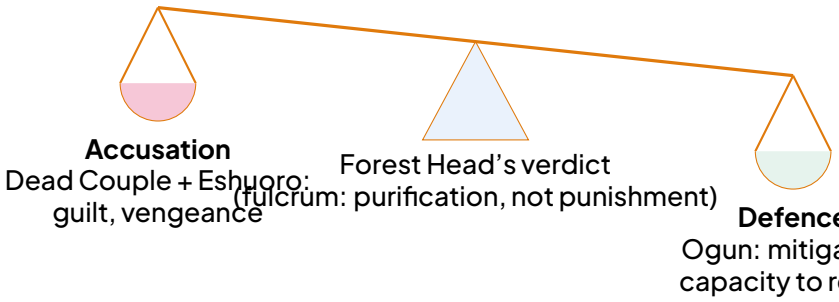
ending remains open: the living fail, in part, to welcome the Half-Child. Forest Head offers the possibility of renewal; he does not guarantee it.

13.5 The Trial as Ritual Drama: A Courtroom that is also a Grove

What makes this scene unique in world drama is its fusion of forms. Structurally, it follows courtroom procedure: charges are read, accusers testify, prosecution and defence speak, a judge presides and rules. But every element is simultaneously ritual: the accusers are masked spirits of the dead; the lawyers are gods; the procedure is punctuated by drumming, dance and possession; the court sits in a sacred forest, not a building. Soyinka is showing that in African experience, justice has always been communal and spiritual — the masquerade that judges, the ancestors who witness — long before colonial courts arrived. The trial scene is thus also a cultural argument: a reclaiming of African ritual as a valid form of high theatre.



The trial as ritual courtroom: accusers, prosecution, defence, accused and judge.



The scales of the trial: accusation outweighs defence, yet the fulcrum — Forest Head's purpose — converts judgement into purification.

13.6 Method and Worked Example

METHOD **Analysing a trial scene**

1. Identify the charges. Who is accused, of what, and by whom? (Here: the living, accused by the dead of inherited and personal guilt.)
2. Examine the evidence. What has the play already shown? (The flashbacks to Mata Kharibu's court function as the evidence.)
3. Analyse the rhetoric of each speaker. What language, tone and appeals does each use, and what do they conceal? (Eshuoro: inflated legal-religious rhetoric hiding jealousy; Ogun: honest admission of guilt plus a plea for possibility.)
4. Define the judge's verdict and purpose. Is it punishment, acquittal, or something else? (Forest Head: exposure of guilt followed by ritual purification — an open offer of renewal.)
5. Relate the scene to the play's themes. (The past must be faced; justice is cleansing, not revenge; the future — the Half-Child — depends on the living's response.)

WORKED EXAMPLE 14 **Character question: "Eshuoro is no more than a god of vengeance." Discuss**

Statement: "In A Dance of the Forests, Eshuoro is no more than a god of vengeance." Discuss the validity of this view of Soyinka's characterisation of Eshuoro in the trial scene.

SOLUTION

Plan and model paragraph. A strong answer refuses both extremes: Eshuoro is not "no

more than" vengeance, but vengeance dominates his dramatic behaviour.
Step 1 — Symbolic role. Eshuoro is an orisha with a legitimate grievance: blood has been shed (Oremole), the forest has been violated, and his rivalry with Ogun is ancient. He therefore represents a real principle — the demand that wrongs be answered.
Step 2 — Dramatic behaviour. In the trial, however, this principle is corrupted. His prosecution speech uses the inflated rhetoric of law and cult to disguise jealousy of Ogun and a personal appetite for Demoke's destruction. Soyinka satirises the way institutions — courts, cults — can dress vengeance in the robes of justice.
Step 3 — Contrast and verdict. Against Ogun's honest defence and Forest Head's purifying judgement, Eshuoro stands exposed as a prosecutor whose case outlives its justice.
Conclusion: the statement is half-true — vengeance is his dominant motive, but Soyinka characterises him with enough legitimacy and rhetorical skill to make him a serious satire of perverted justice, not a mere demon.

EXEMPLE **Exam tip — character questions on the gods and Forest Head**

When the GCE asks you to "discuss the character and role of Eshuoro / Ogun / Forest Head", always write on two levels:

1. the symbolic role (what the figure means: vengeance, creative ambivalence, purifying authority); and
2. the dramatic behaviour (what the figure does and says: prosecuting, pleading, judging — with reference to the trial scene).

An answer that treats only the symbolism reads like notes on mythology; an answer that treats only the plot misses Soyinka's design. The best scripts weave both, and end by linking the figure to the play's central theme: the community can only be cleansed by facing its past.

EXERCISE 13 **Practice — The trial as ritual drama**

1. Explain, with reference to the Dead Man and the Dead Woman, why Soyinka makes the dead the accusers of the living.
2. "Ogun's defence succeeds because he does not deny guilt." Discuss this view of the defence speech.
3. Show how Forest Head's verdict differs from both Eshuoro's demand and a simple acquittal. What does this reveal about Soyinka's idea of justice?

SOLUTION **Exercise — guidance**

1. The dead couple are the victims of the community's past (the Warrior's resistance and enslavement, the wife's death with her unborn child). Making them accusers dramatises the theme that the unacknowledged past returns to demand justice; it also converts the festival into a tribunal and foreshadows the Half-Child.
2. Largely valid: Ogun admits the trio's guilt (proved in the flashbacks) and instead pleads mitigation — humanity's capacity to create, suffer and change — grounded in his own ambivalence as creator-destroyer. His honesty gives his plea moral weight that Eshuoro's rhetoric lacks.
3. Eshuoro demands blood (punishment); an acquittal would deny guilt. Forest Head confirms the guilt but prescribes purification through the forest dances and the offer of the Half-Child. Soyinka's justice is therefore restorative and communal — cleansing rather than revenge — and its success depends on the living's response, which is why the ending stays open.

In Section 14, we shall follow the consequences of Forest Head's verdict into the dances of the forest — the Dance of Welcome, the Dance of the Half-World — the birth and rejection of the Half-Child, and the play's deliberately open ending, before drawing together Soyinka's style, themes and setting for final GCE revision.

14 SECTION 14: A DANCE OF THE FORESTS — THE DANCES, THE HALF-CHILD, STYLE, THEMES, SETTING AND GCE REVISION

In Section 13 we followed the trial of humanity before Forest Head: the Dead Man and Dead Woman laid their accusation, Eshuoro prosecuted with vindictive energy, Ogun defended, and the Judge listened in grave silence. But Soyinka's play does not end with a verdict. The trial dissolves into something older than law — **dance**. The final movement of A Dance of the Forests is a sequence of ritual dances in which the fate of the **Half-Child**, the symbolic unborn future, is fought over before our eyes. This closing section studies those dances, the birth and struggle for the Half-Child, the deliberately **open ending**, and then draws the whole play together — style, themes, setting — before turning to your final GCE revision strategy across all three genres.

14.1 Dance 1 — The Dance of Welcome: Structure, Choreography and Function

After the solemnity of the trial, the forest erupts into movement. The **Dance of Welcome** is the first great choreographic sequence of the play's climax. Observe what happens dramatically: the human guests — Demoke, Rola, Adenebi — have been summoned to the feast of the tribes; the spirits and forest denizens now receive them, and reception in Soyinka's world is never neutral. To be welcomed into the forest is to be drawn into its judgement.

The dance is built on three interlocking elements:

- **Drumming and music.** The drum is the heartbeat of the ritual. Changes of rhythm signal changes of mood and of power — a quickening tempo announces possession, danger or the approach of a greater presence. On stage, the drummer is effectively a co-director of the action.
- **Masquerade and costume.** Masked figures embody spirits and ancestors. The mask depersonalises the actor: the individual human face disappears so that a force — an ancestor, a deity, a principle — can appear.
- **Choreographed movement.** Gestures are stylised and symbolic rather than realistic: circling suggests the cyclical nature of time; prostration suggests submission to judgement; sudden freezes create tableaux that the audience reads like pictures.

KEY POINTS **Dramatic function of the Dance of Welcome**

The Dance of Welcome is not decorative entertainment. Its functions are: (1) to shift the play from verbal argument (the trial) to **ritual** experience; (2) to dissolve the boundary between the human world and the spirit world; (3) to prepare the stage — and the audience — for the appearance of the Half-Child; and (4) to remind the living that they are guests, and guests under judgement, in a realm older than themselves.

14.2 Dance 2 — The Dance of Unwelcome and the Half-World

The mood darkens. The **Dance of Unwelcome** — the dance of the **Half-World** — introduces the spirits of the unborn and the dead who were never properly buried or mourned. Where the Dance of Welcome was ordered and ceremonial, this dance is **grotesque**: twisted bodies, distorted masks, discordant rhythms. Soyinka stages the Half-World as a limbo of wasted potential — lives cut short, children never born, futures squandered by the violence and corruption of the living.

DEFINITION **The Half-Child**

The **Half-Child** is the symbolic unborn child of the Dead Woman, who in life was the pregnant wife sold into the court of Mata Kharibu and who died with her child unborn. It exists in the Half-World, suspended between non-being and birth. Its fate represents the future itself: the coming generation which the living — through their guilt, greed and violence — either endanger or redeem. To save the Half-Child is to give the future a chance; to let it fall back into the Half-World is to repeat the crimes of the past.

The grotesque masquerades of this dance matter for the exam. Their deformity is a visual argument: Soyinka shows that a society built on unexpiated guilt produces monstrosity. The unborn crowd the stage as accusers — the most helpless victims of history, demanding to know whether the living deserve the future they claim to celebrate at the Gathering of the Tribes.

DID YOU KNOW? **Ritual theatre and Cameroon**

Soyinka's use of drumming, masquerade and communal ceremony will feel familiar to any student who has witnessed traditional performances in the Grassfields or the coastal societies of Cameroon, where masked dance is never mere entertainment but a medium through which the community confronts its ancestors, its guilt and its hopes. Soyinka's achievement is to bring this ritual grammar onto the modern stage without diluting its seriousness.

14.3 The Birth of the Half-Child and Demoke's Struggle

At the climax of the dances, the Half-Child is brought forth — a ritual birth staged before the assembly. Eshuoro, still vengeful over the loss of his sacred tree (felled by Demoke's hand) and his follower Oremole, seeks to seize the child and drag it back into the Half-World. **Demoke** — the carver, the poet of the trial scenes, the man who pushed his apprentice to his death — intervenes. He struggles physically to save the child, and in the struggle he is himself half-destroyed, falling exhausted, broken, but having done one selfless act.

EXEMPLE **Reading the struggle symbolically**

Demoke's fight for the Half-Child works on three levels at once. Personal: the guilty artist performs his first act of genuine self-sacrifice, risking himself for another. Communal: the community's representative fights for its unborn generation. Historical: the present generation of Africa, heir to the crimes of Mata Kharibu's empire, must actively wrest the future from the grip of the past — the future will not simply arrive as a gift.

Note the precision of Soyinka's symbolism: it is Demoke, the artist and murderer, who is given this task. Soyinka insists that redemption is not reserved for the innocent — there are no innocents — but must be seized by the guilty through costly action.

14.4 The Return and the Open Ending

The play closes with the humans returning from the forest to the world of the living. Demoke is restored, but diminished and marked by his ordeal. The Half-Child has been saved — yet Eshuoro's malice is not extinguished; his threat persists beyond the final curtain. Soyinka refuses a tidy resolution.

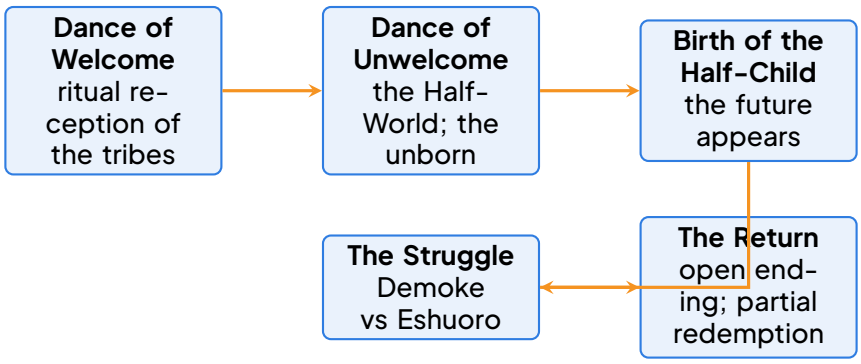
DEFINITION **Open ending**

An **open ending** is a conclusion that deliberately withholds full resolution. Conflicts are not finally settled; judgement and hope are left in balance, and the audience is sent away with a responsibility rather than an answer. In A Dance of the Forests, the open ending means: the future (the Half-Child) has been given a chance, but only a chance — whether

the living will protect it remains undecided, and depends on us.

WARNING **Common mistake**

Do not write that the play "ends happily" because the Half-Child is saved, nor that it "ends in despair" because Eshuoro survives. Both readings flatten Soyinka's deliberate ambiguity. The precise formulation is: partial redemption under continuing threat. Demoke has expiated something; nothing is guaranteed.



Sequence of the closing dances: from ritual welcome to the open-ended return.

14.5 The Playwright's Unique Style

Soyinka's dramatic style in this play is unlike anything else on your syllabus, and examiners reward candidates who can name its components precisely.

- **Ritual and festival form.** The play is structured like a Yoruba festival: invocation, masquerade, trial, dance, sacrifice. Drama becomes communal ceremony.
- **Dance, drumming and song.** Meaning is carried by rhythm and movement as much as by words; whole scenes (the dances) are nearly wordless.
- **Yoruba myth and cosmology.** Ogun, Eshuoro, Aroni (the lame one, linked to esoteric knowledge), Forest Head (Oba of the forest) — Soyinka dramatises a living pantheon, not as folklore decoration but as a framework for moral judgement.
- **Poetic and incantatory language.** Speeches move between proverb, chant, riddling and dense poetic imagery; the dirge and the praise-song sit beside satirical dialogue.
- **Satire.** The human world — Adenebi the corrupt councillor, the truck "Chimney of Ekiti", the vain Rola, the pompous historians of the Gathering — is mocked with sharp comedy that coexists with tragedy.
- **Spectacle and total theatre.** Masks, costume, fire, drumming, chorus: Soyinka aims at a

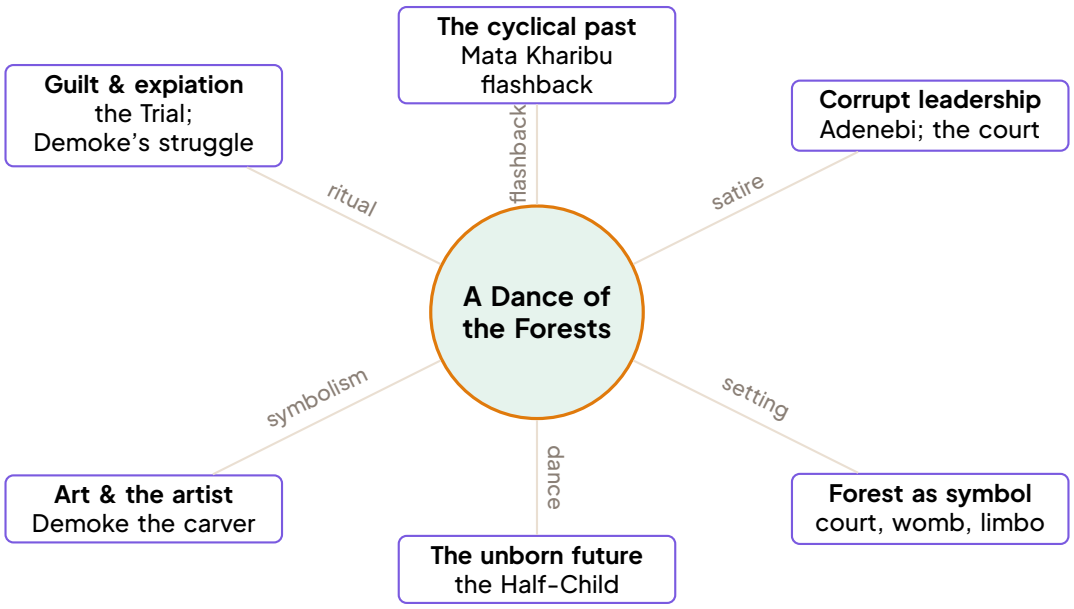
total theatrical experience in the tradition of Yoruba performance, not a drawing-room play.

14.6 Themes and Setting: A Synthesis

KEY POINTS **The major themes**

- Guilt and expiation. Every character carries guilt from a past life; the forest forces confrontation, and expiation is possible only through suffering and self-sacrifice (Demoke).
- The cyclical past. The flashback to Mata Kharibu's empire shows the present repeating the past: tyranny, slavery and lust are not imported ills but indigenous and recurrent. Soyinka rejects romantic nostalgia for a "glorious African past".
- Leadership and corruption. Mata Kharibu, Adenebi and the courtiers of both ages embody power abused — a theme with obvious resonance for post-independence Africa.
- Art and the artist. Demoke the carver is both creator and destroyer: art is implicated in guilt, yet the artist is also the one who can struggle for the future.
- The future / the unborn. The Half-Child concentrates the play's question: does the present deserve the future?

The **setting** is itself a meaning. The **forest** is a symbolic space: a courtroom, a womb, a memory, a limbo between worlds. It stands outside ordinary time (the flashback moves centuries back without leaving the stage) and strips away social disguise — in the forest, no one can hide behind office or title. Against it stands the **human world** of the present, with its lorries, councils and celebrations, shown as shallow and self-deceiving.



Mind-map: each theme linked to a key scene and to the device that carries it.

14.7 Revising Drama for the GCE

METHOD **A complete revision file for each play**

For A Dance of the Forests — and for every set play — prepare the following, in writing:

1. A plot outline of 10–15 numbered beats, from the Gathering of the Tribes to the open ending.
2. Character files for Demoke, Rola, Adenebi, Forest Head, Aroni, Eshuoro, Ogun, the Dead Man and Dead Woman: function, key scenes, one quotation each.
3. Theme cards: one card per theme, with two scenes and one device noted on each.
4. Ten quotations learnt accurately (short ones you are certain of).
5. Three timed essay plans (35 minutes each), written out in full PEEL structure.

WARNING **Analyse the dance — do not merely describe it**

In the exam, a paragraph that simply retells what happens in the Dance of Unwelcome earns little. Always move from what happens to what it does: state the function (shift from verbal trial to ritual), the symbolism (the grotesque masks as the deformity produced by unexpiated guilt) and the effect on the audience (unease, pity, judgement).

Description is narration; function plus symbolism is analysis.

WORKED EXAMPLE 15 **Worked essay plan: the dances**

Question: "Comment on the dramatic significance of the dances in A Dance of the Forests."

SOLUTION

Introduction. Define the dances as the play's ritual climax; thesis: they are not ornament but the play's deepest language, carrying its judgement and its hope. Paragraph 1 (Point): The Dance of Welcome shifts the drama from speech to ritual. Evidence: the reception of the tribes after the trial. Explanation: drumming and masquerade dissolve the human/spirit boundary. Link: the audience is prepared for judgement through experience, not argument. Paragraph 2: The Dance of Unwelcome embodies the wasted future. Evidence: the grotesque masquerades of the Half-World. Explanation: deformity as visual symbol of unexpiated guilt; the unborn as accusers. Paragraph 3: The struggle for the Half-Child dramatises the play's central question. Evidence: Demoke's fight against Eshuoro. Explanation: the guilty artist seizes redemption through sacrifice; the future must be wrested from the past. Paragraph 4: The open ending. Evidence: Demoke's broken return, Eshuoro's survival. Explanation: hope without guarantee; responsibility transferred to the audience. Conclusion: the dances are the play's verdict and its question mark — Soyinka's total theatre at its most purposeful.

14.8 General Revision Across All Genres: Final Strategy

WARNING **Read the instruction word**

Instruction words determine the shape of your answer. "Discuss" demands a balanced argument weighing more than one view. "Comment on" demands your interpretation of a specified aspect, supported by evidence. "Compare" demands parallel treatment of two texts or characters in every paragraph — never two separate halves. "Examine / Analyse" demands close attention to how meaning is made (devices, structure). Misreading the instruction word is the single most costly error at the GCE.

KEY POINTS **Final-week strategy**

In the last week before the examination, alternate daily: one timed essay (35–40 minutes, full PEEL structure) and one context or appreciation question, self-marked honestly

against the PEEL checklist — Point, Evidence, Explanation, Link. Rotate genres so that drama, prose and poetry are each practised at least twice. On the day: spend 5 minutes planning, keep quotations short and accurate, and leave 3 minutes to reread.

EXERCISE 14 **Practice**

1. Write a timed essay plan (10 minutes) for: "The Half-Child is the true centre of A Dance of the Forests. Discuss."
2. In one PEEL paragraph, comment on the dramatic function of the Dance of Unwelcome.
3. Compare the endings of A Dance of the Forests and A Raisin in the Sun: what does each playwright leave unresolved, and why?

SOLUTION **Exercise 1–3**

1. A strong plan: introduction defining the Half-Child; paragraph on the Half-World and the unborn; paragraph on the struggle (Demoke's redemption); paragraph conceding that the trial and the human satire also carry weight (balance for "discuss"); conclusion affirming the child as the symbolic stake of the whole action. 2. Point: the dance embodies wasted potential; Evidence: grotesque masquerades, discordant rhythm; Explanation: deformity visualises unexpiated guilt and the unborn accuse the living; Link: it prepares the birth and struggle that follow. 3. Both endings are open but differently weighted: Hansberry leaves the Youngers moving into a hostile neighbourhood — hope carried by pride and family unity; Soyinka leaves Demoke broken, the child saved but Eshuoro menacing — hope hedged by warning. Parallel treatment, scene by scene, is essential.

You have now completed the full study of A Dance of the Forests and, with it, the drama component of this chapter. Carry into the examination room the habits this course has built: interpret the question before you answer it, argue in PEEL paragraphs, quote briefly and accurately, and always move from what a scene shows to what it means. That discipline — more than any memorised fact — is what distinguishes the best candidates.

15 INTEGRATION ACTIVITY

15.1 Aims of the activity

This integration activity closes the chapter by bringing together every skill you have practised across the four genres studied this term. By the end of the activity, you should be able to:

- Analyse **characterisation** across drama, prose and poetry, showing how authors build **true-to-life human representations** through speech, action, contrast, symbolism and narrative voice.
- Compare **themes** across prescribed texts (family duty, betrayal, power, love, oppression, dignity) and support every claim with precise **textual evidence**.
- Perform a **role play** that dramatises a trial, imitating the structure of the trial scene in A Dance of the Forests (accusation, prosecution, defence, judgement).
- Construct a balanced, well-argued **GCE-style essay** under time constraints, using the **PEEL** method (Point, Evidence, Explanation, Link).
- Assess your peers' work critically and charitably, in the spirit of **Forest Head**, whose justice aims at purification, not punishment.

KEY POINTS **Why a trial?**

In A Dance of the Forests, the Dead Man and the Dead Woman accuse humanity before Forest Head; Eshuoro prosecutes, Ogun defends, and the verdict reveals that the living repeat the crimes of the past. A trial is therefore the perfect dramatic frame for testing whether a character is a **villain** (responsible agent) or a **victim** (product of circumstances) — the central question of this chapter on true-to-life human representation.

15.2 Situation

The Literary Tribunal of GBHS Molyko, Buea.

Your school, Government Bilingual High School Molyko, is preparing its end-of-term Literary and Cultural Week. The Upper Sixth Literature class has been commissioned to stage the flagship event: a public mock trial entitled **"The Court of True-to-Life Characters"**, to be performed before the Lower Sixth classes and a jury of teachers. The principal has announced that the best written verdict and the best GCE-style essay produced during the event will be published in the school magazine and read at the prize-giving ceremony.

The court sits in the manner of Forest Head's tribunal in Soyinka's A Dance of the Forests: the aim is not to destroy the accused but to understand them — to decide, with evidence, whether each character is a villain who betrayed family, truth or community, or a victim crushed by forces beyond his control.

The four accused are brought before the court:

Accused	Text	Charge
Walter Lee Younger	A Raisin in the Sun (Hansberry)	Betrayal of family trust: losing the insurance money, including Beneatha's school fees, in a fraudulent liquor-store scheme (Act 3, Scene 1).
January	The Merchant's Tale (Chaucer)	Exploitation: marrying young May for lust, building a walled garden of possessiveness, and degrading marriage itself (ll. 1600–1650, 2000–2100).
His Excellency Sam	Anthills of the Savannah (Achebe)	Tyranny: betraying his friends, censoring the press, and destroying Ikem and the nation of Kangan (Chapters 1, 4, 11–12).
Winston Smith	Nineteen Eighty-Four (Orwell)	Betrayal of truth and love: under torture in the Ministry of Love, he betrays Julia and learns to love Big Brother (Part 3, Chapters 5–6).

The court personnel (the class of about forty students is divided into four chambers, one per accused; each chamber contains):

1. **Prosecutors** (2–3 students): they argue the character is a villain, citing at least three precise moments from the text (scene, chapter or line reference).
2. **Defenders** (2–3 students): they plead mitigating circumstances — racial oppression, old age and folly, the machinery of dictatorship, torture — citing at least three precise moments.
3. **Judges** (2 students): they listen, question both sides, and deliver a reasoned verdict of about 150 words, following Forest Head's principle of purification rather than punishment.
4. **Court reporters** (2 students): they take notes and convert the proceedings into a **timed 45-minute GCE-style essay** on the question: "Literature presents characters who are victims rather than villains." Discuss with reference to three prescribed texts.

Available data and rules of the court:

- Each chamber has 40 minutes of preparation, 10 minutes of hearing (3 minutes prosecution, 3 minutes defence, 2 minutes questioning, 2 minutes verdict).
- Every assertion must be supported by a **short quotation** or a precise paraphrase with a clear reference (act/scene, chapter, or passage of the poem).
- The verdict must weigh both sides: a one-sided verdict is quashed by the presiding teacher.
- Essays are assessed with the PEEL checklist: clear Point, accurate Evidence, developed Explanation, explicit Link back to the question.

15.3 Tasks

Task 1 — Preparing the case files (knowledge and comprehension).

In your chamber, reread the relevant passages and complete a case file for your accused: (a) three facts that make him look guilty; (b) three circumstances that excuse or explain his conduct; (c) two short quotations for each side; (d) one sentence defining the central theme his story illustrates.

Task 2 — Building the arguments (analysis and characterisation).

Prosecutors: show how the author makes the character's fault visible (dialogue, symbolism, irony, narrative comment). Defenders: show how the author makes the character sympathetic or pitiable. Each side writes its three-minute speech using at least two PEEL paragraphs.

Task 3 — The hearing (role play and oral skills).

Perform the trial. Judges must ask each side at least one probing question (for example: "Was Walter's dream itself a product of his society?" or "Can a victim of Room 101 still be held responsible?"). Reporters record the strongest argument on each side.

Task 4 — The verdict (synthesis and judgement).

The judges deliver a reasoned verdict of about 150 words, stating: the charge, the strongest point of each side, the final decision (villain, victim, or a nuanced mixture), and a sentence of "purification" — what the character, or the audience, should learn.

Task 5 — The GCE essay (examination technique).

Court reporters (and, at home, every student) write the timed essay: "Literature presents characters who are victims rather than villains." Discuss with reference to three prescribed texts. Requirements: an introduction that defines the key terms and states a position; three developed PEEL paragraphs (one per text); a counter-argument acknowledged and answered; a conclusion.

Task 6 — Peer assessment and anthology (evaluation).

Exchange essays. Using the PEEL checklist, award up to 5 marks per paragraph and write one strength and one piece of advice. The class votes for the best verdict and the best essay for the school magazine anthology.

WARNING **Common traps**

- Retelling the plot. A prosecutor who narrates Walter's whole life scores nothing: argue, quote, analyse.
- Quotations without commentary. A quotation proves nothing until you explain how its words, images or tone support your point.
- One-sided verdicts. The question says "Discuss": the GCE rewards candidates who weigh both victimhood and responsibility.
- Anachronism. Do not judge January by modern law or Sam by another country's constitution; judge each character within his fictional world, then draw the universal lesson.

15.4 Model answer

Model verdict — the case of Walter Lee Younger (delivered by the judges).

The charge: Walter Lee Younger stands accused of betraying his family's trust by entrusting $6,500 — including Beneatha's medical school fees — to Willy Harris, who vanishes with it (Act 3, Scene 1).

For the prosecution: The evidence is grave. Walter disobeys Mama's explicit values, never invests in the liquor store legally, and hands over money that was never wholly his. His despair is self-inflicted, and his first response to ruin is to grovel before Lindner, agreeing to sell back the house and, as Mama bitterly warns, to trade the family's dignity for money.

For the defence: Yet the court must see the man whole. Walter is a chauffeur in 1950s Chicago, a Black man whose dream of "being somebody" is mocked by a society that offers him only another man's car to drive. Hansberry fills his speeches with the poetry of frustrated dignity; his folly is the distorted mirror of a legitimate hunger. And in Act 3 he rises: refusing Lindner's money, he declares that the family will move into Clybourne Park — "we are very proud people."

Verdict: Walter is neither villain nor pure victim but a flawed, true-to-life man wounded by racism and rescued by family love. His fault is real; his growth is realer. Sentence of purification: let the audience learn that dignity, once chosen, redeems error.

Model essay (abridged) — "Literature presents characters who are victims rather than villains." Discuss with reference to three prescribed texts.

Introduction. A villain acts freely and wickedly; a victim suffers under forces he cannot command. Literature's most memorable characters, however, live in the tension between the two. A study of Hansberry's Walter Lee Younger, Achebe's Ikem Osodi and Orwell's Winston Smith suggests that great writers present characters who are fundamentally victims — of racism, dictatorship and totalitarian terror — even when their own choices deepen their fall.

Paragraph 1 — Walter Lee Younger (A Raisin in the Sun). Walter's squandering of the insurance money looks villainous, but Hansberry frames it within systemic exclusion: a chauffeur with no access to capital, he grasps at the liquor store as his only imagined route to manhood. When he finally refuses Lindner's buy-out, the play confirms that his "crime" was a symptom; his society, not his soul, is the true accused.

Paragraph 2 — Ikem Osodi (Anthills of the Savannah). Ikem is guilty of nothing but eloquence. His editorials and his lecture to the students of Abazon speak truth to His Excellency's regime, and he is "removed" for it — murdered and disguised as a casualty of a traffic accident (Chapters 11–12). Achebe's irony is surgical: the state that brands Ikem an enemy is itself the criminal. Ikem is the purest victim of the three, silenced by the very friend power has corrupted.

Paragraph 3 — Winston Smith (Nineteen Eighty-Four). Winston alone commits a genuine betrayal: in Room 101, facing the rats, he cries that the torture should be done to Julia instead (Part 3, Chapter 5). Yet Orwell's point is precisely that the Party's machinery is designed to make betrayal unavoidable — O'Brien explains that the Ministry of Love does not merely punish but remakes the inner man. A victim who is tortured until he loves Big Brother cannot be called a villain in any meaningful sense.

Counter-argument and conclusion. Admittedly, each character retains a margin of choice: Walter chooses recklessness, Winston chooses rebellion knowing the risk. But choice exercised inside a cage — racial, dictatorial or totalitarian — is not the freedom that makes a villain. Liter-

ature, at its most humane, puts not the character but his world in the dock. Like Forest Head's tribunal, it judges in order to purify: we leave these texts not hating Walter, Ikem or Winston, but understanding them — and resolved to change the forces that made them suffer.

Sample peer assessment (PEEL checklist applied to Paragraph 2).

- **Point** — clear and relevant (Ikem as pure victim): 5/5.
- **Evidence** — accurate reference to the editorials, the Abazon lecture and the staged "traffic accident": 4/5 (a short quotation would strengthen it).
- **Explanation** — the irony of the criminal state is well analysed: 5/5.
- **Link** — explicit return to the question in the final sentence: 5/5.
- Advice: add one brief quotation from Ikem's lecture to make the evidence irrefutable.

METHOD **How to run the activity smoothly**

1. Form the four chambers and assign roles by lot to guarantee fairness.
2. Allow 40 minutes of preparation with the texts open; insist that every claim earns a reference.
3. Stage the four hearings (about 45 minutes total), with the teacher presiding as "Forest Head".
4. Collect verdicts and launch the 45-minute timed essay in examination silence.
5. Close with peer assessment, the class vote, and the selection of pieces for the school anthology.

DID YOU KNOW? **From the courtroom to the examination hall**

The GCE Advanced Level rewards exactly what this tribunal trains: a defined position, precise textual evidence, balanced discussion and elegant expression. Candidates who have practised defending a character orally almost always write richer essays, because they have already heard — and answered — the strongest objections to their own view.

16 METHODS AND WORKED EXAMPLES

16.1 Skill 1 — Analysing Character and Characterisation in Drama

METHOD **Analysing a Dramatic Character (the S.T.A.G.E. method)**

When a GCE question asks you to discuss a character (for example Walter Lee Younger in A Raisin in the Sun or Demoke in A Dance of the Forests), proceed in five ordered steps:

1. Situate the character: name, family or social position, and role in the plot (protagonist, antagonist, foil, catalyst).
2. Trace the character's development: what is he/she like at the beginning, what crisis transforms him/her, what is he/she at the end? (Walter: dreamer → desperate man → dignified man in Act 3.)
3. Assemble the evidence of characterisation: what the character says (dialogue), what he/she does (action), what others say about him/her, and what the stage directions reveal.
4. Generalise: connect the character to a theme (dreams, pride, race, corruption, guilt) and to the author's message.
5. Evaluate: give a personal, justified judgement — is the character admirable, pitiable, symbolic? This earns the highest marks.

Reflex: never retell the story. Every plot detail must serve an analytical point.

WARNING **Common Pitfall in Character Essays**

Do not confuse character (the person in the play) with characterisation (the techniques the playwright uses to create that person). A question on "Hansberry's characterisation of Walter" requires you to discuss dialogue, stage directions, contrast with other characters, etc. — not just what Walter does.

WORKED EXAMPLE 16 **Worked Example 1 — Walter's Dilemma in Act 3**

Statement: "In Act 3 of A Raisin in the Sun, Walter Lee is a broken man who finally becomes a hero." Discuss this view of Hansberry's characterisation of Walter.

SOLUTION

Detailed solution.

Step 1 — Situate. Walter Lee Younger is the protagonist of the play: a thirty-five-year-old chauffeur, son of Lena (Mama), husband of Ruth and brother of Beneatha, living in a cramped Chicago Southside apartment. Act 3 opens after the catastrophe: Willy Harris has absconded with the insurance money, including Beneatha's school fees.
Step 2 — Trace the development. At the start of Act 3, Walter is indeed "broken": he lies prostrate, speaks bitterly, and conceives the humiliating plan of accepting Mr Lindner's money — selling back the Clybourne Park house, and with it the family's dignity. He even rehearses the grovelling performance he will give, a painful parody of the "yes sir" stereotype. The turning point comes when Mama forces him to perform this surrender before his own son, Travis. Faced with the boy's innocent gaze, Walter cannot do it. He tells Lindner, in substance, that the family has decided to move into the house because his father earned it "brick by brick." By the end of the Act, Walter has moved from money-dreamer to moral adult: he chooses **pride** over cash.
Step 3 — Assemble the evidence. Hansberry characterises Walter through: (a) dialogue — his clipped, bitter speeches early in the Act contrast with his firm, measured refusal of Lindner; (b) action — the rehearsal of submission, then the straightening of his body as he refuses; (c) others' reactions — Mama's insistence that he speak before Travis, Beneatha's scorn ("he is no brother of mine"), and finally her recognition that he has "come into his manhood"; (d) stage directions — Hansberry describes Walter looking at his son and slowly changing, a visual emblem of transformation.
Step 4 — Generalise. Walter embodies the theme of the deferred dream and of racial dignity. His refusal of Lindner's money dramatises Hansberry's message: self-respect, not wealth, is the true inheritance of the Younger family.
Step 5 — Evaluate. Walter is not a conventional hero — he is flawed, selfish, even cruel to Ruth and Beneatha. But precisely because he rises from failure, his final stand is more moving and more true to life. The statement is therefore accurate, provided we stress that his "heroism" is quiet, domestic and hard-won.
Conclusion: Act 3 completes Walter's arc from despair to dignity; Hansberry makes him a true-to-life hero whose victory is moral, not material.

16.2 Skill 2 — Writing a Critical Appreciation of a Prose Passage

METHOD **Prose Appreciation (the P.E.E.L. paragraph method)**

For an unseen or set-text passage (e.g. from Nineteen Eighty-Four or Anthills of the Savannah):

1. Read twice: first for meaning, then to annotate diction, imagery, tone, narrative voice and structure.
2. Identify the dominant effect: what is the passage doing — satirising, mourning, frightening, persuading?

3. Build P.E.E.L. paragraphs: Point (one analytical claim), Evidence (short quotation or precise reference), Explanation (how the language creates the effect), Link (to theme and to the question).
4. Comment on narrative technique: point of view (Winston's limited third person; Achebe's multiple voices), irony, symbolism.
5. Conclude by relating the passage to the whole work and the author's vision.

Reflex: quote short fragments you are sure of; otherwise paraphrase accurately.

WORKED EXAMPLE 17 **Worked Example 2 — The End of Nineteen Eighty-Four (Part 3, Chapters 5–6)**

Statement: "In Part 3 of Nineteen Eighty-Four, Orwell shows that the Party's ultimate victory is over the human heart, not merely over the body." Discuss with close reference to Chapters 5 and 6 and to the novel as a whole.

SOLUTION

Detailed solution.
Point 1 — The destruction of private loyalty. In Chapter 5, in Room 101, Winston is confronted with the thing he fears most — rats. O'Brien's machine of terror does not merely extract a confession; it forces Winston to betray the one person he loves: he begs that the torture be done to Julia instead. Evidence: his cry, in effect, "Do it to Julia! Not me!" Explanation: the Party's aim, as O'Brien has explained, is not obedience but the conquest of inner life; love itself must be broken. Link: this fulfils the novel's central theme — totalitarianism seeks to abolish private feeling.
Point 2 — The hollow survivor. Chapter 6 shows Winston released, sitting in the Chestnut Tree Café, drinking gin, playing chess, waiting for the bullet he knows will come. Evidence: he traces "2 + 2 = 5" in the dust of the table. Explanation: the symbol of Party-imposed unreality, once resisted, is now accepted mechanically; his mind has been colonised. Link: the Party controls not only the past (the Ministry of Truth) but the very faculty of thought.
Point 3 — The meeting with Julia. When Winston and Julia meet again, both admit they betrayed each other; their love is dead. Explanation: Orwell shows that betrayal under torture is irreversible — "after that, you don't feel the same." The heart has been conquered.
Point 4 — The final sentence. The novel closes with Winston gazing at the face of Big Brother and realising that he loves him. Explanation: the last private space — emotion — has been annexed. The victory is total: over body (torture), mind (doublethink) and heart (love redirected to the Party).
Conclusion: Orwell's general vision is one of near-total pessimism: Part 3 demonstrates that a regime which controls language, history and fear can finally make a man love his own enslavement. The statement is fully justified.

16.3 Skill 3 — Analysing Characterisation in Poetry (Chaucer)

METHOD **Analysing a Chaucerian Character**

For The General Prologue and The Merchant's Tale:

1. Identify the portrait type: idealised (the Knight) or satirical (the Merchant, the Friar).
2. List the techniques: physical description, clothing, speech, profession, and above all **irony** — Chaucer often praises what he condemns.
3. Connect teller to tale: the Merchant, unhappily married, tells a bitter tale of marriage (January, May, Damyan). Characterisation of the teller illuminates the tale.
4. Analyse the tale's characters through symbol: January's **blindness** (physical and moral), May's duplicity, the pear tree, the garden.
5. Judge the tone: comic fabliau or serious satire? Support with examples.

Reflex: always distinguish what Chaucer says from what Chaucer means.

WORKED EXAMPLE 18 **Worked Example 3 — January's Blindness in The Merchant's Tale**

Statement: "In The Merchant's Tale, January's physical blindness is less important than his moral blindness." Examine Chaucer's treatment of blindness in the tale.

SOLUTION

Detailed solution.
Step 1 — Identify the two blindnesses. January, the old knight of Pavia, is morally blind long before he is physically blind: he marries the young May out of lust and self-delusion, believing he can possess youth and fidelity by decree. Later, Chaucer makes him literally blind — a physical condition that mirrors his inner state.
Step 2 — Moral blindness. January refuses to see reality: he ignores the counsel of Justinus (whose very name suggests justice), idealises marriage as a private paradise, and builds an enclosed garden — a symbol of his wish to lock May away from the world and from truth. His jealousy after losing his sight (he keeps his hand on May constantly) shows that his "love" is possessiveness.
Step 3 — Physical blindness as irony. When January becomes blind, the audience expects justice; instead, May exploits his blindness, climbing the pear tree to meet Damyan. The irony is double: the blind husband "sees" nothing, and when the gods Pluto and Proserpina restore his sight at the climax, he sees too much — yet May talks him out of his own eyes. Restoration of sight does not cure moral blindness.
Step 4 — Symbolic structure. The garden (false Eden), the pear tree (the Fall re-enacted as farce), and the divine quarrel of Pluto and Proserpina all reinforce the theme: human beings see what they wish to see.

Step 5 — Judgement. The statement is correct: physical blindness is a comic device, but moral blindness is the tale's true subject. Chaucer's satire targets self-deception — in husbands, in wives, and in the bitter Merchant who tells the tale.

16.4 Skill 4 — Discussing Theme and Author's Style in the African Novel

METHOD **Thematic Essay on Anthills of the Savannah**

1. Define the theme precisely (e.g. "the corruption of power", "the role of women", "truth versus censorship").
2. Map the theme onto characters: Sam/His Excellency (power corrupted), Ikem (truth and the press), Chris (conscience and flight), Beatrice (female insight and continuity).
3. Select key episodes: the Cabinet meeting and the Abazon delegation (Ch. 1), Ikem's editorials, the death of Ikem, Chris's flight and death, the naming ceremony.
4. Comment on style: Achebe's multiple narrators, proverbs, pidgin and Standard English, symbolism (anthills, the savannah).
5. Conclude with Achebe's vision: hope carried by women and the common people.

WORKED EXAMPLE 19 **Worked Example 4 — The Role of the Press and the Death of Ikem**

Statement: "Through Ikem Osodi, Achebe explores both the power and the limits of the writer under a dictatorship." Discuss with reference to Anthills of the Savannah.

SOLUTION

Detailed solution.
Introduction. Ikem Osodi, editor of the National Gazette and a poet, is Achebe's portrait of the intellectual under military rule in the fictional state of Kangan.
Paragraph 1 — The power of the press. Ikem's editorials speak truth to power: he champions the drought-stricken people of Abazon whom the Cabinet (Ch. 1) dismisses, and he mocks His Excellency's vanity. His famous public lecture argues, in substance, that the writer must side with the people, not with rulers. Achebe shows the press as the last public conscience of the nation.
Paragraph 2 — The limits. Yet Ikem's words cannot save him: he is suspended, abducted and murdered by the regime, and his death is disguised as the work of armed robbers. Censorship and violence answer the pen. Achebe is realistic: truth-telling is necessary but not sufficient; the writer alone cannot overthrow tyranny.
Paragraph 3 — Style and symbol. Through Ikem, Achebe blends poetry, proverb and po-

litical argument; Ikem's poetic voice and his wit embody the artist's freedom of spirit, in contrast to the sterile language of the regime ("His Excellency", protocol, euphemism).
Paragraph 4 — Legacy. Ikem's death is not the end: Beatrice, Chris and the naming ceremony at the close carry his spirit forward. The people of Abazon, the taxi-drivers, the women — the "anthills" that survive — inherit his message.
Conclusion. Ikem embodies both the nobility and the vulnerability of the writer: the pen is mighty enough to frighten a dictator, but only collective courage — symbolised by the novel's hopeful ending — can finish the work he began.

16.5 Skill 5 — Analysing Structure and Symbolism in Soyinka's Drama

METHOD **Reading A Dance of the Forests**

1. Master the two time-frames: the present (the Gathering of the Tribes) and the flashback to Mata Kharibu's empire, four centuries earlier.
2. Identify the structural units: the human world, Aroni's invitation, the entry into the forest, the trial before Forest Head, the dances, the birth of the Half-Child.
3. Read characters as doubles: Demoke/Adenebi/Obaneji re-enact their past crimes (the poet, the corrupt official, the judge).
4. Interpret symbols: the forest (memory and judgement), the Dead Man and Woman (history's victims), the Half-Child (the future), Ogun (destruction and creation).
5. State Soyinka's message: independence celebrations are hollow unless the nation confronts its guilty past.

WORKED EXAMPLE 20 **Worked Example 5 — The Trial before Forest Head**

Statement: "The trial in the forest is the heart of Soyinka's A Dance of the Forests." Justify this view, showing how the trial scene concentrates the play's themes and techniques.

SOLUTION

Detailed solution.
Step 1 — Situate the trial. After Aroni (the lame one) leads the living into the forest, the dead — a Man and a Woman — appear and accuse the living. Forest Head presides; Eshuoro prosecutes; Ogun defends. The scene fuses the play's two time-frames.
Step 2 — The accusation. The Dead Man and Woman represent the victims of history: in the flashback, the warrior (Demoke's earlier self) served Mata Kharibu, who sold his own people into slavery and sent men to die for a futile war; Madame Tortoise (Rola's ear-

lier self) embodies destructive vanity. The accusation shows that the "glorious" past the tribes have gathered to celebrate is in fact a record of guilt.
Step 3 — Prosecution and defence. Eshuoro, the vengeful forest spirit, demands punishment — he stands for the cycle of violence. Ogun, patron of Demoke, defends humanity despite its crimes: he represents the creative-destructive ambiguity at the centre of Soyinka's thought. The debate dramatises the question: can humanity be forgiven, and can it change?
Step 4 — Forest Head as judge. Forest Head (Obaneji in disguise) does not acquit; he makes the living confront their guilt. Judgement in Soyinka is not punishment but recognition — the first step toward renewal.
Step 5 — Techniques. The trial concentrates Soyinka's unique style: ritual, masquerade, dance, Yoruba cosmology, poetic dialogue and flashback. The stage becomes a court, a shrine and a mirror.
Conclusion. The trial is indeed the heart of the play: it gathers past and present, the living and the dead, and states Soyinka's central warning — a nation that refuses to judge its history cannot be reborn. The open ending (the Half-Child handed to Demoke) leaves the verdict to the audience.

16.6 Skill 6 — Interpreting and Answering GCE Questions

METHOD **Decoding GCE Essay Instructions**

1. Underline the command word: discuss (give balanced argument + judgement), examine/assess (weigh evidence), comment on (analyse closely), compare (similarities and differences), trace/show how (follow a development through the text).
2. Underline the focus: character, theme, style, setting, or a quoted statement.
3. Plan before writing: 5 minutes — introduction, 3–4 paragraphs, conclusion; one text-specific example per paragraph.
4. Answer the question, not your prepared essay: adapt your knowledge to the exact wording.
5. Manage time: about 45–50 minutes per essay; leave 3 minutes to proofread.

WARNING **Common traps**

Do not narrate the plot; do not ignore the second half of a two-part question; do not write on a text you have not studied; do not quote passages you cannot reproduce accurately — paraphrase instead.

WORKED EXAMPLE 21 **Worked Example 6 — A Full GCE-Style Question**

Statement: "The writers you have studied present characters whose greatest enemies are themselves." Discuss with close reference to two of the following: A Raisin in the Sun, Nineteen Eighty-Four, The Merchant's Tale.

SOLUTION

Detailed solution (model plan and development).
Decoding. Command word: discuss — argue for and against, then judge. Focus: self-defeating characters. Requirement: two texts. Choose A Raisin in the Sun and The Merchant's Tale.
Introduction. Define the claim: a character's worst enemy is internal — pride, delusion, fear — rather than society or fate. State the two texts and your position: largely true, but with important qualifications.
Paragraph 1 — Walter Lee: pride as enemy. Walter's obsession with the liquor-store dream makes him despise his family, trust Willy foolishly, and lose the insurance money. His enemy is his own impatience and wounded pride. Qualification: racism (Lindner) is a real external enemy; yet the play's crisis is internal — Walter must defeat his own despair to refuse Lindner.
Paragraph 2 — Walter's victory over self. Act 3 shows the enemy conquered: before Travis, Walter chooses dignity. Hansberry thus suggests the inner enemy can be defeated — the play is finally hopeful.
Paragraph 3 — January: delusion as enemy. In The Merchant's Tale, January's lust and self-flattery blind him: he marries May, builds the garden, and is deceived in the pear tree. His enemy is his refusal to see. Qualification: May and Damyan actively betray him; but Chaucer stresses that January's moral blindness invited the betrayal.
Paragraph 4 — Counter-view. One could argue the true enemies are external: segregation for the Youngers, or (in Nineteen Eighty-Four) the Party for Winston. Yet even Winston is undone partly by his own illusions — his trust in O'Brien and in the "proles" — so the statement retains force.
Conclusion. Both writers dramatise self-defeat: Walter nearly destroys his family, January destroys his own dignity. The difference is in the endings — Hansberry grants her character victory over himself, while Chaucer leaves January comically enslaved to his delusion. The statement is therefore substantially justified, with the nuance that external oppression sharpens, but does not replace, the enemy within.

16.7 Skill 7 — Comparing Setting Across Genres

METHOD **Writing About Setting**

1. Locate the setting in place and time (Chicago Southside, 1950s; Oceania, 1984; Pavia

and the pilgrimage road, medieval England; Kangan, post-independence Africa; the Nigerian forest).

2. Describe its function: realistic background, symbolic space, or instrument of theme.
3. Analyse techniques: stage directions (the "weariness" of the Youngers' sitting room), descriptive prose, poetic imagery (the enclosed garden, the forest).
4. Link setting to character: setting shapes and mirrors the people who inhabit it.
5. Compare if asked: e.g. the closed garden and the closed apartment as images of confinement.

WORKED EXAMPLE 22 **Worked Example 7 — Setting as Symbol**

Statement: "In the works you have studied, setting is never mere decoration: it expresses the condition of the characters." Examine this view with reference to The Merchant's Tale and A Raisin in the Sun.

SOLUTION

Detailed solution.
Introduction. Setting in literature is both where action happens and what action means. Both Chaucer and Hansberry make place symbolic.
Paragraph 1 — The enclosed garden. January's walled garden, which only his key can open, is his fantasy of possession: a private paradise where May will belong to him alone. It echoes the Garden of Eden — and like Eden it contains a tree of transgression. The setting thus exposes January's moral blindness: walls cannot imprison desire.
Paragraph 2 — The pear tree. Within the garden, the pear tree is the precise site of the climax: May climbs it to meet Damyan while the blind January holds its trunk. A place of fertility becomes a place of farce and betrayal — the setting enacts the tale's fabliau irony.
Paragraph 3 — The Youngers' apartment. Hansberry's opening stage directions describe a living room whose furniture is worn from too many years of service: the setting embodies exhaustion and deferred dreams. The single window is the family's only light — and Mama's plant, struggling toward that light, is the family itself.
Paragraph 4 — Clybourne Park. The new house, though in a hostile white neighbourhood, represents space, air and self-respect. The movement of the play is a movement of setting: from the cramped apartment to the house — from confinement to dignity.
Conclusion. In both works, setting is argument: Chaucer's garden exposes false possession, Hansberry's apartment and house chart the journey from oppression to pride. The statement is fully borne out.

17 EXERCISES

17.1 I check my knowledge

EXERCISE 15 **MCQ: Characters and their creators**

For each question, choose the single correct answer and write it down with a one-sentence justification.

1. In Act 3 of A Raisin in the Sun, Walter Lee's decisive moment involves:
   (a) accepting Lindner's offer and selling the house;
   (b) refusing Lindner's offer and moving to Clybourne Park;
   (c) giving the insurance money to Beneatha;
   (d) leaving the family to open a liquor store.
2. In Nineteen Eighty-Four, Part 3, the room that contains "the worst thing in the world" is:
   (a) Room 101;
   (b) Room 100;
   (c) the Golden Country;
   (d) the Chestnut Tree Café.
3. In Chaucer's The Merchant's Tale, the blind old husband of May is:
   (a) Damyan;
   (b) January;
   (c) Pluto;
   (d) Placebo.
4. In Anthills of the Savannah, Ikem Osodi's profession is:
   (a) army colonel;
   (b) editor of the National Gazette;
   (c) Commissioner for Information;
   (d) university professor.
5. In A Dance of the Forests, the lame old man who lures the living into the forest is:
   (a) Forest Head;

(b) Eshuoro;

(c) Aroni;

(d) Ogun.

EXERCISE 16 **True or False, with justification**

Say whether each statement is true or false, then justify your answer in one or two sentences with reference to the text.

1. Walter Lee accepts Lindner's money at the end of A Raisin in the Sun.
2. At the end of Nineteen Eighty-Four, Winston still secretly hates Big Brother.
3. In The Merchant's Tale, Pluto restores January's sight while Proserpina gives May her reply.
4. Chris Oriko dies in Abazon, killed during the public disorder there.
5. In A Dance of the Forests, the Dead Man and Dead Woman are welcomed as honoured guests of the tribes.
6. Beatrice in Anthills of the Savannah is presented as a passive victim of the military regime.

EXERCISE 17 **Key definitions**

Define each of the following terms in two or three sentences and give one precise illustration from any of the prescribed texts of this chapter.

1. **Characterisation** (distinguish direct from indirect characterisation).
2. **Fabliau**.
3. **Flashback** (as used in A Dance of the Forests).
4. **Open ending**.
5. **Dramatic irony** (illustrate with the pear-tree scene of The Merchant's Tale).

EXERCISE 18 **Who says it, and why does it matter?**

Identify the text, the speaker (or narrative voice) and the context of each of the following, then state in one sentence its importance for characterisation or theme.

1. “He loved Big Brother.”
2. Lindner’s proposal to buy back the Youngers’ new house.
3. May’s explanation to January of what she was doing in the pear tree.
4. Ikem’s declaration that the story, not the ruler, is the true power.
5. Forest Head’s judgement on the living and the dead.

17.2 I practise

EXERCISE 19 **Tracing a character’s arc: Walter Lee Younger**

In about one page, trace the development of Walter Lee from the beginning of A Raisin in the Sun to his final decision in Act 3. Structure your answer in three stages: his dreams and frustrations, his moral collapse after the loss of the money, and his recovery of dignity before Lindner. Support each stage with one well-chosen moment from the play and explain what Hansberry’s characterisation reveals about pride, manhood and the family.

EXERCISE 20 **Character file: January and May**

Construct a comparative character file for January and May in The Merchant’s Tale under the following headings: social position, physical description, motives in the marriage, behaviour in the garden episode, and the judgement the tale invites on each. Conclude with five lines assessing which of the two Chaucer presents more critically, and why.

EXERCISE 21 **How friends become enemies**

Write a structured account of the breakdown of the friendship between Sam, Chris and Ikem in Anthills of the Savannah. Identify at least four successive stages (schoolboy friendship, the coup and the cabinet, the Abazon crisis and the editorial conflict, betrayal and death), and for each stage name the precise cause of the deterioration. End by stating what Achebe suggests about power and friendship.

EXERCISE 22 **Dramatic functions of the trial scene**

Analyse the four movements of the trial in A Dance of the Forests: the accusation by the

Dead Man and Dead Woman, the prosecution by Eshuoro, the defence by Ogun, and the judgement of Forest Head. For each movement, state: (a) who speaks and what they claim; (b) what the movement reveals about the human characters; (c) its dramatic effect on the audience. Present your answer in four short paragraphs, one per movement.

17.3 I prepare for the GCE

EXERCISE 23 **GCE essay: redemption in A Raisin in the Sun (20 marks)**

"Walter's final decision in Act 3 redeems his earlier failures." Discuss this view with close reference to A Raisin in the Sun. Your essay should present a clear thesis, weigh Walter's earlier errors (the liquor-store dream, the loss of the insurance money, his treatment of Mama and Ruth) against his final stand before Lindner, and reach a nuanced conclusion on Hansberry's presentation of pride and manhood. (Plan, introduction and conclusion expected; approximately 500–600 words.)

EXERCISE 24 **GCE context question: Nineteen Eighty-Four (20 marks)**

Read the following passage: "He loved Big Brother." Locate this passage in Nineteen Eighty-Four, situating it precisely within Part 3. Then comment on it, showing: (a) what has been done to Winston in the Ministry of Love and in Room 101 to produce this ending; (b) how the sentence completes Orwell's demonstration that totalitarian power seeks not merely obedience but the conquest of inner life; (c) the effect of the flat, closing tone on the reader. Conclude by assessing the passage as the logical end of Winston's characterisation.

EXERCISE 25 **GCE essay: blindness in The Merchant's Tale (20 marks)**

"In The Merchant's Tale, physical blindness is less serious than moral blindness." Examine this view with close reference to the tale. You should consider: January's wilful self-deception before his literal blinding; the behaviour of May and Damyan; the role of Pluto and Proserpina; and the irony of the restoration of sight. Your answer should show how Chaucer uses the two kinds of blindness to judge his characters.

EXERCISE 26 **GCE essay: A Dance of the Forests (20 marks)**

"A Dance of the Forests is a warning, not a celebration." Discuss with reference to the

gathering of the tribes, the flashbacks to Mata Kharibu's empire, and the fate of the Half-Child. Your essay should explain why Soyinka refuses a simple festival of independence, how the past is shown to live inside the present, and what the open ending asks of the audience.

EXERCISE 27 **GCE essay: the press in Anthills of the Savannah (20 marks)**

"The press is the true hero of Anthills of the Savannah." Assess the validity of this statement. Consider Ikem's editorials and his Abazon speech, the censorship and violence directed at the National Gazette, and the limits of words against guns as shown by Ikem's death. Weigh the claim against the roles of Chris, Beatrice and the women of the naming ceremony before reaching your conclusion.

EXERCISE 28 **Comparative essay: May and Beatrice (20 marks)**

Compare Chaucer's presentation of May in The Merchant's Tale with Achebe's presentation of Beatrice in Anthills of the Savannah as women who see more clearly than the men around them. Consider: the situations of male blindness or error each woman confronts; the means each uses (cunning and speech for May, intelligence, memory and moral clarity for Beatrice); and the judgement each author finally invites on his heroine. Organise your answer thematically rather than text by text.

EXERCISE 29 **Context question: Ikem's Abazon speech (20 marks)**

Locate Ikem's address to the Abazon delegation in Anthills of the Savannah and comment on it. Show: (a) the circumstances that bring the delegation to him; (b) the rhetorical power of the speech (its imagery, its movement from grievance to universal principle, its praise of the story over the ruler); (c) its consequences for Ikem within the novel. Conclude by explaining why Achebe places this speech at the structural centre of the book.

EXERCISE 30 **Prose appreciation: the naming ceremony (20 marks)**

Write a guided commentary on the naming-ceremony passage (Chapters 17–18) of Anthills of the Savannah. Your commentary should: situate the passage after the deaths of Ikem and Chris; analyse how Achebe presents the women as survivors and carriers of continuity; examine the significance of the child's name and of Beatrice's role; and show how the ceremony answers the violence of the preceding chapters. Pay attention to narrative voice, tone and symbolism.

EXERCISE 31 **Timed Paper 2 practice (40 marks)**

In examination conditions (two hours, no notes), answer: (a) one context question chosen from the exercises above; (b) one essay question chosen from a different prescribed text. Then self-mark your script using the PEEL checklist (Point, Evidence, Explanation, Link to the question): check that every paragraph opens with a clear point, supports it with a precise reference, explains its significance, and links back to the exact wording of the question. Note two strengths and two targets for improvement.

EXERCISE 32 **Revision: character files across the set texts**

Build complete character files for five characters drawn from at least three different prescribed texts of this chapter (for example: Walter Lee, Winston Smith, January or May, Ikem or Beatrice, Demoke or Forest Head). Each file must contain: role in the work; three dominant traits with one piece of evidence each; key relationships; one key quotation (short and accurate) or precise paraphrased moment; and the character's dramatic or narrative function. Finish with a one-page synthesis answering: what do these five portraits together teach about the chapter's focus on true-to-life human representation?

WARNING **Common traps in this chapter's questions**

- Do not write that Chris Oriko dies in Abazon: he visits Abazon, but is killed later while on the run, during the disorder after the regime's collapse.
- Do not confuse Aroni (the lame messenger who leads the living into the forest) with Forest Head (the judge of the trial).
- In The Merchant's Tale, keep the divine pair straight: Pluto restores January's sight; Proserpina supplies May's excuse.
- "He loved Big Brother" is narrated, not spoken by Winston; quoting it as dialogue is a factual error examiners penalise.
- In essays on A Raisin in the Sun, always name Lindner's association and Clybourne Park precisely; vague references to "the white man" weaken the evidence mark.

18 SOLUTIONS TO THE EXERCISES

SOLUTION **Exercise 1 — MCQ: Characters and their creators**

1. (b) In Act 3, before Lindner and his son Travis, Walter refuses the buy-out and confirms the move to Clybourne Park, declaring that his father earned the house "brick by brick"; this is the climax of his moral recovery.
2. (a) Room 101 contains "the worst thing in the world" for each prisoner — for Winston, the cage of rats — and its purpose is to break the last private loyalty, which it does when he betrays Julia.
3. (b) January is the aged, lecherous knight of Pavia who marries young May; when he is struck blind his jealousy becomes pathological, which sets up the pear-tree deception.
4. (b) Ikem Osodi is the poet and crusading editor of the state-controlled National Gazette; his editorials and his Abazon speech make him the regime's most dangerous critic.
5. (c) Aroni, "the lame one", is Forest Head's messenger who lures Demoke, Rola and Adenebi into the forest for the gathering of the tribes.

SOLUTION **Exercise 2 — True or False, with justification**

1. False. Walter enters Act 3 intending to accept Lindner's money, but in front of Lindner and Travis he refuses it and confirms the family's move; the scene dramatises the recovery, not the loss, of his dignity.
2. False. The final sentence, "He loved Big Brother", shows that the Party has conquered Winston's inner life itself; after Room 101 he no longer even secretly rebels.
3. True. Pluto, angered by January's conduct, restores his sight at the very moment May is with Damyan in the pear tree, while Proserpina, championing women, gives May the instant excuse that her "struggle" in the tree was the prescribed cure for his blindness.
4. False. Chris visits Abazon earlier and is humbled by the people's drought and loyalty; he is killed later, while on the run after the regime's fall, shot by a drunken security man amid the chaotic celebrations.
5. False. The living tribes demand glorious, heroic ancestors and react with hostility when Forest Head sends instead the Dead Man and Dead Woman — ordinary, wronged dead who come to accuse the living.

6. False. Beatrice is politically lucid, intellectually independent and spiritually authoritative: she confronts Chris's blindness, shelters the fugitives, and presides over the naming ceremony that closes the novel.

SOLUTION **Exercise 3 — Key definitions**

1. Characterisation is the set of techniques by which a writer constructs a character. In direct characterisation, the narrator or another character tells us what a person is like; in indirect characterisation, we infer personality from speech, action, gesture, appearance and the reactions of others. Illustration: Hansberry characterises Walter Lee indirectly — his restless pacing, his obsession with the liquor store, his collapse after Willy's theft — so that we judge his frustration and pride for ourselves.
2. Fabliau is a short comic verse tale of medieval French origin turning on trickery, sexual intrigue and the duping of a foolish (usually old or jealous) husband, often with an anti-clerical or anti-patriarchal satirical edge. The Merchant's Tale follows the pattern exactly: old January is cuckolded by May and Damyan and is duped a second time even after his sight is restored.
3. Flashback is a movement backwards in time that interrupts the present action to reveal earlier events. In A Dance of the Forests the play flashes back some four hundred years to the court of Mata Kharibu, where the same characters appear in past incarnations, proving that present corruption repeats an ancient pattern.
4. Open ending is a conclusion that withholds full resolution and leaves interpretation to the audience. Soyinka ends with the fate of the Half-Child unresolved: Demoke's partial recovery of it offers hope but no guarantee, so the warning is handed over to the audience's own future.
5. Dramatic irony occurs when the audience knows more than a character, so that the character's words or confidence become double-edged. In the pear-tree scene the audience knows May and Damyan are lovers above the blind January; when his sight returns, May's instant "explanation" fools him again, and our superior knowledge makes his credulity both comic and damning.

SOLUTION **Exercise 4 — Who says it, and why does it matter?**

1. Orwell's impersonal narrative voice closes Nineteen Eighty-Four as Winston sits in the Chestnut Tree Café after his release. Importance: it proves the Party's victory is total — not mere obedience but the conquest of love and thought themselves, the logical end of Winston's characterisation.

2. In A Raisin in the Sun, Lindner of the Clybourne Park Improvement Association offers (Act 2, repeated in Act 3) to buy back the Youngers' house to keep a Black family out. Importance: the proposal crystallises the play's central conflict between money and dignity and sets up Walter's final test of manhood.
3. At the climax of The Merchant's Tale, May tells the newly-sighted January that she "struggled with a man upon a tree" only to cure his blindness. Importance: the instant lie, supplied by Proserpina, displays May's cunning and completes the fabliau's triumph of wit over jealous age.
4. In his address to the Abazon delegation in Anthills of the Savannah, Ikem argues that the story outlives and outranks the ruler. Importance: the claim defines his vocation as editor and poet and explains why the regime must silence him.
5. In the trial scene of A Dance of the Forests, Forest Head weighs the accusations of the Dead Man and Dead Woman against the living. Importance: his judgement exposes the guilt behind the tribes' "glorious" past and turns the independence celebration into a summons to self-knowledge.

SOLUTION **Exercise 5 — Tracing a character's arc: Walter Lee Younger**

Stage 1: dreams and frustrations. At the opening, Walter is a chauffeur in his thirties, cramped in the South Side apartment, humiliated by serving white employers and by asking his wife Ruth for money his son needs. His dream of the liquor store is not mere greed: it is his claim to manhood, to providing, to being "somebody". Key moment: his bitter complaint that Mama's generation does not understand a man's need to take risks. Hansberry characterises him indirectly through restless movement and wounded talk, so we see pride deformed by exclusion.
Stage 2: moral collapse. Entrusted with the insurance money — including Beneatha's schooling share — Walter hands it to Willy Harris, who steals it. Key moment: his grotesque "Mister Charlie" performance, rehearsing the shuffling, grinning submission he plans to offer Lindner. This is his nadir: despair turns dignity into self-caricature, and the family (especially Beneatha) nearly disowns him. Characterisation here is ruthlessly honest: Hansberry lets her hero be wrong.
Stage 3: recovery of dignity. Before Lindner, with Travis watching, Walter reverses himself: the family will move, because his father earned the house "brick by brick". Key moment: his speech naming the family's five generations of labour. Mama's verdict — that he has "come into his manhood" — defines Hansberry's thesis: manhood is not money but moral standing, and pride is recovered not by winning but by refusing to sell the family's self-respect.
Conclusion. The arc moves from frustrated dreamer, through betrayer of trust, to flawed but genuine head of the family. Hansberry's true-to-life method — no saint, no villain, but a man shaped by economic pressure — makes the redemption credible and moving.

SOLUTION **Exercise 6 — Character file: January and May**

Heading	January	May
Social position	Aged, wealthy knight of Pavia; high rank, long experience, authority over household.	Young woman of "small degree" (modest birth); gains status only through the marriage.
Physical description	Old, white-bearded, later struck blind; his age is stressed comically on the wedding night.	Young, fresh and beautiful — her beauty is what inflames both January and Damyan.
Motives in the marriage	Lust dressed up as piety: he wants a young wife for pleasure and an heir, and convinces himself it is holy.	Security and advancement; she accepts the marriage but not fidelity, and soon prefers Damyan.
Behaviour in the garden episode	Pathologically jealous, he clings to May physically; blind, he is led to the pear tree and duped.	She signals Damyan, climbs the tree to him, and on being caught invents the "cure" excuse instantly.
Judgement invited	Ridicule and censure: a lecherous fool whose self-deception precedes his blindness.	Amused admiration tempered by censure: clever and energetic, but deceitful and adulterous.

Conclusion (five lines). Chaucer presents January more critically. May's deceit is reactive — the resource of a young woman traded into a loveless marriage to an old man who bought her as property. January's folly is self-authored: he deceives himself long before anyone deceives him, lust masquerading as devotion. The tale's comic justice therefore falls on him: restored sight only reveals what his moral blindness had already guaranteed. May survives by wit; January is condemned by his own desires.

SOLUTION **Exercise 7 — How friends become enemies**

Stage 1: schoolboy friendship. Sam, Chris and Ikem are bound from their schooldays at Lord Lugard College, where Sam was the admired, sociable athlete and the others the in-

tellectuals. The bond is real but unequal: friendship rests on youthful roles, not on tested principle.
Stage 2: the coup and the cabinet. When the military coup makes Sam Head of State, he appoints Chris (Information) and co-opts Ikem's Gazette. Friendship is now crossed by hierarchy: Sam expects loyalty as obedience, while his friends still address him as an equal. The first cause of deterioration is power itself — Sam begins to suspect criticism as disloyalty.
Stage 3: the Abazon crisis and the editorial conflict. The drought-stricken province of Abazon, denied water and punished for opposing Sam's life-presidency referendum, sends a delegation; Ikem's sympathetic editorials and Chris's hesitation to muzzle him enrage Sam. The precise cause here is policy: Sam reads solidarity with Abazon as treason, and demands that Chris control Ikem — forcing each friend to choose between the man and the truth.
Stage 4: betrayal and death. Sam's security apparatus moves against Ikem: his editorials are suppressed, he is dismissed, abducted after the Abazon speech, and murdered, with a false official story. Chris, refusing to endorse the lie, is himself declared a traitor and flees; he dies shot by a drunken policeman amid the chaos of the regime's collapse. The final cause is fear institutionalised as violence: the friendship is destroyed not by quarrel but by the machinery of dictatorship.
Achebe's point. Friendship cannot survive unchecked power, because power redefines loyalty as silence. Yet the novel also suggests the reverse: the moral courage friendship once nourished (Ikem's voice, Chris's refusal, Beatrice's clarity) outlives the tyrant. Power kills the friends; it cannot kill what they stood for.

SOLUTION **Exercise 8 — Dramatic functions of the trial scene**

Movement 1: the accusation. (a) The Dead Man and Dead Woman — the ordinary, wronged dead sent back by Forest Head instead of glorious ancestors — accuse the living of the crimes that destroyed them. (b) Their testimony reveals that the human guests (Demoke, Rola, Adenebi) and the tribes they represent carry unacknowledged guilt: the celebrated past was built on victims. (c) For the audience, the festive expectation of the gathering is shattered; celebration turns into judgement, establishing the play's tone of warning.
Movement 2: the prosecution. (a) Eshuoro, the vengeful forest deity, prosecutes, pressing the case against the humans and demanding their punishment. (b) His zeal reveals that the gods themselves are not impartial — Eshuoro has personal grievances (against Ogun and Demoke), so "divine justice" is entangled with divine ego. (c) Dramatically, the prosecution raises the stakes and the tension: the humans' survival is genuinely in doubt, and the audience learns to distrust easy verdicts from any quarter.
Movement 3: the defence. (a) Ogun, patron of Demoke and god of iron and creation, speaks for the defence, pleading the humans' capacity for remorse and partial redemption. (b) The defence reveals the human characters' mitigating side: Demoke's guilt (the

death of his apprentice) is confessed and felt, unlike the tribes' collective denial. (c) For the audience, hope re-enters the play — but a fragile, conditional hope, dependent on honest self-knowledge rather than acquittal.
Movement 4: the judgement. (a) Forest Head, the ancient judge, weighs accusation, prosecution and defence; his verdict neither damns nor absolves absolutely, but returns the living to the world with the burden of knowledge, and the Half-Child's fate left hanging. (b) The judgement reveals that the deepest guilt belongs to the living community's refusal to remember, and the deepest hope to individuals who accept responsibility. (c) Dramatically, the refusal of a neat verdict prepares the open ending: the audience is denied comfortable closure and is itself put on trial.

SOLUTION **Exercise 9 — GCE essay: redemption in A Raisin in the Sun (20 marks)**

Indicative mark scheme: thesis and plan (3); knowledge of Act 3 and earlier acts (5); quality of argument, weighing errors against the final stand (6); use of precise evidence (4); expression and organisation (2).
Model plan and approach. Thesis: Walter's refusal of Lindner's money genuinely redeems him — not by erasing his failures, but by reversing the value system that caused them.
Paragraph 1 — the failures. The liquor-store obsession leads him to despise Ruth's pregnancy news, to dismiss Mama's values, and finally to entrust the insurance money — including Beneatha's share — to Willy Harris, who steals it. His lowest point is the rehearsed "Mister Charlie" act: dignity traded for cash.
Paragraph 2 — the turning point. In Act 3, before Lindner and Travis, Walter names the family's generations of labour and refuses the buy-out: his father earned the house "brick by brick". The evidence of redemption is that the decision costs him exactly what his failure pursued — money — and is made in his son's sight.
Paragraph 3 — nuance. The redemption is partial and realistic: the family still faces Clybourne Park's hostility and poverty; Mama's plant and the moving boxes signal hope, not triumph. Hansberry redeems Walter as a man, not as a financier: manhood is redefined as moral standing.
Conclusion. The statement is valid if "redeem" means recovering the self-respect his failures had sold; the play's realism lies in showing that one right choice can restore a man without solving his problems.
Examiner expectations: precise naming (Lindner, the Clybourne Park Improvement Association, Willy Harris, Travis); balanced judgement; conclusion that engages the word "redeems".

SOLUTION **Exercise 10 — GCE context question: Nineteen Eighty-Four (20 marks)**

Indicative mark scheme: location (3); commentary on process (a) (5); commentary on theme (b) (6); tone and effect (c) (4); conclusion on characterisation (2).

Location. The sentence is the novel's closing line, at the end of Part 3: Winston, released from the Ministry of Love, sits in the Chestnut Tree Café, drinking gin, awaiting the bullet he knows will come, as a telescreen announces victory.
(a) What has been done to him. O'Brien has subjected him to months of interrogation, starvation and torture; taught him that reality is whatever the Party says (2 + 2 = 5); and finally, in Room 101, confronted him with the cage of rats, at which point he screamed for it to be done to Julia — betraying the one person he loved. That betrayal, not the pain, is the decisive wound: afterwards he and Julia meet and feel nothing.
(b) The conquest of inner life. Earlier, the Party could command behaviour; the point of the Ministry of Love is that obedience is not enough. O'Brien's aim is conversion, not submission: the heretic must not merely confess but believe. The final sentence records the completion of that project — the last private space, love, has been occupied. This is Orwell's deepest warning about totalitarianism: it seeks the soul.
(c) The flat tone. The sentence is short, declarative, without protest or irony in the narration; its very flatness is the horror. The reader, who has shared Winston's inner rebellion for the whole novel, is shut out: there is no interiority left to narrate. The effect is desolation — more chilling than any execution scene.
Conclusion. It is the logical end of Winston's characterisation: the man defined by his secret diary, his love and his memory is extinguished from within; what remains loves Big Brother. Characterisation and theme converge in four words.

SOLUTION **Exercise 11 — GCE essay: blindness in The Merchant's Tale (20 marks)**

Indicative mark scheme: thesis (3); treatment of January's self-deception (5); May and Damyan (4); Pluto and Proserpina and the irony of restored sight (5); expression (3).
Model approach. Thesis: The tale's literal blindness is a comic device; its moral blindness — wilful, self-serving, and incurable — is the real subject of Chaucer's judgement.
January's self-deception. Long before he loses his sight, January is blind: he flatters himself that an old man's lust for a young bride is holy wedlock, hears only the counsel he wants (Placebo's flattery over Justinus's warning), and constructs an enclosed garden as a fantasy of possession. His physical blinding merely makes visible what was already true.
May and Damyan. They see physically but are morally short-sighted: lust and deceit, the key to the garden, the signal at the tree. Yet the tale treats their blindness as the lesser fault — the predictable answer to an unnatural marriage.
The gods and the restoration. Pluto restores January's sight in outrage at May's betrayal; Proserpina arms May with her excuse. The irony is perfect: sight returns only to be defeated by words. January, given the evidence of his eyes, chooses again to believe what flatters him — proving his blindness was never in his eyes.
Conclusion. Chaucer judges by the two blindnesses: May's cunning earns comic admiration; January's self-deception, surviving even restored sight, earns the tale's deepest satire. Physical blindness is an event; moral blindness is a character — and only the second is damning.

SOLUTION **Exercise 12 — GCE essay: A Dance of the Forests (20 marks)**

Indicative mark scheme: thesis (3); the gathering (4); the flashbacks (5); the Half-Child and open ending (5); expression (3).
Model approach. Thesis: Written for Nigeria's independence celebrations, the play deliberately refuses festivity: it is a warning that a nation which will not face its past cannot be reborn.
The gathering of the tribes. The living ask Forest Head for glorious ancestors to grace the celebration; he sends instead the Dead Man and Dead Woman — victims, not heroes. The tribes' hostility to them dramatises the nation's refusal of its true history: the "guests of honour" are the crimes themselves.
The flashbacks. Four hundred years back, at Mata Kharibu's court, the same souls replay the same evils: the warrior who will not fight an unjust war is enslaved, the queen (Rola's past self) is complicit, power corrupts as it always has. The structural point is that the past is not past: present corruption is repetition, not accident. Independence changes the flag, not the soul.
The Half-Child and the open ending. The Half-Child — the unborn future, drawn prematurely into the world — is fought over by Eshuoro and the forces of destruction; Demoke, the carver guilty of his apprentice's death, partially redeems himself by rescuing it, but its survival is not secured. The ending withholds assurance: the future is in human hands, and the play exits into the audience's responsibility.
Conclusion. Soyinka warns because celebration without memory is self-deception. The play honours independence precisely by refusing to flatter it.

SOLUTION **Exercise 13 — GCE essay: the press in Anthills of the Savannah (20 marks)**

Indicative mark scheme: thesis (3); Ikem's editorials and Abazon speech (5); censorship and violence (4); limits of words, and the counter-claims of Chris, Beatrice and the women (5); expression (3).
Model approach. Thesis: The press, embodied in Ikem, is the novel's clearest hero of truth — but Achebe deliberately shows both its nobility and its insufficiency.
For the claim. Ikem's editorials in the National Gazette are the only public voice naming the regime's failures; his Abazon speech elevates journalism into prophecy — the story outlives the ruler. He alone speaks for the drought-stricken province when the cabinet will not. In a state where the cabinet is silent, the editor is the conscience of the nation.
Against the claim — the limits of words. The regime answers editorials with censorship, dismissal, abduction and murder, then lies about the killing. Words cannot stop guns; Ikem dies, and his paper is silenced. A "hero" who is destroyed mid-novel cannot, alone, carry the book's hope.
The counter-claims. Chris acts: he refuses to endorse the official lie and dies sheltering others. Beatrice and the women survive, remember, and renew: the naming ceremony, presided over by a woman, gives the future a name. Achebe distributes heroism — the word (Ikem), the deed (Chris), continuity (Beatrice and the women).

Conclusion. The statement is half-true. The press is the hero of truth-telling, but the novel's heroism is finally communal: the story Ikem praised is carried on not by the Gazette but by the people, especially its women.

SOLUTION **Exercise 14 — Comparative essay: May and Beatrice (20 marks)**

Indicative mark scheme: comparative organisation by theme, not text by text (4); treatment of each thematic axis (4 each, total 12); balance and evidence (2); expression (2).
Model approach (thematic plan). Thesis: Both women see further than the powerful men around them, but Chaucer grants May only the clarity of self-interest while Achebe grants Beatrice the clarity of moral vision — and the two judgements differ accordingly.
Theme 1 — the male blindness each confronts. May faces January's self-deceiving lust and pathological jealousy; Beatrice faces Chris's political naivety and Sam's tyranny — men who cannot read their own situation. In both cases male error creates the space in which the woman must act.
Theme 2 — the means each uses. May's instruments are cunning and speech: the stolen key, the signal to Damyan, the instant "cure" lie that defeats even restored sight. Beatrice's instruments are intelligence, memory and moral authority: she reads the regime correctly, names Chris's failures to his face, connects present politics to older female spiritual power, and finally gathers the community.
Theme 3 — the ends served. May's clear sight serves herself — pleasure and survival within a marriage that was a transaction. Beatrice's serves others — the fugitives she shelters, the truth she keeps, the child she names.
Theme 4 — the judgement invited. Chaucer's judgement is comic and ambivalent: May is censured as deceitful yet admired for wit, and the fabliau form lets her win. Achebe's is grave and affirmative: Beatrice is the novel's moral centre, and the closing ceremony entrusts the future to her.
Conclusion. Both portraits honour female perception over male power; but where Chaucer laughs at a world women outwit, Achebe hopes in a world women may heal.

SOLUTION **Exercise 15 — Context question: Ikem's Abazon speech (20 marks)**

Indicative mark scheme: location and circumstances (4); rhetorical analysis (8); consequences (4); structural conclusion (4).
(a) Circumstances. The drought-stricken province of Abazon, punished for voting against the life-presidency and denied water, sends a delegation to the capital; ignored by the cabinet, they come at night to Ikem, the editor who has written sympathetically about them. The speech is his impromptu address to these humble, patient visitors.
(b) Rhetorical power. The speech moves from the particular grievance — Abazon's thirst and neglect — to a universal principle: the meaning of power and the primacy of the story. Its imagery draws on the people themselves (the drought, the land, the stubborn hope of

the powerless); its tone shifts from fellow-feeling to prophetic declaration; its climax inverts the political hierarchy: rulers pass, but the story — the people's account of themselves — survives and judges them. The rhetoric matters because it is addressed not to the powerful but to the powerless, and it dignifies them as the true authors of history.
(c) Consequences. The speech is reported, distorted and read by the regime as sedition; it precipitates Ikem's dismissal, abduction and murder, and the official lie about his death. His own thesis is thus enacted: the ruler kills the storyteller, and the story outlives him.
Conclusion. Achebe places the speech at the structural centre because it is the novel's thesis in miniature: everything before it builds the pressure, everything after it (Chris's flight, the fall of the regime, the naming ceremony) tests whether the story really does outlive the ruler — and the ending answers yes.

SOLUTION **Exercise 16 — Prose appreciation: the naming ceremony (20 marks)**

Indicative mark scheme: situation (3); women as survivors (5); the name and Beatrice's role (5); voice, tone, symbolism (4); conclusion on the ceremony as answer to violence (3).
Situation. The passage closes the novel, after the deaths of Ikem and Chris and the collapse of the regime. Elewa, Ikem's lover, has borne his child; the community gathers in Beatrice's flat to name the baby — a ceremony normally male-led, here presided over by a woman.
The women as survivors and carriers of continuity. Achebe gathers Elewa, Beatrice and the older women around the child: the men of words and action are dead, but the women remain — mourning, organising, naming. Continuity is re-gendered: the future is carried not by the state, the army or the press, but by the maternal and communal network that tyranny could not reach.
The name and Beatrice's role. The child — a girl — is given a name that answers the novel's grief with hope, and Beatrice, who has grown from Chris's perceptive partner into the community's moral and spiritual centre, performs the naming. Her role fuses the modern educated woman with the older female power the novel has invoked throughout: she is priestess of continuity.
Voice, tone, symbolism. The narrative voice is quiet, intimate, ceremonial — a deliberate deceleration after the violence and flight of the preceding chapters. The tone is elegiac but not despairing. Symbolically, the newborn girl counters the novel's deaths; the female-led ritual counters the male cult of power; the gathering in a private home counters the corrupted public space of the state.
Conclusion. The ceremony answers violence with generation, silence with naming, and the ruler's story with the people's story — enacting Ikem's thesis that the story outlives the ruler, now entrusted to women's hands.

SOLUTION **Exercise 17 — Timed Paper 2 practice (40 marks)**

This is a self-administered examination task; the correction is methodological. Apply the following mark scheme and checklist to your own script.
Mark allocation. Context question (20): location and circumstances 4; close commentary on language, tone and device 8; links to theme and characterisation 5; conclusion 3. Essay question (20): thesis and plan 3; argument and structure 6; precise textual evidence 5; engagement with the exact wording of the question 4; expression 2.
PEEL self-check — for every paragraph ask:

1. Point: does the paragraph open with one clear, arguable point that answers part of the question?
2. Evidence: is there a precise reference — a named scene, act, chapter or short accurate quotation (not a vague "the white man" or "the editor said something")?
3. Explanation: do you explain how the evidence proves the point (device, tone, irony, characterisation), rather than retelling the plot?
4. Link: does the final sentence return to the exact words of the question ("redeems", "warning, not celebration", "true hero")?

Typical targets. The two most common weaknesses examiners report are: narrative retelling instead of analysis (fix by forcing every paragraph through the Explanation step), and evidence without names (fix by memorising precise references: Room 101, Clybourne Park, the pear tree, the National Gazette, Mata Kharibu). Record your two strengths and two targets in writing before your next timed attempt.

SOLUTION **Exercise 18 — Revision: character files across the set texts**

Model files (one per text; any five are acceptable).
Walter Lee Younger (A Raisin in the Sun). Role: protagonist, chauffeur, son and father. Traits: ambitious (the liquor-store dream as a claim to manhood); proud and easily wounded (his fury at Ruth's restraint and Mama's control); capable of moral growth (the refusal of Lindner before Travis). Key relationships: Mama (authority he must inherit), Ruth (strained, then renewed marriage), Beneatha (rivalry over the money), Travis (the gaze that saves him). Key moment: "my father earned it brick by brick". Function: his arc carries the play's redefinition of pride and manhood.
Winston Smith (Nineteen Eighty-Four). Role: protagonist, Outer Party functionary. Traits: rebellious in secret (the diary); hungry for truth and memory (the paperweight, the proles); ultimately breakable (Room 101). Relationships: Julia (love as rebellion), O'Brien (seducer-destroyer). Key moment: the closing narration, "He loved Big Brother". Function: his destruction demonstrates that totalitarianism seeks the inner life.
January (The Merchant's Tale). Role: the duped old husband of the fabliau. Traits: lecherous (marriage as licensed lust); self-deceiving (hears Placebo, ignores Justinus); jeal-

ously possessive (the enclosed garden, clinging to May). Relationships: May (wife-possession), Damyan (rival), the gods (his sight restored by Pluto). Key moment: believing May's "cure" lie after regaining sight. Function: embodiment of moral blindness, the tale's satiric target.

Ikem Osodi (Anthills of the Savannah). Role: editor of the National Gazette, poet, conscience of the nation. Traits: courageous (editorials against the regime); principled (refuses silence over Abazon); prophetic (the story outlives the ruler). Relationships: Chris (friendship broken by power), Beatrice (intellectual kinship), Sam (friend turned executioner). Key moment: the Abazon speech. Function: his murder proves both the power and the fragility of the word.

Forest Head (A Dance of the Forests). Role: judge of the trial, master of the gathering. Traits: patient (he has watched centuries); just but not comforting (sends victims, not heroes); pedagogic (his verdict returns the living to self-knowledge). Relationships: Aroni (his messenger), the dead (his witnesses), Ogun and Eshuoro (the contending gods). Key moment: the judgement that neither damns nor absolves. Function: he converts celebration into trial and embodies the play's warning.

One-page synthesis. These five portraits show what "true-to-life human representation" means across the chapter's genres. None of the five is a type or a saint: Walter is redeemed but remains flawed; Winston is heroic but breakable; January is ridiculous but recognisably human; Ikem is noble but destroyed; Forest Head is wise but refuses comfort. Each writer builds character indirectly — through choices under pressure (Walter before Lindner, Winston before the rats, January at the tree, Ikem before the delegation), through relationships that test them, and through arcs that end in moral revelation rather than wish-fulfilment. Together they teach that literature's deepest subject is the human being at the moment of testing, and that the test is always the same: whether a person will see clearly — self, others, history — and act on what they see.

19 SUMMARY SHEET



Mind map of the chapter: four set texts studied through characters, characterisation and role play, crowned by examination technique.

FICHE BILAN **L'essentiel à connaître pour l'examen**

1. Key definitions to master

- **Character**: a personage in a literary work whose thoughts, words, actions and interactions drive the plot and embody the themes.
- **Characterisation**: the techniques by which an author builds a character — direct (the narrator or another character describes) and indirect (revealed through speech, action, reaction of others, setting, symbolism).
- **Rounded vs flat characters**: rounded characters develop and surprise (Walter Lee, Winston, Chris); flat characters embody one trait (Lindner, the Merchant's January in part).
- **Protagonist / antagonist**; **foil** (a character who highlights another by contrast, e.g. Beneatha vs George Murchison; Ikem vs Sam).
- **Role play / dramatic irony**: the audience knows more than a character (May and Damyan under the pear tree; Winston trusting O'Brien).
- **Fabliau**: a short comic verse tale of trickery, lust and comeuppance — the genre of the Merchant's Tale.

2. The four set texts — essentials

- A Raisin in the Sun (Hansberry), Act 3: Walter loses the insurance money, is tempted to accept Lindner's buy-out, then refuses it — "we have decided to move into our house". Resolution = dignity over money; Mama's plant, Beneatha's African identity, the Youngers' collective pride. Know themes (dreams deferred, race, family, money vs values), setting (Southside Chicago), and Hansberry's naturalistic dialogue.

- Nineteen Eighty-Four (Orwell), Part 3, ch. 5–6: Room 101 and the rats break Winston; he betrays Julia ("Do it to Julia!"); the final line confirms he loves Big Brother. General overview: Newspeak, doublethink, the Party's aim of power for its own sake, the destruction of private truth and love.
- The Merchant's Tale (Chaucer): old January marries young May; Damyan loves her; the enclosed garden, the pear tree, Pluto and Proserpina's quarrel; January's blindness (physical) mirrors his moral blindness; sight restored at the very moment of May's betrayal — she talks her way out. Analyse it as a fabliau and as bitter satire of marriage.
- Anthills of the Savannah (Achebe): Kangan under His Excellency Sam; the cabinet meeting, Ikem's editorials and the crusading press, Chris's dilemma and flight to Abazon, Beatrice's circle and female power, Ikem's murder, Chris's death, the naming ceremony — women as survivors and hope. Themes: power corrupts, truth vs censorship, the role of the intellectual, the story as the people's weapon.
- A Dance of the Forests (Soyinka): written for Nigerian independence (1960); the tribes gather, Aroni leads the living into the forest; flashbacks to Mata Kharibu's court show the past is as guilty as the present; the trial of the Dead Man and Dead Woman before Forest Head, with Eshuoro prosecuting and Ogun defending; the dances of welcome and unwelcome; the half-child snatched — an open, warning ending: the future must not repeat the past.

3. Methods

- Character analysis: identify trait → quote or paraphrase evidence → link to theme → note development across the text.
- Essay plan: introduction (text, author, issue), 3–4 thematic paragraphs (point, evidence, explanation), conclusion (judgement).
- For drama, always comment on stagecraft: dialogue, stage directions, symbolism of props (Mama's plant, the pear tree, the half-child).

4. Common mistakes to avoid

- Retelling the plot instead of analysing characterisation and theme.
- Confusing characters: Walter Lee vs Walter (the horse-courtier); Chris vs Ikem; Demoke vs the Dead Man.
- Ignoring the question's key word ("discuss", "examine", "to what extent").
- Quoting inaccurately — paraphrase when unsure.

5. GCE tips

- Answer the question set, not the one you prepared; spend 5 minutes planning.
- One developed argument with precise reference beats three vague ones.
- Always link character to theme and to the author's purpose (Hansberry's hope, Or-

well's warning, Chaucer's satire, Achebe's call for the people's story, Soyinka's rejection of nostalgic glorification of the African past).

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